

Bangladesh at a Glance

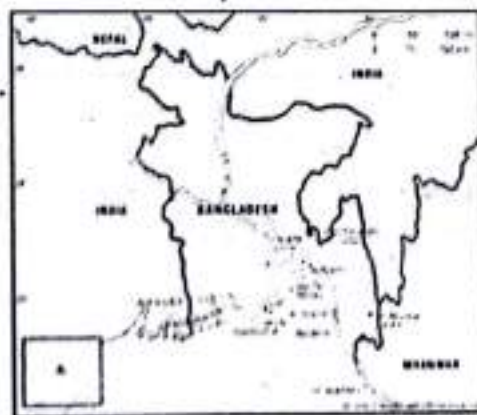
Bangladesh, country of South Asia, located in the delta of the Padma (Ganges [Ganga]) and Jamuna (Brahmaputra) rivers in the northeastern part of the Indian subcontinent.



Bangladesh

The riverine country of Bangladesh ("Land of the Bengals") is one of the most densely populated countries in the world, and its people are predominantly Muslim. As the eastern portion of the historical region of Bengal, the area once formed, along with what is now the Indian state of West Bengal, the province of Bengal in British India. With the partition of India in 1947, it became the Pakistani province of East Bengal (later renamed East Pakistan), one of five provinces of Pakistan, separated from the other four by 1,100 miles (1,800 km) of Indian territory. In 1971 it became the independent country of Bangladesh, with its capital at Dhaka.

land



Physical features of Bangladesh

Bangladesh is bordered by the Indian states of West Bengal to the west and north, Assam to the north, Meghalaya to the north and northeast, and Tripura and Mizoram to the east. To the

southeast, it shares a boundary with Myanmar (Burma). The southern part of Bangladesh opens into the Bay of Bengal.

Relief

Stretching northward from the Bay of Bengal, Bangladesh constitutes roughly the eastern two-thirds of the deltaic plain of the Padma (Ganges [Ganga]) and Jamuna (Brahmaputra) rivers. Except for small higher areas of jungle-covered old alluvium (rising to about 100 feet [30 metres]) in the northwest and north-centre—in the Barind and the Madhupur Tract, respectively—the plain is a flat surface of recent alluvium, having a gentle slope and an elevation of generally less than 30 feet (9 metres) above sea level. In the northeast and southeast—in the Sylhet and Chittagong Hills areas, respectively—the alluvial plains give place to ridges, running mainly north-south, that form part of the mountains that separate Bangladesh from Myanmar and India. In its southern region, Bangladesh is fringed by the Sundarbans, a huge expanse of marshy deltaic forest.

The Barind is a somewhat elevated triangular wedge of land that lies between the floodplains of the upper Padma and Jamuna rivers in northwestern Bangladesh. A depression called the Bhar Basin extends southeast from the Barind for about 100 miles (160 km) to the confluence of the Padma and Jamuna. This area is inundated during the summer monsoon season, in some places to a depth exceeding 10 feet (3 metres). The drainage of the western part of the basin is centred in the vast marshy area called the Chalan wetlands, also known as Chalan Lake. The floodplains of the Jamuna, which lie north of the Bhar Basin and east of the Barind, stretch from the border with Assam in the north to the confluence of the Padma and Jamuna in the south. The area is dominated by the Jamuna, which frequently overflows its banks in devastating floods. South of the Bhar Basin is the floodplain of the lower Padma.

In north-central Bangladesh, east of the Jamuna floodplains, is the Madhupur Tract. It consists of an elevated plateau on which hillocks ranging in height from 30 to 60 feet (9 to 18 metres) give contour to cultivated valleys. The Madhupur Tract contains *sal* trees, whose hardwood is comparable in value and utility to teak. East of the Madhupur Tract, in northeastern Bangladesh, is a region called the Northeastern Lowland. It encompasses the southern and southwestern parts of the Sylhet area (including the valley plain of the Surma River) and the northern part of the Mymensingh area and has a large number of lakes. The Sylhet Hills in the far northeast of the region consist of a number of hillocks and hills ranging in elevation from about 100 feet (30 metres) to more than 1,100 feet (330 metres).

The Barind is a somewhat elevated triangular wedge of land that lies between the floodplains of the upper Padma and Jamuna rivers in northwestern Bangladesh. A depression called the Bhar Basin extends southeast from the Barind for about 100 miles (160 km) to the confluence of the Padma and Jamuna. This area is inundated during the summer monsoon season, in some places to a depth exceeding 10 feet (3 metres). The drainage of the western part of the basin is centred in the vast marshy area called the Chalan wetlands, also known as Chalan Lake. The floodplains of the Jamuna, which lie north of the

Bhar Basin and east of the Barind, stretch from the border with Assam in the north to the confluence of the Padma and Jamuna in the south. The area is dominated by the Jamuna, which frequently overflows its banks in devastating floods. South of the Bhar Basin is the floodplain of the lower Padma.

In north-central Bangladesh, east of the Jamuna floodplains, is the Madhupur Tract. It consists of an elevated plateau on which hillocks ranging in height from 30 to 60 feet (9 to 18 metres) give contour to cultivated valleys. The Madhupur Tract contains *sal* trees, whose hardwood is comparable in value and utility to teak. East of the Madhupur Tract, in northeastern Bangladesh, is a region called the Northeastern Lowland. It encompasses the southern and southwestern parts of the Sylhet area (including the valley plain of the Surma River) and the northern part of the Mymensingh area and has a large number of lakes. The Sylhet Hills in the far northeast of the region consist of a number of hillocks and hills ranging in elevation from about 100 feet (30 metres) to more than 1,100 feet (330 metres).

Drainage of Bangladesh

The most significant feature of the Bangladesh landscape is provided by the rivers, which have molded not only its physiography but also the way of life of the people. Rivers in Bangladesh, however, are subject to constant and sometimes rapid changes of course, which can affect the hydrology of a large region; consequently, no description of Bangladesh's topography retains its absolute accuracy for long. One spectacular example of such a change occurred in 1787, when the Tista River underwent exceptionally high flooding; its waters were suddenly diverted eastward, where they reinforced the Brahmaputra. The swollen Brahmaputra in turn began to cut into a minor stream, which by the early 1800s had become the river's main lower course, now known as the Jamuna. A much smaller river (the Old Brahmaputra) now flows through the Brahmaputra's former course.

Each year between June and October, the rivers overflow their banks and inundate the countryside, rising most heavily in September or October and receding quickly in November. The inundations are both a blessing and a curse. Without them, the fertile silt deposits would not be replenished, but severe floods regularly damage crops and ruin hamlets and sometimes take a heavy toll on human and animal populations.

The rivers may be divided into five systems: (1) The Padma (or Ganges) and its deltaic streams, (2) the Meghna and the Surma river system, (3) the Jamuna and its adjoining channels, (4) the North Bengal rivers, and (5) the rivers of the Chittagong Hill Tracts and the adjoining plains.

The greater Ganges is the pivot of the deltaic river system of the historical region of Bengal. The greater Ganges Delta covers some 23,000 square miles (60,000 square km), the bulk of it in southwestern Bangladesh. The Ganges in Bangladesh is known as the Padma, and it is divided into two segments, the upper Padma and the lower Padma. The river enters Bangladesh from the west and constitutes, for about 90 miles (145 km), the boundary between Bangladesh and West Bengal. As it flows farther into Bangladesh, the upper Padma forms numerous distributaries and spill channels and reaches its confluence with the Jamuna

west of Dhaka, after which their combined waters make up the lower Padma—which hydrological perspective, is the Padma proper. The lower Padma flows southeast to Meghna near Chandpur and enters the Bay of Bengal through the Meghna estuary and channels. Except where it is confined by high banks, the upper Padma's main changes course every two or three years. Its waters appear muddy owing to the volume carried by the river. Silt deposits build temporary islands that reduce navigability but are highly fertile that they have been for decades a source of feuds among peasants who occupy them.

The Meghna is formed by the union of the Sylhet-Surma and Kusiara rivers. The rivers are branches of the Barak River, which rises in the Nagar-Manipur watershed in India. The main branch of the Barak, the Surma, is joined near Azmiriganj in north Bangladesh by the Kalni and farther down by the Kusiara branch. The Dhaleswari, a tributary of the Jamuna River, joins the Meghna a few miles above the junction of the lower Padma and the Meghna. As it meanders south, the Meghna grows larger after receiving the waters of several rivers, including the Buriganga and the Sitalakhya.

The Jamuna and its adjoining channels cover a large area from north-central Bangladesh to the Meghna River in the southeast. A number of rivers enter the Jamuna, especially from the west, and, with their notoriously shifting channels, they not only prevent permanent settlement along the Jamuna's banks but also inhibit communication between the northern area of Bangladesh and the eastern part, where Dhaka is situated.

The Tista is the most important water carrier of northwestern Bangladesh. Rising in the Himalayas near Sikkim, India, it flows southward, turning south near Darjiling (Darjeeling) to enter Bangladesh, where it eventually meets the Jamuna. Shoals and quicksand that surround the junction of the two rivers render navigation on the Tista's lower reaches difficult.

Four main rivers constitute the river system of the Chittagong Hills and the adjoining plains—the Feni, the Karnaphuli, the Sangu, and the Matamuhari. Flowing generally north and southwest across the coastal plain, they empty into the Bay of Bengal. Of these rivers the longest is the Karnaphuli, which is dammed at Kaptai, about 30 miles (50 km) upstream from its mouth near the city of Chittagong.

None of the major rivers of Bangladesh originates within the country's territory. The headwaters of the Surma are in India; the upper Padma rises in Nepal and the Jamuna in China, but they too reach Bangladesh across Indian territory. Thus, Bangladesh lacks control over the flow of any of the streams that irrigate it. The construction of a barrage upstream at Farakka in West Bengal has led to the diversion of a considerable volume of water from the Ganges in India, and the flow to western Bangladesh is insufficient in the dry season, from November to April. The equitable distribution of the river's water has been since the 1970s a source of friction between India and Bangladesh.

Soils

There are three main categories of soils in Bangladesh: the old alluvial soils, the recent alluvial soils, and the hill soils, which have a base of sandstone and shale. The fertile recent alluvial soils, found mainly in flooded areas, are usually clays and loams, variously pale brown, sandy, chalky, and mica-laden. They are deficient in phosphoric acid, nitrogen, and humus but not in potash and lime. The old alluvial soils in the jungles of the Barind and Madhupur regions are dark iron-rich brown or reddish clays and loams. They are sticky during the rainy season and hard during the dry periods. The hill soils are generally permeable and can support dense forest growth.

Climate

Bangladesh has a typical monsoon climate characterized by rain-bearing winds, moderately warm temperatures, and high humidity. In general, maximum temperatures in the summer months, from April to September, are in the low to mid-90s F (mid-30s C). April is the warmest month in most parts. The range of high temperatures in the winter months, from November to March, is greater than in the summer months. January is the coolest month, with high temperatures averaging in the mid- to upper 70s F (mid-20s C).

The conditions of lowest atmospheric pressure occur in Bangladesh in June and July, the storm season. Winds are mostly from the north and northeast in winter, blowing gently in northern and central areas and somewhat more aggressively near the coast. During the period of the northwesterly (strong winds from the northwest) from March to May, however, wind speeds may rise to 40 miles (65 km) per hour.

Bangladesh receives heavy rainfall; except for some parts in the west, it generally exceeds 60 inches (1,500 mm) annually. Large areas of the south, southeast, north, and northeast typically receive from 80 to 100 inches (2,000 to 2,500 mm), and the northern and northwestern parts of the Sylhet area usually receive from 150 to 200 inches (3,800 to 5,000 mm). The maximum rainfall occurs during the monsoon period, from June to September or early October.

Storms of very high intensity often occur early in the summer (in April and May) and late in the monsoon season (September to October, and sometimes November). These disturbances may produce winds with speeds exceeding 100 miles (160 km) per hour, and they may generate waves in the Bay of Bengal that crest as high as 20 feet (6 metres) before crashing with tremendous force onto the coastal areas and the offshore islands, causing heavy losses of life and property. Since the early 18th century, when records were first kept, more than 1,000,000 people have been killed in such storms, some 815,000 of them in just three storms occurring in 1737, 1876, and 1970.

Plant and animal life

Bangladesh in general possesses a luxuriant vegetation, with villages appearing to be buried in groves of mango, jackfruit, bamboo, betel nut, coconut, and date palm. However, only a small portion of the country's land surface is covered with forests.

Bangladesh has four different areas of vegetation. The eastern zone, consisting of parts of the Sylhet and Chittagong areas, has many low hills covered with jungles of bamboo and rattan (a species of climbing palm). The most common plant is a large type of bamboo that forms the basis of the country's paper industry. The central zone, covering parts of the country to the north of Dhaka, contains many lakes and supports swampy vegetation; the southern part of this zone produces the Madhupur jungles. The area lying to the northwest of the Jamuna and to the southwest of the Padma forms a flat plain, the vegetation of which consists mostly of cultivated plants and orchards. Babul (*Acacia arabica*) is the most conspicuous tree. The southern zone along the Bay of Bengal contains the vast wetlands of the Sundarbans, with their distinctive mangrove vegetation. Several of the mangrove species are commercially valuable, including the *sundari* (*Sonneratia fomes* or *S. minor*), which the Sundarbans are named, and the *goran* (*Ceriops roxburghiana*). Also valuable are the *gewa* or *gengwa* (*Excoecaria agallocha*) trees, which yield a softwood used for making newsprint. Among the astounding variety of flowers are water lilies (locally called *shapla*, the country's national flower), marigolds, tuberoses, and Chinese hibiscus. The *bokul* (*Mimusops elengi*) is a common shrub that produces small red berries.

Bangladesh has an abundance of wildlife, including more than 100 species of mammals, although the population of some species has diminished significantly since the early 20th century. Elephants, living in herds of fewer than a dozen to nearly 100, are found in Chittagong Hill Tracts and in the northeastern Sylhet region. Domesticated water buffaloes (*Bubalis bubalis*) are used for plowing and pulling carts. Of the different kinds of deer, the small muntjac (genus *Muntiacus*; also called barking deer) and the large sambar deer (*Cervus unicolor*), with its maned neck, are well known. The sambar deer is found in the eastern jungles of the country. The medium-sized spotted deer (*C. axis*) was common in many parts of the country but by the early 21st century had become limited to the Sundarbans region. The barasingha (*C. duvauceli*) also once inhabited the Sundarbans but became extinct in Bangladesh in the 20th century. Similarly, the hog deer (*Axis procerus*) disappeared from the country.

Of the carnivores, the royal Bengal tiger (*Panthera tigris tigris*) is the best known. The common leopard (*P. pardus*) is native to the region, as is its smaller relative, the rare cloud leopard (*Neofelis nebulosa*), with its dark gray oblong-spotted fur. The ferocious leopard cat (*Felis bengalensis*) is about the size of the domestic cat but with longer legs.

Bears in Bangladesh include the sloth bear (*Melursus ursinus*), Asiatic black bear (*Ursus thibetanus*; also called Himalayan black bear), and sun bear (*U. malayanus*). The sloth bear is the most common. Jackals (*Canis aureus*), whose eerie howling at night is a familiar sound in Bangladesh, are abundant, as are various species of mongooses. The Bengal, or rhesus, monkey (*Macaca mulatta*) is about the most common primate in the country.

Bangladesh is inhabited by hundreds of species of birds. Common house crows are everywhere, and their cries are detested by many people of Bangladesh, who regard crows as a bad omen. Bulbuls, magpie-robins, and a wide variety of warblers are also found; some are migrants that appear only in winter. Several kinds of flycatchers occur, and

rynah birds of several kinds. Other species of birds include various game birds, jacks, cuckoos, hawks, owls, kingfishers, hornbills, hoopoes, woodpeckers, and vultures. Among the eagles, the crested serpent eagle and the ring-tailed fishing eagle are the most common. There also are an array of water birds, including herons, storks, ducks, and wild geese.

14

14 Ethnic groups

A vast majority of the population of Bangladesh is Bengali—a term describing both an ethnic and a linguistic group. The Bengali people are historically of diverse origin, having emerged from the confluence of various communities that entered the region over the course of many centuries. The Vedda peoples were perhaps the earliest group to settle in the area. According to some ethnologists, they were followed by peoples from the Mediterranean and neighbouring areas, particularly those who spoke Indo-European languages. During the 8th century CE, persons of Arab, Persian, and Turkish origin moved in large numbers to the continent. By the beginning of the 13th century, they had entered what is now Bangladesh. The contention that contemporary Bengali Muslims are all descended from pre-caste Hindus who had converted to Islam, then, is clearly incorrect; a substantial portion are descendants of Muslims who reached the subcontinent from elsewhere.

Non-Bengalis—consisting primarily of smaller indigenous groups—constitute only a tiny fraction of the population. Most of these peoples inhabit the Chittagong Hill Tracts in the northeast, the most sparsely settled area of the country. Some of the groups are related to the peoples of Myanmar (Burma), and many follow Buddhism, although both Hinduism and Christianity also have a significant following. Of the dozen or so ethnolinguistic groups in the Chittagong Hill Tracts, the largest are the Chakma, the Marma (Magh or Mogh), the Tripura (Tipra), and the Mro; the Khomoi (Kumi), the Kuki, and the Mizo (formerly called Lushai) are among the smaller groups. Since the mid-1970s ethnic tensions and periodic violence have marked the Chittagong Hill Tracts, where many peoples long resident in the area have objected to the influx of Muslim Bengali settlers.

Indigenous minority peoples in other parts of Bangladesh include the Santhal, the Khasi, the Garo, and the Hajang. The Santhal peoples live in the northwestern part of Bangladesh, the Khasi in Sylhet in the Khasi Hills near the border with Assam, India, and the Garo and Hajang in the northeastern part of the country.

Languages of Bangladesh

Bengali (Bangla), the national language of Bangladesh, belongs to the Indo-Aryan group of languages and is related to Sanskrit. Like Pali, however, and various other forms of Prakrit in ancient India, Bengali originated beyond the influence of the Brahman society of the Aryans. The Pala rulers of Bengal (8th to 12th century)—who were Buddhists and whose religious language was Pali—did not inhibit the emergence of a colloquial tongue known as Gaudiya Prakrit, the language from which Bengali developed.

Bengali is the mother tongue of almost the entire population of Bangladesh. However, the indigenous minority groups have their own languages and dialects, some of which are Tibeto-Burman languages. English, an Indo-European language, is spoken in urban centres and among educated groups.

The Bengali language has two distinct styles: *sadhu bhasa*, the literary style, which contains many words derived from Sanskrit, and *calit bhasa*, the colloquial style, which is the standard medium of informal discourse, both spoken and written. Until the 1930s *sadhu bhasa* was used for all printed matter, but *calit bhasa* is now the basic form used for contemporary literature. There also are a number of dialects. Bengali contains many loanwords from Portuguese, English, Arabic, Persian, and Hindi.

Religion

Most of the people of Bangladesh follow the religion of Islam, which was made the official religion by a 1988 constitutional amendment. The arrival of Muslims in Bengal at the beginning of the 13th century and the rapid increase in their strength and influence permanently changed the character and culture of the area. When the Muslims arrived, Hinduism was by far the dominant religion, although there were also a few Buddhists and a few adherents of local religions. The Hindus remained in the majority through the Mughal period (16th to 18th century). Even as late as the early 1870s, there were more than 18 million Hindus in Bengal, compared with about 16 million Muslims. From the 1890s onward, however, the weight began to shift toward the Muslims.

There were several reasons for the increase in the proportion of the Muslim population. Perhaps the most significant was the activity of ascetics and Sufis (practitioners of a mystical form of Islam), who won converts among lower-caste Hindus. Also significant was an influx of Muslims from northern India and from other countries.

Most Muslims are Sunni, but there are a small number of Shi'is, primarily descended from immigrants from Iran. Hindus form a significant minority, while Roman Catholic Christians constitute just a tiny fraction of the population. Of the tribes in the Chittagong Tracts, the Chakma, Marma, and Mro are mostly Buddhists. Portions of the Kuki, Jaintia, and Mro communities practice local religions. While most of the Mizo are Christians, the Tripura are Hindus.

Settlement patterns

The extremely high overall population density of Bangladesh, averaging more than 1,000 persons per square mile (1,000 per square km) in the early 21st century, varies according to the distribution of flatland. The highest density occurs in and around the Ganges delta, which is also the centre of the country's most fertile zone; the lowest population density occurs in the hills of Chittagong.

Rural settlement

The Pakistani administration established new types of autonomous corporations to deal with industrial development, electricity, water and sewerage management, the development of forest industries, and road transportation. In 1972, however, the government of the new independent Bangladesh implemented socialist policies, nationalizing these corporations and establishing several new corporations to manage the nationalized enterprises. Hasty change coupled with the inexperience of those placed in charge of the corporations, produced widespread disruptions, and industrial production nearly came to a halt. In 1973 the government launched a five-year development plan (the first of a series of such plans that have guided the country's economy into the 21st century). The policy of nationalization was gradually revised and was replaced by a 19-point program announced in 1979 that emphasized greater productivity and efficiency. In an effort to encourage private investment, the government also returned many state-owned enterprises to the private sector.

Agriculture and fishing

Bangladesh has remained largely agricultural, with nearly half the population employed in this sector in the early 21st century. Rice is the predominant agricultural product, but jute and tea, both of which are key sources of foreign exchange, also are important. Indeed, the country is one of the world's leading suppliers of raw jute. Other major agricultural products include wheat; pulses, such as peas, beans, and lentils; sweet potatoes; oilseeds and spices of various kinds; sugarcane; tobacco; and fruits, such as bananas, mangoes, and pineapples. The country also is a leading producer of goat milk and goat meat.

Agriculture was at one time wholly dependent upon the vagaries of the monsoon; a poor monsoon always meant poor harvests and the threat of famine. To reduce the risk of crop failure as a result of such adverse weather conditions, a number of irrigation projects including the construction of dams—have been undertaken to control floods and to conserve rainwater for use in the dry months. Among the most important of these initiatives have been the Karnaphuli Multipurpose Project in the southeast, the Tista Barrage Project in the northeast, and the Ganges-Kabaddak Project, to serve the southwestern part of the country. Economic planning has encouraged double and triple cropping, intercropping, and the increased use of fertilizers.



Meghna River

The rural area throughout Bangladesh is so thickly settled that it is often difficult to distinguish any well-defined pattern of individual villages. There are, however, some noticeable features. The inundation of most of the fields during the rainy season makes it necessary to build houses on higher ground. Continuous strings of settlements along roads are common in areas south of the upper Padma River and in the floodplains of the Mahananda, Teesta, Jamuna, lower Padma, and Meghna rivers. Similar settlements are found in the Chittagong Hills and in the hilly segment of the southern Sylhet region. Settlements are more scattered, however, in areas in southwestern Bangladesh along the Bay of Bengal, in the floodplains of the Old Brahmaputra, in the lower-lying areas of eastern and southern Sylhet, and in parts of Chittagong. In central and western Sylhet and in some areas of the Chittagong Hills, settlements occur in a nucleated, or clustered, pattern. With the addition of fabricated one- or two-story structures scattered among thatched bamboo huts, the character of rural villages has changed since the mid-20th century. Supplies of electricity and drinking water, however, have remained inadequate in some regions.

Rural settlement

Although industrial development has prompted migration to the cities, Bangladesh is one of the least-urbanized areas in South Asia. In the 2010s about one-third of the population lived in urban areas. There are three major cities: Dhaka, Chittagong, and Khulna. Dhaka, the capital, is the largest. Chittagong, the country's major port, is second in importance. A number of industrial areas, such as Kalurghat, Sholashahar, and Faujdar Hat, have developed near Chittagong. Khulna, in the southwest, has become a commercial and industrial centre; the opening of the port at Mongla nearby and the growth of the Daulatpur industrial area have increased its population.

Demographic trends

In the 2010s more than one-fourth of Bangladesh's population was under age 15. The birth rate dropped from well above the world average at the beginning of the decade to about 20 per 1,000. Infant mortality had dropped dramatically since the late 20th century but remained high. Life expectancy was about 74 years. There has been very little immigration since the 1970s. Many Bangladeshis, however, live and work abroad—especially in the Middle East.

Economy of Bangladesh

Bangladesh's heavy dependence on agriculture has long contributed to seasonal unemployment among rural farmworkers, as well as to a generally low standard of living in rural areas. To counteract this imbalance, a policy of industrialization was adopted in the 20th century. During the period of Pakistani administration (1947–71), priority was given to industries based on indigenous raw materials such as jute, cotton, hides, and skins. The principle of free enterprise in the private sector was accepted, subject to certain restrictions, including the national ownership of public utilities. The industrial policy also aimed to develop the production of consumer goods as quickly as possible in order to avoid dependence on imports.

rivers of Bangladesh are particularly amenable to breeding and raising fish, aquaculture is the source of more than two-fifths of the country's fish yield. However, rivers and seacoast also offer opportunities for open-water fishing, mostly in the estuaries of the Bay of Bengal. Among the varieties of fish caught are the marine *rupchanda*, or tilapia, and the freshwater hilsa, a relative of the shad.

Resources and power ✓✓

A major obstacle to the economic development of Bangladesh has been a general lack of mineral resources. The country's first oil well, near Sylhet, was established in 1986, but petroleum in marketable quantities has not been struck anywhere in Bangladesh. Natural gas is used mainly in the manufacture of fertilizer and for thermal power. More than half the known gas reserves are in the Comilla area, and nearly all the rest are in Sylhet.

Some deposits of coal have been found in northwestern Bangladesh in the Rajshahi area. The thickest seams are located at relatively inaccessible depths of 3,000 to 3,500 feet (900 to 1,000 metres). Smaller deposits of coal exist in northwestern Sylhet. The Chittagong Hill Tracts contain some brown coal and lignite. Peat deposits exist in several places, but some of the beds remain underwater for half the year, making extraction difficult. Limestone is found in the Sylhet and Chittagong areas. Radioactive minerals have been detected in sand deposits along the beaches south of Cox's Bazar.

Bangladesh's electricity is produced by thermal and hydroelectric processes. The main source of hydroelectricity is the Kaptai Dam in the Chittagong Hill Tracts.

Manufacturing ✓

Because the export of raw jute is not highly remunerative, efforts were made under the Pakistani administration to establish mills to produce and export jute products and thus earn foreign exchange. About 45 percent of the jute produced during that period was processed in the territory; the balance was exported raw. After independence, jute and jute products remained an important source of the country's foreign exchange earnings. However, the clothing industry expanded rapidly in the late 20th century, and by the early 21st century the export value of garments, hosiery, and knitwear had far surpassed that of jute manufactures. Frozen fish and shrimp also became major exports.

The bamboo in the Chittagong Hill Tracts and the various softwood trees growing in the Sundarbans provide excellent raw material for papermaking. There are paper mills at Comilla, Chhatak, and Paksey, as well as a paper and board mill at Khulna.

Bangladesh has fertilizer factories, textile mills, sugar factories, glassworks, and aluminum works. It also has cement factories, located at Chhatak, in the Sylhet area. A shipyard was

opened at Khulna for repairing and reconstructing ships, and a steel mill is at Chittagong.

By far the most important cottage industry centres on the production of yarn and fabrics—mostly coarse and medium-quality fabrics. Another cottage industry produces cigarettes known as bidis. Carpets, ceramics, and cane furniture also are products of cottage industries.

Finance

The Bank of Bangladesh serves as the country's central bank. Upon independence, Bangladesh nationalized all domestic banks, though much of this nationalization was reversed beginning with a privatization program in the 1980s. Since the establishment of Grameen Bank in 1976 and through the efforts of its founder, Muhammad Yunus, Bangladesh has served as a pioneering centre for microfinance, a method of extending credit in the form of small loans to nontraditional borrowers, such as women. By the 2010s more than 30 million Bangladeshis were members of microfinance institutions.

Trade

Total annual imports typically exceed exports. Imports come primarily from China and South Asia, while Bangladesh exports goods primarily to Europe, the United States, and Canada. Major exports include garments and knitwear, agricultural products, seafood, jute, and leather.

Transportation

Central to the country's transportation system are networks of waterways, roads, and railways, the last built mostly during British rule. Inland waterways are important for low-cost transport and access to areas where land transport would be costly. They carry much of the domestic and foreign cargo. Chief seaports are Chittagong and Mongla, and international airports are at Dhaka and Chittagong, as well as several other airports serving domestic service.

The forms of transport used on Bangladesh's roads range from automobiles and the bullock cart. Two-wheeled horse-drawn jigs and bullock carts are still used, particularly in the north in Rajshahi. Town and city dwellers both rely largely on the cycle rickshaw and two types of three-wheeled vehicles, known locally as auto and tempo. The light-weight rickshaw, which can easily be used on unpaved roads, is the most popular vehicle in towns and villages. The annual inundations that submerge most of the rural roads necessitate the use of so-called country boats—flat wooden boats that are hand-propelled by means of long paddles.

Government and society

Constitutional framework

er of the Supreme Court was greatly reduced. In 1977 a Supreme Judicial Council established to draw up a code of conduct for Supreme Court and High Court judges, who removed from office by the president upon the council's recommendation.

from the High Court may go on circuit for a portion of the year to hear cases from courts in other parts of the country. Those lower courts include district courts, sessions and several types of magistrate courts. The magistrate courts handle the vast majority of civil cases.

and welfare

Bangladesh has many government hospitals and rural health centres. Tuberculosis, cholera, and malaria continue to pose threats to public health, and since about 2000 outbreaks of dengue fever have been a concern as well. However, an effective approach to the treatment of cholera and tuberculosis has been developed by research laboratories and hospitals in Dhaka and Comilla, and the incidence of malaria has been reduced by a malaria-eradication program in which swamps and marshes are regularly sprayed with insecticides. Historically, leprosy also was a serious problem in Bangladesh. In the late 20th century, however, the government took aggressive measures to eradicate the disease, and within less than a decade, leprosy had virtually disappeared from the country.

Health services are provided by private agencies and government departments. These services include, among others, community development projects, schools for handicapped children, day-care centres, orphanages, and training institutes for social workers. A family-planning program inaugurated in the late 20th century has helped to control population growth.

Education of Bangladesh

The foundation of the educational system in Bangladesh was laid down during the period of British rule. The system has three levels—primary, secondary, and higher education. Primary and secondary education are both compulsory, though universal participation has remained more an ideal than a fact. Primary education consists of eight years, while secondary education lasts four years. Secondary education is divided into a lower level and a higher level, and public examinations are held at the conclusion of each level of schooling. Schools in cities and towns are generally better-staffed and better-financed than those in rural areas.

There are hundreds of colleges, most of them affiliated with one of the larger universities, such as the University of Dhaka (1921), the University of Rajshahi (1953), or the University of Chittagong (1966). Other prominent institutions include Jahangirnagar University (1970) on the outskirts of the capital, the Bangladesh Agricultural University (1961) at Mymensingh, the Bangladesh University of Engineering and Technology (1962) at Dhaka, and the Islamic University (1980) at Kushtia. Medical education is provided by several medical colleges and

While Bangladesh's constitution of 1972 specifies a parliamentary form of government under a prime minister and a president elected by a national assembly, its implementation has been interrupted by coups. In 1975 a military coup led to a regime of martial law, and, though the form of government that followed was a mixture of presidential and parliamentary systems, power effectively remained with the army. The country experienced additional upsets and periods of martial law in the 1980s, but in 1991 a parliamentary system was restored, with president as head of state and a prime minister as head of government.



Bangladesh: Jatiya Sangsad Bhaban (parliament building)

The parliament of Bangladesh, called the Jatiya Sangsad (House of the Nation), is a unicameral entity consisting of some 350 seats, most of which are filled through direct election. The remaining seats are reserved for women; these members are elected by the parliament itself. Legislators serve five-year terms. The parliament elects the president, who also serves a five-year term, with a two-term limit. The president then appoints the leader of the legislative majority party (or coalition) as prime minister.

Local government

Between the early 1980s and the early 1990s, local government in Bangladesh underwent large-scale administrative reorganization to decentralize power. The resulting structure consisted of several major divisions, each of which was subdivided into a number of districts called *zila*. These districts were parceled further into smaller units, called *upzila* and *thana*. Bangladesh now consists of 8 divisions, more than 60 districts, and more than 500 *upzila* and *thana*. Villages—the smallest unit of government—numbered in the tens of thousands and were grouped into unions beneath the *upzila* and *thana*.

Local government in both rural and urban regions is primarily in the hands of popularly elected executives and councils. Each division is headed by a commissioner. Executives at the district and *thana* levels are assisted by various professionals appointed by the national government, as well as by their elected councils.

Justice

Bangladesh has maintained essentially the same judicial system that was in operation when the territory was a province of Pakistan and that owes its origins to the system in operation under the British raj. The 1972 constitution divided the Supreme Court of Bangladesh into Appellate and High Court divisions and mandated a complete separation of the judicial and executive branches of government. During the subsequent authoritarian regime, however

an institute of postgraduate medicine at Dhaka. Each college or institute has a full-fledged hospital attached to it.

For vocational training Bangladesh relies on several engineering colleges and a network of polytechnic and law colleges. In addition, an array of specialized colleges are dedicated to training students in areas such as the arts, home economics, social welfare and research, and various aspects of agriculture.

Literacy improved significantly in the 21st century: less than half of the population could read and write at the beginning of the century, but by the late 2010s more than two-thirds were literate.

Cultural life

The Bengali language, Islamic religion, and rural character of Bangladesh all serve to unify the country's culture to a considerable degree. Although some regional variation occurs across the Bengali community, cultural differences between ethnic, religious, and social minorities and between rural and urban populations are much more salient.

Daily life and social customs

The typical household in Bangladesh, particularly in the villages, includes several generations of extended family. Most marriages are arranged by parents or other relatives, but increasing numbers of educated men and women choose their own partners. Custom and religion among Muslims require that a dowry be offered by the husband to the wife, but it is usually claimed only in the event of separation or at the husband's death. Divorce is permissible among Muslims, and Muslim law (*Shari'ah*) permits limited polygyny, although it is not widespread. Hindus may obtain a separation by application to a court of law.

The main festivals in Bangladesh are religious. The two most important are Eid al-Fitr, which comes at the end of Ramadan, the Muslim month of fasting, and Eid al-Adha, the festival of sacrifice, which falls on the 10th day of the last month of the Islamic calendar. On both occasions families and friends exchange visits.

While rice, pulses, and fish continue to constitute the staple diet of Bangladeshis, shortages of rice since World War II have forced the acceptance of wheat and wheat products as alternatives. Meat, including goat and beef, also is eaten, especially in the towns. At weddings and other festive occasions, seasoned rice (*pilau*) accompanies highly spiced meat dishes and curries. Bangladesh is noted for a large variety of milk-based sweets.

The *lungi* (a length of cloth wrapped around the lower half of the body, comparable to the Malaysian sarong) with a short vest is the most common form of male attire in the countryside and in the less-wealthy sections of urban settlements. Men of the educated classes prefer light cotton trousers called pajamas (from which the English word originates) and a kind of collarless knee-length shirt known as a *panjabi*. On more formal occasions they dress in a modification of the Western suit. The traditional *sherwani* and *churidar*, calf-length tunic and close-fitting trousers, are still seen at weddings, where they are worn along with the

turban. The sari is common among women, but girls and younger women, especially students, prefer the *shadwar kamiz*, a combination of calf-length shirt and baggy silk or cotton trousers gathered at the ankles.

The arts of Bangladesh

Literature

The Bengali language began to assume a distinct form in the 7th century CE, and by the 11th century a tradition of Bengali literature had been established. Litterateurs received official patronage under both the Pala (8th to 12th century) kings and early Muslim rulers, under the Senas (11th and 12th centuries) and Mughals (early 16th to mid-18th century); however, they were generally unsupported. Nevertheless, Bengali language and literature thrived in various traditions of music and poetry that were practiced outside the court, laying the foundation for the so-called "Bengali Renaissance" of the 19th century. The renaissance was centred in Kolkata (Calcutta) and led by Ram Mohan Roy (1772–1833); its luminary poet, Rabindranath Tagore (1861–1941), composed the national anthems of both India and Bangladesh and was awarded the Nobel Prize for Literature in 1913. In its early years the movement espoused the virtues of Western education and liberalism, and it was largely confined to the Hindu community.

Music, dance, and theatre

There are four main types of music in Bangladesh—classical, light-classical, devotional, and popular—which may overlap in some cases. Classical music has many forms, of which the *dhrupad* (Hindustani devotional songs) and the related, shorter form called *khayal* are the best known. Devotional music also is represented by *qawwali* and *kirtana*, vocal genres that are part of the common musical heritage of the subcontinent. It is, however, in the field of local nonclassical popular music that Bangladesh is most prominent. The forms known as *bhatiali*, *bhawaiya*, *jari*, *sari*, *marfati*, and *baul* have no real equivalents outside the country. The vigorous spontaneous style of these musics generally distinguishes them from classical genres.

Apart from such classical dances as *kathakali* and *bharata natyam*—forms that are popular throughout the subcontinent—unique indigenous dances have developed in Bangladesh. Among the most widespread of these are the *dholi*, *baul*, *manipuri*, and snake dances. Each form expresses a particular aspect of communal life and is danced on specific occasions. Improvisation has been a core component of both classical and nonclassical music and dance. With the increasing commercialization of the arts, however, improvisation has been on the wane. Although some of the performing arts are learned informally, others are taught formally at music and dance academies. Two of the oldest and most prominent of such academies are the Bulbul Academy for Fine Arts and the Nazrul Academy, both in Dhaka.

All towns and most villages have cinema houses. Plays are occasionally staged by amateur groups and drama societies in educational institutions and are broadcast regularly on radio and television. Musical concerts, though not as popular as the cinema, are well

attended. Especially popular in the countryside is *jatra*, a form of opera that draws on local legends.

Visual art and architecture

Painting as an independent art form is a relatively recent phenomenon in Bangladesh. The main figure behind the art movement was Zainul Abedin, who first attracted attention with his sketches of the Bengal famine of 1943. After the partition of Pakistan from India in 1947, he was able to gather around him a school of artists who experimented with various forms, both orthodox and innovative.

The historical prevalence of Islamic arts in Bangladesh is especially evident in the many mosques, mausoleums, forts, and gateways that have survived from the Mughal period. Like Muslim architecture elsewhere in the subcontinent, these structures are characterized by the pointed arch, the dome, and the minaret. The best-preserved example is the 77-dome mosque at Bagerhat in the south. The ruins of Lalbagh Fort, an incomplete 17th-century Mughal palace at Dhaka, also provide some idea of the older Islamic architectural traditions. While such Mughal architecture belongs in style and conception to the same school as medieval buildings in northern India, a unique innovation in Bangladesh has been the translation into brick and mortar of the sloping four-sided thatched roof found in the countryside.



Somapura Mahavira

Some remains of pre-Muslim Buddhist architecture have been unearthed at Paharpur and Mahasthan in the north and at Maynamati in the south. They are said to date from the 8th century, and they exhibit the circular stupa pattern characteristic of ancient Buddhist monasteries in India.

Public buildings in the British and Pakistani periods sometimes followed the Mughal style, but preferences subsequently shifted to the International Style, which was prevalent in the United States and Europe in the mid-20th century. The softness of Bangladesh's subsoil precludes the construction of skyscrapers.

Sports and recreation

During the 20th century, football (soccer) emerged as the preeminent sport in Bangladesh. Field hockey, cricket, tennis, badminton, and wrestling also are popular. Bangladesh made its

Olympic debut at the 1984 Summer Games in Los Angeles. Indigenous games of the "touch and run" type, however, remain among the favourites of children and youths. One such game called *kobadi*, requires each of two teams in turn to send out a player to raid the other territory. The raider must, while chanting, touch as many opposing players as he can without taking a breath. Kite flying is another traditional pastime enjoyed by young and old alike. The making of elaborate kites from cloth or paper is a distinctive form of visual art as well.

Media and publishing

Programs are broadcast on radio and television in English and in Bengali; news on the radio is also broadcast in Urdu, Hindi, Burmese, and Arabic. Both radio and television are controlled by the government. By contrast, most newspapers are privately owned, and the constitution provides for freedom of the press. The Bengali newspapers have relatively small circulations, a fact that reflects the low level of literacy in the country. Nonreaders, however, are still exposed to the ideas and influence of the press, as newspapers are often read aloud in groups. Although their circulation is smaller than that of the Bengali papers, English dailies exercise a disproportionate influence, because their patrons belong to the educated classes. Major Bengali dailies include the *Daily Prothom Alo*, *Dainik Ittefaq*, and *Dainik Juganto*. Major English dailies include *The Daily Star*, *New Age*, and *The New Nation*.

Importance of River in Bangladesh

Bangladesh is a small country located in South Asia, bordered by India and Myanmar. It is known for its lush green landscapes, deltaic plains, and numerous rivers. The country is crisscrossed by more than 230 rivers, which play a vital role in the country's economy, society, and culture.

Importance of rivers in Bangladesh

The rivers of Bangladesh are lifelines for the country's people. They provide water for drinking, irrigation, and hydropower. They also serve as a means of transportation and commerce. They are also deeply rooted in the country's culture and religion.

Physical Characteristics of Rivers in Bangladesh

Types of rivers

The rivers in Bangladesh can be broadly classified into two types: the Himalayan rivers, which originate in the mountains of India and Nepal, and the trans-boundary rivers, which originate in India and flow through Bangladesh. The rivers in Bangladesh are generally characterized as braided and meandering.

Length and width of major rivers

Some of the major rivers in Bangladesh include the Brahmaputra, the Ganges, the Meghna, and the Padma. The Brahmaputra is the longest river in the country, stretching over 1,800 kilometers. The Ganges, Meghna and Padma are also large rivers, with the Ganges flowing over 1,500 kilometers and the Meghna and Padma flowing over 700 kilometers each.

River basin and drainage system

Bangladesh is located in the Ganges-Brahmaputra-Meghna (GBM) river basin, which is one of the largest river basins in the world. The Ganges and Brahmaputra rivers merge in Bangladesh to form the Meghna river, which then flows into the Bay of Bengal. The country's river drainage system is characterized by a network of distributaries, which form a deltaic plain that is highly susceptible to flooding.

Economic Importance of Rivers in Bangladesh

Transportation and commerce

The rivers of Bangladesh serve as important transportation routes for people and goods. The country's inland water transport system is one of the largest in the world, and it plays a vital role in connecting remote areas with major cities and ports. The rivers also serve as important trade routes, both domestically and internationally.

System

Agriculture and Irrigation

The rivers are also crucial for agriculture and irrigation. The fertile deltaic plain of Bangladesh is heavily dependent on the rivers for irrigation and the rivers provide water for the growth of crops such as rice, jute, sugarcane, and wheat.

Hydroelectric power generation

The rivers are also used for hydroelectric power generation. The country has several hydroelectric power plants, which provide a significant portion of the country's electricity.

Blessing for fisherman and fisherman communities

Many people in Bangladesh earn their livelihoods by fishing in the rivers. The rivers are home to a wide variety of fish species, and the fishing industry provides employment and food security for many people in the country.

Environmental Impact of Rivers in Bangladesh

Flooding and erosion

The deltaic plain of Bangladesh is highly susceptible to flooding and erosion due to the country's flat terrain and the large volume of water that the rivers carry during the monsoon season. Flooding can cause significant damage to crops, homes, and infrastructure, and it can also lead to the displacement of people. Erosion can also cause the loss of valuable land and can affect the country's overall agricultural productivity.

Water pollution and its impact on aquatic life

The rivers of Bangladesh are also facing significant pollution problems. Industries, agriculture, and human settlements discharge large amounts of pollutants into the rivers, which can harm aquatic life and make the water unsafe for human consumption.

Impact on biodiversity and ecosystems

The pollution and degradation of the rivers also have negative impacts on the biodiversity and ecosystems that depend on the rivers. Many fish and other aquatic species are facing extinction due to the pollution, and the loss of these species can have cascading effects on the entire ecosystem.

Climate change and its impact on rivers

Climate change is also affecting the rivers in Bangladesh. Rising sea levels and increased frequency of extreme weather events can exacerbate the problems of flooding and erosion, and can also affect the flow of the rivers. Additionally, changes in precipitation patterns can affect the water availability for irrigation and hydroelectric power generation.

The People of Bangladesh

Learning Objectives

After this chapter, the learners will be able to understand the origin and evolution of the people of Bangladesh and different tribal groups in the country. It will also provide a clear understanding about the population growth in different phases of history, its distribution based on various socio-economic factors and how Bangladesh has been facing the challenges of overpopulation together with its prospects.

Keywords: Origin, People, population, challenge, prospect, Bangladesh.

Chapter Outlines

1.1 Origin of the People;

1.2 Population Growth;

1.3 Sex Composition;

1.4 Rural-urban Population;

1.5 Literacy;

1.6 Population Challenges and Prospects for Bangladesh.

Chapter Summary

Chapter Evaluation

1.0 Introduction to the Study

Bangladesh is one of the top five countries in the world in terms of population density with 1222 population in a square kilometer according to World Bank's data of 2011, while the country ranks 94th in terms of area with 147,612 square kilometers. It is the 8th most populous country in the world,² while Russia is the 9th but with an area of 17.5 million square kilometers, at least 120 times bigger than Bangladesh. The total population of Bangladesh is about 16,89,57,745 (2014).³ Here is some information relevant to Bangladesh population statistics⁴:

Age structure	00-14 years: 32.3% (male 27,268,560/female 26,468,883) 15-24 years: 18.8% (male 14,637,526/female 16,630,766) 25-54 years: 38% (male 29,853,531/female 33,266,733) 55-64 years: 5.9% (male 4,964,130/female 4,870,447) 65 years and over: 5% (male 4,082,544/female 4,237,591 est.)
Population growth rate	1.05% (2016 est.)
Birth rate	19 births/1,000 population (2016 est.)
Death rate	5.3 deaths/1,000 population (2016 est.)
Urbanization	Urban population: 28.4% of total population (2011) Rate of urbanization: 2.96% annual rate of change (2011 est.)
Major cities - population	DHAKA (capital) 15.391 million; Chittagong 5.239 million Khulna 1.781 million; Rajshahi 932,000 (2011)
Sex ratio	At birth: 1.04 male(s)/female 0-14 years: 1.04 male(s)/female,

¹ Population density, World Bank, retrieved on 12 December 2015, <http://data.worldbank.org/indicator/EN.POP.DNST>.

² U.S. Census Bureau Current Population, United States Census Bureau, retrieved on 12 December 2015, from <http://www.census.gov/popclock/print.php?component=c>

³ *Ibid.*

⁴ CIA World Factbook <https://www.cia.gov/library/publications/the-world-factbook/>
Bangladesh Bureau of Statistics <http://www.bbs.gov.bd/home.aspx>.

	15-24 years: 1 male(s)/female 25-54 years: 0.93 male(s)/female, 55-64 years: 0.98 male(s)/female 65 years and over: 0.97 male(s)/female Total population: 0.97 male(s)/female (2016 est.)
Mortality	Total: 32.9 deaths/1,000 live births Male: 35.2 deaths/1,000 live births, Female: 30.04 deaths/1,000 live births (2016 est.)
Groups	Bengali 98%, other 2% (includes tribal groups, non-Bengali Muslims)
	Muslim 89.5%, Hindu 9.6%, other 0.9% (2004)
	Definition: age 15 and over can read and write Total population: 57.7%, male: 62%, female: 53.4% (2011 est.)

highest density is in Dhaka district with 8229 persons/sq. km, while the lowest is in Bandarban with 86 persons/sq. km. The gender ratio of population is about 100.3 males per 100 females. The annual growth rate of population is 1.2% per annum and the literacy rate is 57.7% (male: 62%, female: 53.4%) (2011 est.) for the population of age 15 years and above. The major population is relatively young, with 52% within the 15-24 age group, while only 2% are 65 or older. In the 1960s and 1970s Bangladesh was one of the fastest growing countries in the world in terms of population when it grew from 50 to 90 million, but in the 1980s and later, the growth rate gradually declined.



In respect to religion, Muslims constitute 89.5%, the Hindu 9.6%, and other minorities comprise 0.9% of the total population of Bangladesh.

History of the People

The earliest known people in this area were Negritos. The next group was the Proto-Australoids, who were followed by a wave of Proto-Mongolians from the east. Soon after them came the Aryans, who entered the region from the northwest.

Dravidians were added from the north-west of the sub-continent to this melting population and spread as far as Bangladesh. All this happened most likely before 1000 BC. From the beginning of the first century, the Aryans gradually moved from the lower Ganges valley. Thus, different ethnic groups of people from different parts of the world formed the nucleus of population in the land combining together various races of people. Besides having major population group of the Bangladeshi country has over thirty tribes most of whom live in Rajshahi, Chittagong, Chittagong Hill Tracts, greater Mymensingh, Sylhet, Patuakhali and Barguna regions. All the ethnic communities of Bangladesh are bi-lingual. They have learnt the Bengali language for communication, while having their own languages to use in their own communities. Based on ethnic diversity, the people of Bangladesh can be classified into four groups:

- a) Dravidian b) Proto-Australian c) Mongolian and d) Bangali.

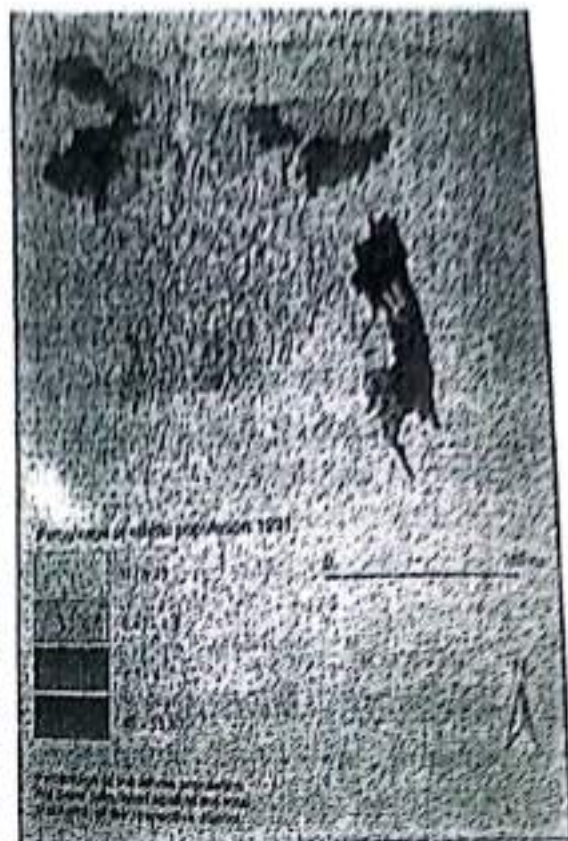
2.a. The Dravidian

The Dravidian refers to the diverse groups of people who natively speak the languages belonging to Dravidian Languages family who are mostly found in southern India and Sri Lanka. The most populous Dravidian peoples (30-70 million each) are the Tamils, Kannadigas and the Malayalis and the best-known Dravidian languages include Tamil, Kannada, Malayalam, Telugu and Tulu.¹ To ascertain the origin of the Dravidian people and language has been difficult. A number of earlier anthropologists held the view that the Dravidian peoples constituted a distinct race, while others held views that they held in India before the Indo-Aryan invasion. Genetic studies have concluded that the Dravidian people are not a distinct race, rather, a continuum between the Dravidian and non-Dravidian people in South India. The smallest ethnic group in Bangladesh with only a few thousand people speak Dravidian language. They are mainly Munda and Oraon, most of whom are living in the Sylhet tea gardens.

¹ Robert Caldwell, *A Comparative Grammar of the Dravidian or South-Indian Languages*, London: Harrison, 1956, pp. 1-6.

Proto-Australian

Second group is the Proto-Australian in which they probably came from Africa, western and spread far into South-East Asia. It is believed that the Proto-Australians are of hunter-gather people descended from the first wave of modern humans to leave sub-Saharan Africa 100,000 years ago. They are believed to have begun their exodus out of Africa about 60,000 years ago. It is hypothesized that they followed a coastal route through south Asia and Southeast Asia. While some individuals made an oceanic voyage into Australia, giving rise to the Afro-Negrito ancestral component of Indian Aborigines, others continued their migration north into East Asia. The



and Santals, the two prime components of this group, mainly labourers in the region of Sylhet, some living in the Chittagong Hill Tracts and in different parts of Rajshahi division. The 1881 census showed that there were Santals in the districts of Pabna, Jessore, Khulna and Chittagong. According to the 1931 census, the Santal population was over two hundred thousand. They are believed to have introduced agricultural practices in and adjoining Bangladesh. This is evidenced by the survival of Austro-Asiatic words in Bengali related to agriculture such as *Plough*, *Ganda* (Four), *Narikel* (Coconut), *Lau* (Pumpkin), and *Kuri*

Mongolians

the term of Central Asian ethnic groups who live mainly on the Mongolian Plateau share a common language and culture. They speak languages belonging to the Altaic family of origin. Their homeland, Greater Mongolia, is nowadays divided into three independent Mongolia, and Mongolian Autonomous Region of Inner Mongolia of China. Owing to wars and migrations, the Mongols are found in various parts of Central Asia. In Bangladesh, Mongolian population is confined mainly to the Chittagong Hill Tracts and Madhupur forest of Mymensingh area. The major

ethnic groups belonging to Mongolian origin are the Chakma, Tipra, Garo, Marma, Tanchanghya and Moghs living in the Chittagong Hill Tracts and Manipuri living in Sylhet, while Garos and Hajongs living in the Mymensingh area. Chakmas are the largest ethnic group with about 253,000 people mostly concentrating in Rangpur and Khagrachari districts. The second largest ethnic minority group in Bangladesh is Marma mostly living in the districts of Rangamati, Bandarban and Khagrachari. Some of them also live in the coastal districts of Cox's Bazar and Patuakhali. They call themselves Rakhain. According to the 1991 census, the number of Marma in Bangladesh is 157,301. They speak in Arakanese dialect and their language is written in Burmese characters. Tripura, the third largest tribal group had their residence in Tripura of India. They initially migrated to Comilla, Sylhet and Chittagong areas and, in course of time, they concentrated largely in the Chittagong Hill Tracts. Manipuri, another important ethnic community, originally came from Manipur in the northeast India. They migrated to the Bangladesh area and settled at different times due to wars, conflicts and other socio-political perspectives.

The number of ethnic population is as follows:⁶

Ethnic Community	Population
Bawm (also spelt as Bum, Baum, Bam)	1,000
Buna (found only in the 1991 Census Report)	700
Chakma	253,000
Garo (people prefer the name Mandi)	60,000
Hajong	1,00,000
Horizon (found only in the 1991 Census Report)	1,000
Khami (also spelt as Khumi, Kami)	1,000
Khasi (generally known as Khasia)	1,000
Khyang (also spelt as Khyen)	1,000
Koch (also spelt as Kots, Kuch, Coach)	1,000
Lushai (also known as Kuki, Mizo)	1,000
Mahat (also known as Mahatu)	1,000
Manipuri (also known as Meithei)	1,000
Marma (also known as Mag, Mogh, Mug)	157,301
Mro (also spelt as Mrbo)	1,000
Mrong (also spelt as Murang, Mrung)	1,000

⁶ Census report 1991, Bangladesh Bureau of Statistics, retrieved from <http://www.bbs.gov.bd/home.aspx>.

Ethnic Community	Population
(also known as Mundari)	2,132
(also spelt as Urang, Urao)	8,216
(also known as Pahary)	1,853
(also spelt as Pangkhu, Pangkhua)	3,227
(also spelt as Rajbongshi)	7,556
(a branch of Marmia)	16,932
(spelt as Chak, Tsak, Thak)	2,127
(also spelt as Saontal)	202,162
(a branch of Chakma)	21,639
(also known as Tripuri, Tripura)	81,014
(and only in the 1991 Census Report)	5,561
(see box for comments)	261,742
	1,205,978

Bangalis

Bangalis are the largest group of all, constituting about 98% of the total population of Bangladesh. This group is non-tribal and heterogeneous in origin. The fertility of the land in Bangladesh and the abundance of its agricultural production attracted the people from various territories of the world to come and settle down there. Particularly, the people coming from the desert and non-agricultural localities migrated to Indian sub-continent including Bangladesh in the various courses of history on different occasions. They began to live together there and thus founded the basis of Bangali society by combining the different races of population. Because of this mixture, they differ in their physical appearances, habits, behaviors and so on.

Population Growth

The population size of Bangladesh was 111.4 million in 1991 and it stood at 168.9 million in 2014. It is estimated that the population of the country will nearly be 205 million by 2050. The number of households in 2011 was 32,067,700. The average size of a household was 4.8.

Population, 1801-2001 (in Million)

Year	1600	1770	1801	1851	1901	1921	1941	1961	1981	2001	2014
Population (in million)	9.0	11.8	14.5	20.3	28.9	33.3	42.0	50.8	89.9	129.25	168.9

The economic prosperity of Bengal attracted people from all other parts of India as well as from other countries to migrate and settle down here. From the 13th century the Muslims of different Muslim countries and various parts of India migrated to Bengal and the trend continued until the 18th century. The population of Bangladesh was around 14.5 million in 1801, which almost doubled to 28.9 million in 1901. The annual growth rate, however, was almost constant at a level of 0.5% in 1901. The slow growth of population continued till 1931 when the size of the population reached 35.3 million. After 1931, the doubling of population took place every 35 years. Records showed a relatively high growth rate during 1941-1951 mainly caused by political migration of both Hindu and Muslim religious groups within India to Pakistan. The rate was 1.93% during 1951-1961, 2.61% during 1961-1974, 2.2% during 1974-1981, and 1.48% during 1991-2001.⁷ The current rate of population growth is 1.6%.

4.0 Age-Sex Composition

32.3% of total population of Bangladesh is within 0-14 years age group and 15-24 age group, which strongly indicates to the very young age structure of the population, reflecting a high level of fertility. Although the proportion of population of age 65 years and higher is still relatively small (5%). The sex ratio of the population is about 100.3 males per 100 females. Another salient feature of the country's population is a very high proportion of women in the reproductive age group (42.3%).

5.0 Rural-Urban Population

The process of urbanization in Bangladesh has been very rapid since 1961. The 1961 census recorded only 0.7 million people living in urban areas but this has increased slowly to 2.6 million in 1961. The urban population increased from 1901 to 5.2% in 1961,⁸ which increased to 25.1% in 2008. The urban population is growing at more than twice the growth rate of national population. Now the urban population is 28.4% of total population (2011) and the annual rate of change of urban population is 2.96%, which indicates the rapid increase of urban population. Most of

⁷ Sirajul Islam (ed.), *Banglapedia*, The National Encyclopedia of Bangladesh, Asiatic Society of Bangladesh, 2003. Retrieved from <http://www.banglapedia.org/>.

⁸ *Ibid.*

History of Bengal

Pre-historic Bengal

Stone Age remnants have been found in Bengal that date back 20,000 years. The indigenous population Bengal consists of tribes and of Austrie and Austro-Asiatic origin such as Kola, Mro, Santhal, Shabara, and Pulinda.

Ancient Bengal

Bengal is a 4,000 year old civilization that thrived between the banks of Ganges to Brahmaputra and sustained itself with the riches of Gangetic Delta.

Remnants of earliest cities in the state date back to the Vedic Period. The oldest archaeological site in Bangladesh is Mahasthangarh, which dates back to 700 BCE. The culture and ethnicity of Bengal was different than that of the Vedic people. The latter referred to the people of Bengal as 'dasyus' or demons.

The Retreat of Alexander from Gangaridai

Greek traveler and chronicler Megasthenes referred to Bengal as Gangaridai in his book *Indica* (300 BC). When Alexander invaded India and defeated Porus, he wanted to conquer all of India and moved eastward where he came to know about the mighty forces of the Gangaridai warriors.

Alexander read accounts of Gangetic Delta written by Ptolemy and Diodorus. Greek historian Diodorus Siculus (90 BC -30 BC) depicted the Gangaridai warriors in this manner:

"The river is called the Ganges which had a width of thirty two stadia, and a greater depth than any other Indian river. Beyond this again were situated the dominions of the nation of the Prasioi and the Gandaridai, whose king, Xandrammes, had an army of 20,000 horses, 200,000 infantry, 2,000 chariots and 4,000 elephants trained and equipped for war.... Now this (Ganges) river, which is 30 stadia broad, flows from north to south, and empties its water into the ocean forming the eastern boundary of the Gandaridai, a nation which possesses the greatest number of elephants and the largest in size."

Arguably, it was the might of the Gangaridai warriors that made Alexander retreat.

Gangaridai occurs as the name of a people and of a country in Greek and Latin writings, dates of which range between 1st century BC and 2nd century AD. The term Gangaridai and its variants Gangaridae, Gangaridum and Gangarides are found in the works of classical authors.

Writing about the countries beyond the Indus on the basis of the knowledge obtained by Alexander and his soldiers, Diodorus (69 BC-16 AD) mentions that beyond the Ganges were the dominions of the Prasioi and the Gangaridai. Quintus Curtius Rufus tells us that two peoples, the Gangaridai and the Pharrisii, inhabited the further banks of the Ganges. Strabo (63 BC - 18 AD) informs us that the Ganges flows through the Gangaridae, forming its eastern boundary. Pliny (c 1st century AD) writes that the final part of the Ganges flowed through the country of the Gangarides. Virgil (c 30 BC) mentions Gangaridai without indicating its location.

Ptolemy (c 2nd century AD) gives a little more detailed location when he writes that Gangaridai occupies the entire region about the five mouths of the Ganges and that the royal residence is located in the city of Gange. Ptolemy's five mouths of the Ganges cannot be definitely identified though he has given their names along with their longitudinal and latitudinal positions, although they are inaccurate. However, in his description 4 longitudinal degrees covered the coast from the westernmost to the easternmost mouth of the river. This, in effect, means that the Gangaridai country stretched a long way on the coastline of the Bay of Bengal between the westernmost and easternmost mouths of the Ganges. It is interesting to note that the longitudinal difference between the mouth of the Bhagirathi (near Tamluk) and the Padma (near Chittagong) at present is little more than 3.5 degrees. Thus on Ptolemy's evidence Gangaridai can be located in an area in between the two main channels of the Ganges in present West Bengal of India and Bangladesh. However, the city of Gange cannot be located for lack of details.

O Periplous tes Erythras Thalasses (Periplus Maris Erythraei), - [The Periplus of the Red Sea (English Trans), Published in Greek, in 1994] an account by a Greek sailor (c 1st century AD) mentions the 'Ganges country' on the Bay of Bengal to the east of Desarene (coastal Orissa) having the river Ganges 'around (peri) or on all sides of it'. It goes on to note that on its bank is a market town which has the same name (Gange) as the river. It is apparent that Gangaridai of Ptolemy and the 'Ganges country' of the author of the Periplus is the same area located on the shores of the Bay of Bengal. This sounds similar to the description of *vanga* found in Kalidasa's Raghuvangsa. Thus the Vanga janapada of ancient Bengal may be considered to be the same as the Gangaridai of Greek and Latin writers.

The stem in the various inflected forms - Gangaridai, Gangaridae and Gangaridum - is Gangarid. It has been suggested that Gangarid is a Greek formation of the Indian word Gangahrd, meaning 'the land with the Ganges at its heart' (Gangahrd > Gangarida > Gangaridai, nominative plural of Gangarid). The meaning fits well with the description of the Gangaridai country given by the author of Periplus.

It must be mentioned that we do not have any local source to ascertain the existence of a kingdom in Bengal in the few centuries before and after the beginning of the Christian era. The match the descriptions of military strength provided by the Classical writers for the country Gangaridai. The king of Gangaridai is mentioned to be very powerful in the 4th century AD with 6000 foot soldiers, 1000 horsemen, and 700 elephants. However, the references indicate that the remote countries of the west came to know about their name and fame during the next five hundred years or so.

Entrepot of the Silk Route

Bengal has always been the gateway to the eastern parts of the Indian subcontinent. It is the shortest and easiest route from the Bay of Bengal to the Himalayas. Such a geographic advantage made Bengal a commercial hub that connected the sea to the famous Silk Route.

Mention in Mahabharata

The Mahabharata mentions Bengali kings Chitrasena and Sanudrasena, who were defeated by the Pandav king Bhima. It also talks about a folklore that Bhima was injured by a poisoned arrow.

and he came to the southern most parts of Bengal, called Patratat, to heal. The southern most parts of Bengal indicates towards the mangrove lands of the Sundarbans.

As a significant development of events, a third century civilisation has been recently discovered beneath the surface of Gobardhanpur in Pathar Pratima Block, Sundarbans. The place has remnants of cauldrons and pots that would have been used to make herbal medicines.

Rulers of the bay

The Bengal rulers have always paid attention to naval expansion. Trade links among Bengal, Java, Sumatra and Siam (now Thailand) can be traced even now.

According to Mahavamsa, the chronicle of Sri Lanka, the Bengal prince Vijaya Simha conquered Lanka (modern day Sri Lanka) in 544 BC and coined the name 'Sinhala'.

The History of Independent Bengal: From the Ancient Age to the Battle of Plassey

Introduction✓

Modern Bangladesh emerged as an independent nation in 1971 after achieving independence from Pakistan in the Bangladesh liberation war. The country's borders coincide with the eastern portion of the ancient and historic region of Bengal in the Eastern part of the Indian subcontinent, where civilization dates back over four millennia, to the Chalcolithic Age. The history of the region is closely intertwined with the history of Bengal and the history of India.

The country's early history featured a succession of Indian empires, internal squabbling, and a rivalry between Hinduism and Buddhism for dominance. Islam became dominant in the 13th century when Sunni missionaries arrived in Bangladesh. Later, Muslim rulers reinforced the process of conversion by building mosques, and madrasahs.

Bangladesh, then Vanga or Bangalah (Vangala), lost her freedom and sovereignty with the defeat of the Nawabs after the Battle of Plassey in 1757. Here, the political history of Independent Bengal will be discussed in brief.

Etymology of Bengal✓

The exact origin of the word Bangla or Bengal is unknown. According to Mahabharata, Purana, and Harivamsha Vanga was one of the adopted sons of King Vali who founded the Vanga Kingdom. The earliest reference to "Vangala" has been traced in the copper plates (805 AD) of the South Indian ruler Rashtrakuta Govinda III, who invaded northern India in the 9th century, which speak of Dharmapala as the king of Vangala. The son of Rajendra Chola I of the Chola Dynasty, who invaded Bengal in the 11th century, referred to Govindachandra as the ruler of Vangaladesa. Shams-ud-din Ilyas Shah took the title "the Bangalah" and united the whole region under one government for the first time.

Vanga Kingdom (also known as Banga) was located in the Eastern part of the Indian subcontinent, comprising part of West Bengal, India and present-day modern Bangladesh. Pundra and Pundra were two dominant tribes in Bangladesh in ancient time.

Ancient Age✓

Aryans entered the Indian subcontinent before 2000 B.C. They developed a cultured civilization in India. The Aryans entered Bengal after a long time they had come to India. Little information about the lifestyle of the people of the country can be found before the arrival of the Aryans.

The only exception that of South-Eastern part of Bengal was quite old. People used to live there in pre-historic time. The signs of most ancient civilization have been found on the Hoary Ajay in the present district of Burdwan in West Bengal. There is a region called "Pundra Rajar Dhibi". The archeologists, by excavating, discovered the civilization.

Besides the civilization that grew on the bank of river Ajay, there have been other civilizations too. A country like Bengal did not emerge at once. Many of archaeological excavations in Bangladesh revealed evidences of the Northern Black Polished Ware culture of the Indian Subcontinent (c. 700-200 B.C.) which was an Iron Age culture developed beginning around 700 BC and peaked from c. 500-300 B.C., coinciding with the emerging 16 great states or mahajanapadas in Northern India, and the subsequent rise of the Maurya Empire. The Eastern part of ancient India, covering much of current days Bangladesh was part of one of such mahajanapadas, the ancient kingdom of Anga, which flourished in the 6th century BC. The other janapadas were Gaur, Banga, Pundra, Harikela, Samatata, Barendra, etc. the exact boundary of these janapadas is not known. However, it is true that the boundaries did not remain the same always. Sometimes the boundary of them increased, and sometimes decreased. Descriptions of some of the janapadas are given below:

Gaur: It was situated in the Northern part of East Bengal in the sixth century. In the seventh century Sasanka was the king of Gaur. Karnasuborna, in the present district of Murshidabad was the capital at that time. Sometimes before the Muslim conquest, Lakhnauti of Malda district was also known as Gaur. This region was known as Gaur during the Muslim period too.

Banga: It was situated in the East and SouthEast portion of Bangladesh; its name was originated from the name of a race called Banga. From the old stone inscription, we know about two parts of Banga - "Vikrampur" in present Munshiganj; and "Navya", comprised of the low-lying lands of Faridpur, Bakerganj and Patuakhali. It was a powerful region; it has been learnt that the reputed "Banga Raj" and the Banga soldiers took part in many formidable battles.

Pundra: One of the important janapadas comprised of the present Bogra, Rangpur, Rajshahi and Dinajpur districts. The capital of the Pundra Janapada was "Pundranagar", later named "Pundra Vardhana". Inscriptions carved on pieces of round stones were found here which are supposed to be the most ancient stone inscriptions found in Bangladesh, made during the time of Asoka in the third century B.C.

Barendra: It was also known as Barendri or Barendrabhumi. It was also a janapada of North Bengal. It is supposed that it constituted a part of Pundra. A large portion of Bogra district and Rajshahi district was included in the Barendra janapada.

Samatata: Samatata existed as a neighboring janapada of Banga in the East and South-East of Bengal. The Chinese traveler Hiuen Sung travelled to Samatata in the middle of seventh century and wrote an account of it. The area from the East of the Ganga- Bhagirathi to the estuary of the Meghna was included in the Samatata. Many believe that Bara Kamata Comilla district was a part of this janapada.

Harikela: It is supposed that the present day Sylhet was the Harikela janapada. Though some think that Harikela was not a separate janapada, rather included in Banga janapada.

A well known pre-Aryan kingdom of this region was Gangariddi or Gangaridai, located somewhere on the bank of the river Ganges. It was a powerful kingdom in the time when Alexander the Great invaded the North-Western part of India. Besides, the most ancient Dynasty of Bangladesh "*Maurya Dynasty*" was established before the advent of the Aryan

Maurya Dynasty (321- 185 B.C.) ✓

It has been mentioned that the Mauryan Dynasty was a pre-Aryan empire. Chandragupta Maurya founded the Maurya Dynasty in 321 B.C. The Mauryan rule was established in North Bengal during the reign of Emperor Asoka (269- 232 B.C.). The region became a province of the Mauryas. Its capital was Pataliputra at first, but later moved to Pundranagar. The archaeological site at Mahasthangarh in Bogra still bears the memory of it. It can be learnt from the description of the Chinese traveler Hsuen Sung that the Maurya rule included Murshidabad (Murshidabad), Tamralipti (Hooghly) and Samatata (South-East Bengal) in North Bengal. The Mauryan Empire was arguably the largest empire to rule the Indian subcontinent. Its decline began fifty years after Asoka's rule ended, and it dissolved in 185 B.C. with the rise of the Sunga Dynasty in Magadha. Sunga Dynasty was succeeded by Kharvela Dynasty (75-30 B.C.). Afterwards some foreign powers invaded India. Noteworthy among them are the Greeks, the Sakas, the Pahlavs, the Kushanas etc., though there is no solid proof if they came to Bengal.

Gupta Dynasty (320- 550 A.D.) ✓

Gupta Dynasty, rulers of the Magadha (now Bihar) state in North-Eastern India. They built an empire over Northern and parts of central and Western India from the early 4th to the late 6th century A.D. The founder of the Gupta Dynasty was Maharaja Sri Gupta (240-280 A.D.), but the empire was markedly founded by Chandragupta I (320-335 A.D.). Chandragupta was succeeded by his son Samudragupta, the celebrated. Some parts of North Bengal came under the Gupta rule during the reign of Chandragupta I. Later he brought the whole of Bengal under the Gupta rule. Only the Samatata remained outside their control. Like the Mauryas, the capital of Bengal under the Guptas was Pundranagar of Mahasthangarh. Gupta rulers spread Hinduism in their empire through the building of temples and the promotion of Hindu writings and rituals. During the time of the Gupta Empire, Indian subcontinent as well as Bengal enjoyed a Golden Age in the arts, sciences and religion. The Gupta rule lasted till the middle of the sixth century.

Bengal in Post Gupta Period ✓

The Gupta Empire fell to pieces as a result of the attacks of a fierce mountainous tribe, the Huns. Taking this opportunity many small kingdoms rose throughout the whole of North India. Thus, in the post-Gupta period, Bengal too suffered the political unrest that affected North India. Two independent kingdoms came into existence – the kingdom of Banga (southern region of South-East and West Bengal) and the kingdom of Gaur (Western and northern region of Bengal).

After the fall of the Gupta Empire, some kings known as the "Later Gupta Dynasty" extended their sway over North Bengal, Northern portion of West Bengal and Magadha. This region was already known as the Gaur janapada. Sasanka was a very powerful ruler of the kingdom of Gaur. The ruler of any big region under the Gupta kings was called "Mahasamanta". Sasanka was a "Mahasamanta" of the king Mahasena Gupta. He became the king of Gaur a little before 600 A.D. by defeating the Maukharis. He extended his kingdom by conquering

the kingdom of Dandabhukti, Utkal of Orissa, kingdom of Kānhabhōd and Magadha of The kings of Kamrupa were also defeated by him.

Sasanka then thought of conquering North India. This region was divided into two pe kingdoms – (i) Thaneshwar under the Pushyabhuti Dynasty, (ii) Kanyakubja (Kanauj) the Maukhari Dynasty. The two kingdoms became friendly as a result of marital re Sasanka made an alliance with Devagupta, the king of Malaba to uproot the Maukhar perpetual enemies of the Guptas. Grahavarma, the Maukhari king was defeated and ki the hands of Devagupta even before Sasanka could reach North India. Then he fought Rajyavardhana, the king of Thaneshwar, and was defeated and killed. Rajyavardhana advanced towards Kanauj. He came face to face with Sasanka on the way. In the Rajyavardhana was defeated; later he was put to death. Afterwards Harshavardhana b the over-lord of Kanauj and Thaneshwar. He made an alliance with the king of A Vaskara Varmana and marched against Sasanka to take revenge with a huge army. He not, however, succeed wholly against Sasanka. Sasanka died a little before 637 A.D.

After Sasanka there was no able ruler in Bengal for a long time. As a result, there disorder and unrest. The country plunged into darkness. The kingdom was broke fragments by Harshavardhana and Vaskara Varmana, while the powerful landlords f against each other. The feudal kings, all of them desiring to become the king of Benga to arms. This period of political unrest has been termed as "Matsyanayam" in the c inscriptions of the Palas. When the strong and big fishes catch and eat up the smaller c is called "Matsyanayam". The powerful Lords of Bengal began to swallow the small re in the same manner. This unrest in Bengal continued for one hundred years. With the r the Pala Dynasty in the middle of eighth century this unrest came to and end.

The Pala Dynasty (750- 1160 A.D.)✓

The founder of the Pala Dynasty was Gopala who was selected as the emperor of Ga 750. He subdued the prevalent unrest with the help of the elders of the society. The kin the Pala Dynasty ruled Bengal for four hundred years at a stretch. No other royal family ruled Bengal for such a long period. It had multiple capitals at different stages o kingdom. Its first capital was in Vikramapura in present day Munshiganj. Later it was m to Pataliputra, and then to Gaur.

After having restored peace, Gopala turned his attention to the extension of the kingdom brought almost all the regions of the North and Eastern part of Bengal under his king North-East Bengal remained out of Gopala's rule. Although some are of opinion that G ruled for 27 years, some modern researchers believe that he ruled the country from 756 A.D.

Dharmapala (781-821 A.D.), son of Gopala, was the greatest of the Pala kings, established his rule in Bengal and Bihar. His capital was in Somapura in Naogaon district fought many fights and wars during his reign, e.g. the "Tripartite War", the battle with Nagbhattacharya II of Gurjara-Pratihara etc. He was defeated in most of them, though the incurred by him was not much. When the Rashtrakuta King Govinda III defeated Nagbhattacharya II, Dharmapala could regain his supremacy in North India. However, Dharmapala conqu Varanasi and Prayaga and extended his kingdom up to the region situated between the m part of the Ganges and the Jamuna. Some historians say that he also conquered Nepal

for about 40 years. The vast area that Dharmapala established was no longer a kingdom; it became an empire.

After the death of Dharmapala, his son Devapala (821-861 A.D.) ascended the throne as the second ruler. He was a worthy successor of his father in respect of intelligence and power. He shifted his capital in Monghyr (Munger) in India. Devapala had two reputed Brahmin ministers. They were Darvapani and Kedaramisra. Aided by these two ministers Devapala made successful attacks on the Pratihara and Rashtrakuta kings. The vast region of North India came under the sway of Bengal's King Devapala. The Pala Empire was most powerful during his time.

Days fell upon the Pala Empire with the death of Devapala. The later kings were weak. Weakness was manifest mostly from the reign of Vigrahapala I to Vigrahapala II (861-920 A.D.). Narayanapala (866-920 A.D.), the son of Vigrahapala I, ruled for the longest time. But he was weak and inactive. After him, Rajyapala (920-952 A.D.) and Gopala II (952-979 A.D.) ascended the throne one after another. None of them were worthy enough to be successors of the Pala Dynasty; as a result the Empire started to break down and its territory started to shrink.

When the Pala Empire was on the verge of destruction, Mahipala I (995-1043 A.D.), son of Gopala II (969-995 A.D.), came forward with a ray of hope. He liberated North and West Bengal from the clutches of foreign powers and founded the capital in Mahipal in present-day Murshidabad. He checked the fall of the Pala Empire and brought back its former glory. But Mahipala could not leave a worthy successor. With his death the empire broke down immediately. After him, his son Nayapala (1043-1058 A.D.) and his grandson Mahipala III (1058-1075 A.D.) ascended the throne. They could not protect the empire from foreign attacks. Bihar, outside Bengal began to slip away. During the reign of Mahipala III, the Pala Empire in Bengal broke into many pieces.

The difficult situation became comparatively tense in the reign of Mahipala II (1075-1080 A.D.). The landlords of North Bengal openly revolted in the Barendra region which is known as the "Kaivarta" rebellion in history. Mahipala II was killed by the rebels and the Kaivarta (Hitya or Divyak) captured power in the Barendra region.

In the meantime, Surapala II, the younger brother of Mahipala II, ascended the Pala throne. He ruled for two years. Thereafter, his youngest brother, Rampala (1082-1124 A.D.) became the ruler. He was the last successful ruler of Pala Dynasty. The ancient poet of Bengal, Jankar Nandi, wrote a biography of Rampala called *Ramcharita*. We can learn about the Pala Empire from it.

Rampala tried to recover Barendra from the clutches of the Kaivartas. He failed in the first attempt. Later he went for the second attempt with the help of the kings of fourteen regions, including Rashtrakuta, Magadha and Rahr who helped him with soldiers, arms and money. In the end the Kaivarta king Bhima was defeated and killed. Rampala tried to bring peace to the region after recovering Barendra. He established a new capital called Ramavati near the present-day Maldah. In order to regain the lost glory, he exercised supremacy over Magadha and Rahr. But it was unfortunate that the succeeding Pala kings were very weak. It was not possible for them to save the Pala Empire. After Rampala, Kumara Pala (1124-1129 A.D.), Mahipala III (1129-1143 A.D.) and Madana Pala (1143-1161 A.D.) ascended the throne of the Pala Empire one after another. Some historians pointed out that there was one more king of

the Pala Dynasty after Madana Pala named Govindapala; though the span of his reign cannot be exactly determined. However, during this time, warfare became an everyday affair. As a result, decadence began which gradually led to the collapse of the Pala Dynasty.

The Independent Kingdom of South-East Bengal ✓

The South-East Bengal was independent most of the time during the time of the Pala Dynasty. The region was in the "Banga" Janapada of the ancient time. From the middle of the seventh century A.D. many dynasties ruled in this region.

The Kharga Dynasty: Founded in South-East Bengal (Tripura and Noakhali) in the second half of the seventh century; the capital was "Karmanta Vasaka", supposed to be the original name of "Bara Kamta" of Comilla.

The Deva Dynasty: Founded in the same region in the eighth century, succeeding the Kharga Dynasty. Renowned kings of this family were Sri Shanti Deva, Sri Ananda Deva and Bhadradeva. They were also Buddhists. Their capital was in Deva Parbata near Mainair, Comilla. The kingdom was extended throughout the whole of the Samatata region. A famous Buddhist monastery "Ananda Vihara" was built by King Ananda Deva. The kings ruled approximately from 740 A.D. to 800 A.D.

The Kingdom of Kanti Deva: An independent state, founded by King Kanti Deva, at the ninth century in Harikela and South Bengal. The present day Sylhet was the kingdom's capital was Burdwanpur – which has no existence today. No descendants of this Buddhist king have been found. This kingdom was succeeded by the Chandra Dynasty.

The Chandra Dynasty: The most powerful independent kingdom of South-East Bengal. It ruled for about 150 years. Its founder was Purna Chandra, succeeded by his son Soma Chandra, and later by his grandson Trailokya Chandra – the first powerful king of this line.

Its main center was the Lalmai hills of Comilla, known as Rohitagiri then. Trailokya Chandra (900-930 A.D.) occupied the whole of East and South-East Bengal. Later, his son Som Chandra (930-975 A.D.) extended the kingdom upto North-East Kamrupa and Gaur in the north, setting up the capital in Vikramapura.

The other kings of this family were Kalyan Chandra (975-1000 A.D.), Ladaha Chandra (1000-1020 A.D.) and Govinda Chandra (1020-1045 A.D.). The dynasty fell when the Sena Dynasty and Kalchuri Dynasty attacked Banga.

The Varmaraja Dynasty: Established at the end of the eleventh century in South Bengal. They are supposed to come to this country with Karna, the king of Kalchuri Dynasty was founded by Jatavarma, the son of Brajavarma. Their capital was in Vikramapura. The kingdom was succeeded by Harivarma, who ruled for 46 years and extended the kingdom upto Nagabhumi (Nagaland) and Assam. The subsequent kings were Shyama and Bhojavarma. The Varma family perished soon after King Vijay Sena of the Sena Dynasty occupied South-East Bengal in the middle of twelfth century.

Dynasty (1070-1230 A.D.) ✓

The Sena Empire was a Hindu dynasty that ruled from Bengal through the 11th and early 12th centuries. The empire at its peak covered much of the north-eastern region of the Indian subcontinent. The rulers of the Sena Dynasty traced their origin to the south Indian region of Karnataka of the Deccan. According to some, they were Brahmakhatryia. At first they were scholars. Later when they became skilled in warfare, they earned the title "Khatrya".

The founder of Sena Dynasty was Samanta Sena, who came to Bengal in his old age, making settlement in the Rahr region on the bank of the river Ganges. As he did not establish a kingdom, the honor of being a king was given to his son Hemanta Sena. Thus Hemanta Sena (1098) is regarded as the founder of Sena Empire, who was supposed to be a feudal lord under the Pala Emperor Rampala. His successor Vijay Sena (1098-1160 A.D.) helped in the foundations of the dynasty, and had an unusually long reign of over 60 years. He ruled East and South Bengal under his reign defeating the Varma king. Then he conquered West Bengal, Kamrupa, Kalinga and Mithila. His first capital was Vijayapura in Hooghly district. The second capital was established in Vikramapura.

Vallala Sena (1160-1178 A.D.), son of Vijay Sena, conquered Gaur from the Pala, became the ruler of the Bengal Delta, and made Nabadwip the capital as well. Vallala Sena married a princess of the Western Chalukya Empire which indicates that the Sena rulers had close social contact with South India.

Lakhshmana Sena (1178-1206 A.D.) succeeded Vallala Sena, ruled Bengal and expanded the empire to Assam, Odisha, Bihar, Proyaga, and probably to Varanasi. Coming to the end of his reign Lakhshmana Sena became quite weak. As a result, the feudal lords around him started to revolt. Well known rebel kings of that time were Dommanpala of Sundarban area and A D L. Pattikera of South-East Bengal and King Ranabankamalla Deva.

At the beginning of the thirteenth century, the Muslim power from the North began to proceed into Bengal. The Muslim commander Ikhtiaruddin Muhammad Bakhtiar Khalji attacked the second capital of Sena Dynasty. Being defeated Lakhshmana Sena fled to East Bengal. North and North-West Bengal went under the Muslim rule. Lakhshmana Sena ruled for two years and died in 1206 A.D. Though the Sena rule continued for some time more, it is very well said that with the defeat of Lakhshmana Sena the Sena rule in Bengal came to an end.

Medieval Age ✓

The Medieval Age in Bengal started in the thirteenth century. The main feature of this age is the end of the Hindu and Buddhist rule and the establishment of the Muslim rule in Bengal. In 1206 A.D. the Turkish hero Bakhtiar Khalji conquered Bihar near Bengal. The inhabitants of Bihar were very afraid of the Turkish. The trained warrior Bakhtiar Khalji chose to go through the jungle of Jharkhand instead of the mountain pass of Teliaghri. He divided his army into small groups and entered Nadia with the first group consisting 17 or 18 men. The people of Nadia thought that a band of horse merchant has come, so nobody fought them. Bakhtiar Khalji occupied the Palace of Lakhshmana Sena; there rose a hue and

city, the other soldiers entered Nadia and Lakhshmana Sena fled to East Bengal. Thus came into the hands of the Muslims.

In 1205 A.D. Bakhtiar Khalji took hold of the famous capital of Sena Devakota. He renamed it as Lakhnauti. But he established the capital at Devakota. He failed in the expedition of Tilaiyati and did not enter into Bengal any farther. He died in 1206 A.D.

Bakhtiar Khalji wanted to establish independent rule in Bengal permanently, so he divided the conquered region into number of provinces or districts called "Ikta". He established mosques and madrasahs for the development of Muslim society and culture. Thus began Muslim rule in Bengal.

The Turkish Rule (1204-1338 A.D.) ✓

The rulers of this period were not fully independent. Some of them who came as slaves were Khalji Malliks, while others were rulers of Turkish blood appointed by the Sultan of Delhi. Later many rulers revolted against Delhi and attempted to be independent. But they failed in the end. The historian from Delhi, Ziauddin Barani named Bengal as "Bulgha" which means "City of Rebellion".

In 1208, Bakhtiar Khalji's fellow warrior Hushamuddin Iwaj Khalji became the ruler of Devakota. Later he voluntarily handed over the rule to Ali Mardan Khalji. Ali Mardan took the name of Alauddin Ali Mardan Khalji and declared independence in 1210 A.D. But he was a very stern ruler. As a result, the Khalji Malliks revolted against him and killed him. Iwaj Khalji came to the power of Bengal for the second time as an independent Sultan in the name of Giasuddin Iwaj Khalji. He ruled from 1212 A.D. to 1227 A.D. He expanded the Muslim rule in Bengal, introduced coins bearing his name and built many mosques, madrasahs, roads. The credit of building the first naval force in Bengal goes to him. But the Sultan of Delhi apparently did not accept Bengal becoming independent in such a manner. Iwaj Khalji was killed in 1227 A.D. by the soldiers of Sultan Iltutmish.

After his death, the "Slave Rule" started in Bengal, when Bengal was reduced to a province of the Muslim Sultan of Delhi upto 1287 A.D. Ten of the fifteen rulers of that time were "Mamluks" or slaves. They all were of Turkish origin, so it can be called the Age of Turkish Rule. During that time, there was internal conflict in Delhi; so the Turkish rulers ruled independently. The first Turkish ruler was Nasiruddin Mahmud, the son of Sultan Iltutmish. He was succeeded by Daulat Shah Bin Moudad. The conflict in Delhi started with the death of Sultan Iltutmish in 1236 A.D. Awor Khan Aibek captured power in Lakhnauti. But the ruler of Bihar, Tughral Tughan Khan defeated him and ruled Bengal till 1245 A.D. The rulers were as follows:

1. Omar Khan (1245-1247 A.D.)
2. Jalaluddin Masud Jani (1247-1251 A.D.)
3. Malik Ikhtiaruddin Uzbek "Mughisuddin" (1251- 1257 A.D.); ruler of Bengal. He expanded the frontier; was killed.
4. Malik Izzauddin Uzbek (1257-1259 A.D.); independent.
5. Tazuddin Arsalan Khan; ruler of the Kara Province; became the ruler in 1269 A.D.
6. Tatar Khan; first pledged allegiance to Delhi, later cut off relation in a few years. He was succeeded by Sher Khan for some time.

Tughril "Mughisuddin"; greatest of the Mamluk Turks. Brought North and West Bengal, Dhaka and some region of Faridpur under rule. Built the fort "Narkilla" or "Tughril's Killa" near Sonargaon; declared independence. Was attacked by Sultan Balban of Delhi, and defeated and killed in 1281 A.D.

After Balban appointed his son Bughra Khan as the Governor of Bengal. After Balban's death in 1287 A.D. Bughra Khan took up the name of Nasiruddin Mahmud Shah and became independent Sultan of Bengal. His son Kaikobad was the Sultan of Delhi. At the news of Kaikobad's death, disheartened Bughra Khan handed over the throne to his other son Alauddin Kaikaus (1291-1300 A.D.). After Kaikaus, Malik Firoz Iqin became the Sultan. The new name of Shamsuddin Firoz Shah, followed by his son Giasuddin Bahadur Shah. He was made a prisoner by the Sultan of Delhi, Giasuddin Tughlak, later was freed in 1325 A.D. and sent to Sonargaon. There he ruled jointly with Bahram Khan. In 1328 A.D. Bahadur Shah revolted and was killed by Bahram Khan. Henceforth, Bengal remained under control of Delhi upto 1338 A.D.

The Independent Sultanate (1338-1538 A.D.)

The ruler of Sonargaon, Bahram Khan died in 1338. The armourer of him was Fakhrhah, who was a royal employee. He declared independence and ascended the throne of Sonargaon with the name Fakhruddin Mubarak Shah. It was the beginning of the independent Sultanate in Bengal. The Sultan of Delhi, Muhammad bin Tughlak, has no time to look into the matters in Bengal. Kader Khan, the ruler of Lakhnauti and Izzauddin, the ruler of Satgaon jointly attacked Sonargaon, but they failed. Kader Khan was defeated and killed by the soldiers of Fakhruddin.

From the dates engraved on the coins issued by Fakhruddin, it is supposed that he ruled Sonargaon from 1338 A.D. to 1349 A.D. He extended the area of his kingdom in the North-East direction. He conquered Chittagong and built a highway from Chandpur to Chittagong. 1440 A.D. coins were issued from the mint of Sonargaon having the name of Ikhtiar Gazi (known as the son of Fakhruddin) inscribed on them; these coins dated upto 1352 A.D. have been found. Gazi Shah ruled Sonargaon for three years after the death of his father in 1352 A.D.

Iltutmish, brother of Alauddin Ali Shah – the ruler of Lakhnauti, defeated and killed Ikhtiar Gazi in 1352 A.D. and ascended the throne of Pandua (Firozabad) becoming the master of South and North-West Bengal. He brought Satgaon under his sway in 1346 A.D. and also ruled Nepal and conquered some portions of Trihut and North Bihar. Finally in 1352 A.D. he defeated Ikhtiaruddin Gazi Shah and established a Dynasty in Bengal. The conquest of Bengal was made complete with this. Described as "Shah-e-Bangalah" and "Shah-e-Bangladesh" by the historian of Delhi Shams-e-Shiraj Afif, Iltutmish Shah conquered some parts of Tripura, Garoakpur and Kashi outside Bengal.

The Sultan of Delhi, Firoz Shah Tughlak waged war against Iltutmish Shah from November 1353 to September 1354 A.D. He was not successful and had to accept the independence of Bengal. He made friendship with Iltutmish Shah and returned to Delhi. When Sikander Shah (1393 A.D.) succeeded his father, Firoz Shah Tughlak again attacked Bengal from 1358 to 1360 A.D. and failed once again. The independent Sultanate in Bengal was continued by Sikander Shah. His son Giasuddin Azam Shah (1393-1411 A.D.) was the

most popular Sultan of the age. He could keep united the vast kingdom without any as an able ruler.

The Rule of the Dynasty of Raja Ganesh

The independent Sultanate in Bengal did not continue for two hundred years at a There was a short interval in the long period. After Giasuddin Azam's death, Saifuddin Hamza Shah ascended the throne in 1411 A.D. But he was killed by his Shihabuddin in 1412 A.D. as a result of a conspiracy. Shihabuddin became the Sultan Shihabuddin Bayazid Shah, and got murdered too in two years. Taking this advantage Ganesh, a high official of Azam Shah assumed power of Bengal.

Ganesh put to death many Muslim Sufis and Saints. Sultan Ibrahim Sharki of Jaunpur forward to save the Muslims. Frightened, Ganesh compromised with Dervish leader Kutub; made his son Jadu accept the religion of Islam, changing Jadu's name to Jalal Mahmud; and left the throne in his charge in the middle of 1415 A.D.

After Sharki's leave, Ganesh again ascended the throne and brought his son back Hindu faith. But Ganesh died in 1418 A.D. and Jadu succeeded the throne as Jalal Mahmud Shah again; he was a devoted Muslim. Jalaluddin Mahmud ruled till 1432 A.D. moved the capital to Gaur from Pandua. He was succeeded by his son Shamsuddin Shah, who was killed by his slave Nasir Khan in 1433 A.D. Thus ended the thirty years of Raja Ganesh and his descendents.

Later Ilias Shahi Rulers

The elite society became agitated because a slave had murdered his master and ascended throne. They united attacked and killed Nasir Khan. In 1452 A.D. they placed on the throne of Bengal Nasir Shah, a descendent of Ilias Shah. He is known as Nasiruddin Mahmud in history.

Nasiruddin Mahmud Shah (1452-1459 A.D.): The boundaries of Bengal extended.

Rukanuddin Barbak Shah (1459-1474 A.D.): Son of Nasiruddin Mahmud, appointed of Satgaon. He employed about eight thousand slaves in different offices.

Shamsuddin Abu Zafar Yusuf Shah (1474-1481 A.D.): Son of Barbak Shah, an ideal competent ruler. After him, his son Sikander Shah ascended the throne. But he was removed because of his sickness.

Jalaluddin Fateh Shah (1481- 1487 A.D.): Younger brother of Yusuf Shah. There was internal chaos in the Royal court. The slaves imported by his predecessors became powerful. Fateh Shah lost his life while attempting to curb their power.

The Habshi Rule (1487-1493 A.D.)

This period was filled with lawlessness, injustice, conspiracy, rebellion and despair. All four Habshi Sultans were killed during this period.

Barbak Shahjuda: Habshi leader, first to ascend the throne, was killed within a few months.

Ismuddin Firoz Shah: Originally slave Commander Malik Andil, killed Barbak Shahjada. Ruled for three years with glory. Later was killed by the Palace Guards.

Nasiruddin Mahmud Shah II: Third Habshi ruler was killed after reigning for some time.

Giasuddin Muzaffar Shah (1491-1493 A.D.): Slave leader, killer of Nasiruddin II. Tyrant and murderer. Nobles of Gaur revolted against him. His minister joined hands with the rebels. Ultimately he was killed and it ended the Habshi rule in Bengal.

Hussain Shahi Dynasty (1493-1538 A.D.) ✓

Ismuddin Hussain Shah (1493-1519 A.D.): Originally known as Syed Hussain, belonged to a Syed family of Arabia; the founder of Hussain Shahi Dynasty – the most successful one among the independent Sultans of Bengal.

He was the greatest Sultan of this dynasty. He conquered Kamrupa, Kamta, some parts of Assam and Tripura, and parts of North and South Bihar. He drove away the Arakanians from Chittagong, but failed in the expedition of Assam. Sikander Lodi, the Sultan of Delhi attacked Bengal during this time, but could not succeed. Hussain Shah was successful in taking all sorts of security measures for his vast kingdom. He died in 1519.

Nusrat Shah; later Nasiruddin Abul Mazaffar Nusrat Shah (1519-1531 A.D.): Son of Hussain Shah. Almost the whole of Bihar came under his sway. It was the time when Mughal Empire established in India. The first Mughal Emperor Babur sent an expedition to Bengal. Nusrat Shah first made friendship with him; but when war broke out, he concluded a treaty with Babur and made the throne of Bengal safe. Bengal had conflicts with the state of Ahom. Nusrat Shah was assassinated in 1531.

Ismuddin Firoz Shah (1531-1533 A.D.): Son of Nusrat Shah, ruled for about one year. The conflict with Ahom continued. Decline of the independent Sultanate began during his reign. He was killed in 1533.

Ismuddin Mahmud Shah (1533-1538 A.D.): Brother of Nusrat Shah, killed Firoz Shah and ascended the throne. Could not bring peace in the kingdom. He kept indulging in fights with Afghan leader Sher Shah Shuri, until Sher Shah captured Gaur in 1538. With Giasuddin's death, the 200 years of the independent rule of Bengal ended. The foreign powers began to attack Bengal one after another.

The Rule of the Afghans and the Mughals in Bengal ✓

Mughal Emperor Humayun occupied the capital of Bengal for a short period. He had to retreat after defeat at the hands of Sher Shah. Bengal and Bihar directly came in the hands of the Afghans. The two sections of the Afghans, Shur Afghans and Karrani Afghans ruled Bengal for quite some time. At last, the Mughal Emperor Akbar snatched the power of Bengal from the Afghans. But the Mughals could not establish their rule throughout Bengal for a long time. At that time, there were a number of big independent 'Zamindars' in Bengal. These lords known as 'Barabhuynas' did not recognize the supremacy of the Mughals. The Zamindars failed, later the 'Barabhuynas' were subdued during the reign of Jahangir.

The Afghan Rule (1538-1576 A.D.) ✓

The founder of the Afghan rule in Bengal was Sher Khan Shur. His father Hasna Khan was the Jagirdar of Sassaram in Bihar. After his death, Sher Khan became the Jagirdar and also assumed the guardianship of the Jagirdar of Bihar, Jalal Khan as he was still a minor.

Sher Khan dreamt of being the lord of the whole of India. He began to increase his power secretly. He occupied Chunar, Bihar and Bengal in a short time. The Mughal Emperor Humayun then became alert. The Mughals failed to bring Bengal under their control because of the Afghan resistance. Humayun was locked in war with Sher Khan. He snatched away the fort of Chunar and Bihar from Sher Khan; he also occupied the capital of Bengal, Gaur. Being charmed by the beautiful Palace and the natural beauty of Gaur, he named it 'Jannatabad' and indulged in merrymaking for six months. In the meantime Sher Khan tried to increase his power. News came from Delhi that the step-brother of Humayun, Hindal, was plotting to seize the throne. Hearing the news Humayun started for Delhi. Sher Khan availed himself for the opportunity. He laid ambush in Chausa near Buxar. When Humayun reached there on the bank of the river Ganges, Sher Khan fell upon him. Taken aback, Humayun was defeated.

Sher Khan took up the title "Sher Shah" after defeating Humayun and declared himself an independent Sultan of Bihar. In 1540 he defeated the Mughal administrator Ali Kuli and occupied Bengal. In that same year he occupied the throne of Delhi by defeating Humayun. After a long time Bengal again went under the rule of Delhi. The whole Bengal, Chittagong and Sylhet came under the domain of Sher Shah. The rule of Bengal during this period was called the rule of the Shur Afghan Dynasty after the title of Sher Shah.

Bengal remained under Delhi upto the reign of Islam Shah (1545-1553 A.D.), son of Sher Shah. After him, the Delhi Empire began to crumble due to factionalism among Afghan leaders. At this opportunity the Afghan ruler Muhammad Shah Shur declared independence of Bengal. He was defeated by the Sultan of Delhi, Muhammad Adil Shah Shur. The rule of Bengal extended upto Arakan.

When Muhammad Shah Shur was killed in 1555, his son Bahadur Shah Shur ascended the throne of Gaur. He killed his master Adil Shah Shur, the killer of his father. After his death his brother Jalal Shah became the Sultan of Gaur. Thereafter one Giasuddin Karrani killed the son of Jalal Shah and seized the throne of Bengal. Thus the rule of the Karrani Afghans began, ending the Shur Afghan rule.

Taj Khan Karrani was the commander and counselor of Islam Shah. He conquered Bengal in 1564 A.D. After his death, his brother Sulaiman Karrani became the Sultan of Bengal. This efficient ruler gathered all Afghan leaders to his side and established his authority in Bengal, Bihar and Orissa. He maintained good relation with the Mughal Emperor Akbar. After Sulaiman died in 1572 A.D. his son Bayazid ascended the throne. In a short time this ruler was put to death by the Afghan leaders. Sulaiman's second son Daud Karrani

held the throne. He was the last Afghan ruler in Bengal. He was an imprudent ruler. The empire, wealth and riches made him feel equivalent to Emperor Akbar. By then the East Bengal and Bihar pledged allegiance openly to the Mughal Emperor. On the other hand, Daud Khan Karrani assumed the title 'Badshah' and also issued coins bearing his name.

The Afghans had already been enemies of the Mughals and Emperor Akbar also was not at ease. As Bengal and Bihar were not under the Mughal authority, the conduct of Daud Karrani provided a pretext to Akbar to attack Bengal. The ruler of Jaunpur, Munim Khan was ordered to attack Bengal, but Daud compromised with him on the advice of minister Lodi. Later, Lodi was killed in 1573 A.D. at the behest of Daud due to the advice of some conspirators. Munim Khan then drove away the Afghans from Bihar. He conquered the capital of Bengal, Tanda. Then the Mughal army proceeded to Saptagram in Hooghly where the Afghans took shelter. Daud then fled to Orissa. But Munim Khan along with many Mughal soldiers died of cholera. Consequently there was disorder and anarchy. Taking advantage of this situation Daud Karrani again took hold of West and North Bengal. On the other hand, Issa Khan, the ruler of the low lying areas, drove away the Mughal soldiers from East Bengal. The Mughal soldiers then left Bengal and took shelter in Bihar.

On getting this news, Emperor Akbar sent Khan Jahan Hussain Kuli Khan as the ruler of Bengal. Raja Todormal was appointed his assistant. Daud Karrani intercepted the Mughal forces at Rajmahal, the Gateway to Bengal. Muzaffar Khan Tarbati, ruler of Bihar came to the aid of the Mughals. In 1576 A.D. a fierce battle was fought between the Mughals and the forces of Daud at Rajmahal. Daud Karrani suffered a crushing defeat and was sentenced to death. Thus the Mughal rule was introduced in Bengal. Of course, the Mughal rule could not be extended very far in the face of the resistance offered by the 'Barabhuynas'.

History of Barabhuynas

Emperor Akbar could not establish authority over the whole of Bengal. The big Zamindars of Bengal did not accept the subordination of the Mughals. The independent and powerful Zamindars fought united against the Mughal commanders to protect their land. They were known as Barabhuynas, where 'Bara' does not mean the number of twelve, rather defines the definite number of Zamindars.

Uzir Khan was the Zamindar of Sonargaon, the low land known as 'Vati' region and the head of Barabhuynas. He was loyal to the Karrani Dynasty. The Gazi family established Zamindars in Bhawal before the conquest of Bengal by Sher Shah. Similarly, big Zamindars were established in the regions of Faridpur, Sylhet, Mymensingh, Vikrampur, Jessore, Hoakhati, Manikganj, etc.

Emperor Akbar gave special attention to subdue the Barabhuynas. He sent Shahbaz Khan in 1584 A.D., Jandut Khan in 1585 A.D., Uzir Khan in 1586 A.D. and Raja Mansingh in 1594 A.D. as subadars in Bengal. They fought a number of battles with Issa Khan and other Zamindars. But they could not defeat him. After Issa Khan's death in 1599 A.D. his son

Musa Khan became the leader of the Barabhuynas. Mansingh was sent to Bengal for the second time in 1601 A.D. But he had to return to Delhi hearing the news of Akbar's illness before the final success achieved.

After the death of Akbar, Jahangir became the Mughal Emperor. During his reign, the Barabhuynas were subdued completely. The claimant of the success was Subadar Islam Khan (1608-1613 A.D.). He shifted the capital of Bengal from Rajmahal to Dhaka with the intention of suppressing the Barabhuynas. Musa Khan's base was at Sonargaon, not far from Dhaka. On his way from Rajmahal to Dhaka, Islam Khan won the allegiance of many Zamindars on the way. He built a strong navy to face the Barabhuynas. The first fight between Musa Khan and Islam Khan took place in 1609 A.D. in Jatrapur on the eastern bank of the River Karatola. Musa Khan had a fort there. In the battle that followed, Musa Khan and other Zamindars were forced to retreat. Islam Khan entered Dhaka in 1610 A.D. From this time Dhaka became the capital of Bengal and was named Jahangirnagar after the Emperor.

The naval force of the Zamindars assembled on the river Sitalakhya under the leadership of Musa Khan. The fort 'Kadam Rasul' of Musa Khan, situated on the eastern bank of the river, was captured by the Mughals. Musa Khan retreated to Sonargaon. The Mughals finally occupied Sonargaon. Thereafter the Zamindars were forced to surrender. Subadar Islam Khan was very generous. He behaved very courteously with Musa Khan. He appointed Musa Khan in his own Zamindari as a representative of the Mughals. Musa Khan passed the rest of his life as a loyal representative of the Mughals.

Many Zamindars were disappointed at the surrender of Musa Khan. After that all the Zamindars pledged allegiance to the Mughals one after another. This ended the rule of the Barabhuynas.

The Mughal Rule in Bengal ✓

The rule of the Mughals in Bengal was divided into two periods.

1. **Rule of the Subadars:** The Mughal provinces were known as 'Subas'. Bengal became a Suba after the defeat of the Barabhuynas. Its golden phase was from the seventeenth to early eighteenth century. After Aurangzeb, the Mughal rule in Bengal became weak in the hands of his weak successors. Taking advantage of this, the Subadars of Bengal were ruling independently.
2. **Rule of the Nawabs:** The independent rule of the Subadars is known as the rule of the Nawabs. This continued upto 1757 A.D. for almost half a century.

The Rule of the Subadars in Bengal

Islam Khan introduced the rule of the Subadars in Bengal in 1610 A.D. after he suppressed the Barabhuynas. Many Subadars ruled in Bengal, but no one could survive before Mir Jumla's reign. The description is as follows:

Khan (1610-1613 A.D.): The first Subadar in Bengal.

Khan Chisti (1613-1617 A.D.): Ascended the throne after Islam Khan's death.

Khan Fateh Jang (1617-1624 A.D.): Brother of Empress Nurjahan of Delhi. He succeeded by Darar Khan, Mohabbat Khan, Mukarram Khan and Fidal Khan (1628 A.D.).

Khan Jumi (1628-1635 A.D.): Appointed by Emperor Shahjahan. The Portuguese increased in number and eventually posed a threat to Bengal since the time of Hussain Khan suppressed them with a strong hand.

Khan Mashadi (1635-1639 A.D.): Ruled for four years.

Suja (1659-1659 A.D.): Second son of Emperor Shahjahan. Quite peaceful reign. The merchants enjoyed special favours during this time, and they increased their power. Emperor Shahjahan fell sick in 1657 A.D., his four sons revolted because each wanted the Emperor. In the battle of the two brothers, Aurangzeb and Shah Suja, Suja was killed in 1659 A.D.

Aurangzeb (1660-1663 A.D.): Came to Bengal to subdue Suja. Emperor Aurangzeb made him Subadar of Bengal. As an efficient Subadar, he annexed Assam and Cooch Bihar to Mughal Empire. Was succeeded by Dilir Khan and Daud Khan Abbasi after his death.

Jahan Khan (1664-1678 A.D., September 1679-1688 A.D.): Maternal uncle of Aurangzeb, a very efficient and farsighted administrator. He drove away the Portuguese and occupied Chittagong. Towards the end of his reign, there was a dispute with the East India Company. After a prolonged attempt he drove away the English from stopping the growth of their power. After him, Khan Jahan Bahadur, Ibrahim Khan and Muhammad became Subadars (1688-1717), but were not very efficient.

Murshid Kuli Khan (1717-1727 A.D.): Formerly Diwan of Bengal came to power as an efficient Subadar during the reign of Emperor Farruk Shiar. Famous for the reformation of the revenue system.

After the death of Aurangzeb, the weak emperors could not give attention to the distant provinces. The Subadars were quite independent. Murshid Kuli Khan was not any difference. He paid loyalty to the Emperor only by name and used to send him an amount of one crore lakhs rupees annually as taxes. From his time Bengal was almost independent the Nawabs started.

Rule of the Nawabs (1727-1757 A.D.) ✓

From this time known as the "Nawabat of Bengal". Suba was then called 'Nizamat' and the Subadar was called 'Nazim'. It became hereditary. The Nazims only received a nominal authority from the Mughal Emperor on ascending the throne. Murshid Kuli Khan was the first Nazim of Bengal.

Sujauddin Khan (1727-1739 A.D.): The husband of Murshid Kuli's daughter Zinatun-Nessa, as Murshid Kuli had no son. He was the first independent Nawab of Bengal, Bihar and Orissa. Appointed his relatives and trustworthy people in high officers; had good relations with the Zamindars. But in his later life he faced many conspiracies of his courtiers, which he faced them boldly.

Sarfaraz Khan (1739-1740 A.D.): Son of Sujauddin, an inefficient ruler. The whole country was in disorder. Was succeeded by Alivardi Khan.

Alivardi Khan (1740-1756 A.D.): Took the power of Bengal not by the authority of the Mughal Emperor, but by sheer power of arms. He established peace in Bengal. From 1740 A.D. to 1751 A.D. he fought for ten years and finally made the Marathi bandits 'Bargis' leave the country. He suppressed the revolting Afghan soldiers with a strong hand. He also checked the activities of many European merchants who began to gather military power.

Siraj-ud-Doula (1756-1757 A.D.): Son of the youngest daughter of Alivardi Khan, Asmat Begum. Was nominated by Alivardi Khan. The first daughter of Alivardi, Ghasheti Begum, started conspiracy to see Shaukat Jang, the son of her second sister, as the Nawab. She got the support from some nobles. Roy Durlav, Jagat Seth, Mir Zafar, Umi Chand, Raj Ballal etc. were among them. The English merchants manipulated the court politics. They joined hands with the conspirators.

The Battle of Plassey

A battle between the Nawabs and the English was inevitable. Thus, in 1757, the famous Battle of Plassey began. Mir Zafar, the Commander-in-Chief of the Nawab absented himself from taking part in the battle. Everything was the conspiracy of the English merchants, the fraud nobles. Siraj-ud-Doula suffered defeat miserably. He tried to save his life by escaping from Murshidabad. But he was caught, and ultimately was murdered by Muhammad Ali Beg.

Boxer Conclusion

With the death of Nawab Siraj-ud-Doula, the foundation of the English rule was laid. The merchants of English East India Company established the English rule in Bengal by annihilating the conspirators one by one. Thus Bengal lost her independence through the Battle of Plassey, which worked as the foundation of the two hundred years long European Colonization in the Indian subcontinent.

Rise of Islam in Bengal

Islam (in Bengal) came to Bengal comparatively late. Within about one hundred years of its birth, Islam penetrated into northwestern India, and Arabian traders came into contact with coastal regions of India, including Bengal. But it took about five hundred years for Muslim political power to reach Bengal. According to unconfirmed traditions, some Muslim sufi-saints came to Bengal even before the political conquest, but Islam actually entered in full force with Turkish conquest towards the beginning of the 13th century. Bangladesh is today a Muslim majority country; about 90% of her population belongs to the Islamic faith.

During the first three hundred years or so of Muslim rule, the Turks of one or the other group - the Iltutmishs, the Iltutmishs and the Qaraunahs, ruled Bengal. The Abyssinian slaves occupied the throne for a few years in the late 15th century and then came successively the Sayyids, the Barids and the Mughals. So broadly speaking, the Muslim rulers of Bengal belonged to three main groups - the Turks, the Afghans and the Mughals. The last were originally linked with the Turks.

Islam entered Bengal both by land and water. By land the Turkish conquerors came with their political culture and concept of governance, while the Arab traders came through waterway. The Arabs came with their religion and culture, with a purpose different from that of the Turks. The influence of the Arabs in some parts of Bengal, particularly in the coastal region of Chittagong is remembered through traditions. But the Arabs probably did not affect the society as was done by the Turkish conquerors.

The Turks came with the avowed intention of establishing political power. The Arabs came to Bengal in the trading season, and left when the season was over. But for the Turkish conquerors the intention was different. They conquered, established a kingdom and a government and took steps to strengthen their position. Ever since the establishment of the first Muslim kingdom in Bengal there was a continuous flow of Muslims into Bengal. There came the scholars, who were, in fact the backbone of political power; the religious learned people, the Ulema, the Ulama and the Mashayikhs to disseminate religion; the civil servants, experts in administration, finance and governance; the traders and businessmen, and also the artisans and labourers. They all came in search of employment and /or better livelihood. The Mongol conquest of the Baghdad Caliphate in the thirteenth century led to widespread displacement of Muslim Muslims, who took refuge in the capitals of Delhi and LAKHNAU. They even

spread to the outlying places. Muslims coming from the cultural centres of central Asia were welcomed; they were known as *al-izza* ('respectable') and given suitable employment. When the Muslim Kingdom was established in Lakhnauti, it was, theoretically at least, a part of the Abbasid Caliphate. Though the caliph's power was dwindling, he was considered the supreme spiritual head of Sunni Muslims all over. The Muslims of Bengal also shared this view and some early Muslim sultans of Bengal actually imprinted the names of Abbasid caliphs on their coins. Some others, who did not actually inscribe the name of the caliph, assumed titles denoting their allegiance to the institution of the Caliphate. Be it may, the Muslim kingdom of Bengal in the pre-Mughal period was for all practical purposes an independent kingdom. During this whole period, the Bengal rulers took the title of Sultan, thus proclaiming the character of the Kingdom as a Sultanate. Some Bengal sultans also took the title of Khalifah themselves. The Caliphate of Baghdad came to an end long before the establishment of Mughal rule in India (or in Bengal). So they had nothing to do with that institution. The Mughals took the imperial title of *shahinshah* (king of the kings), and they gave the title of sultan to their princes. Bengal, or Subah Bangalah, was all through a province of the Mughal empire.

Islam, which came in the wake of the Turkish conquest, changed the socio-religious pattern of Bengal. Politically, it sowed the seeds of Muslim rule, but socially it planted a Muslim seed, opening the gate of Bengal to numerous immigrants from the then Muslim world, which affected the existing society enormously. Islam spread in Bengal in a lengthy process.

Bakhtyar's kingdom was only a nucleus and the Muslims took more than two hundred years to bring the whole of Bengal under their control. In 1338 Bengal witnessed the beginning of an independent Sultanate under **LAKHMEDDIN MUHAMMAD SHAH**. From this time onward, for nearly five hundred years, Bengal remained independent. This was a period of overall development of the country both politically and culturally. But the most important development of this period was that the country for the first time received a name, i.e. Bangalah. Before this there was no political unity of Bengal, no common name for the whole country. Bengal was known by the names of its different units, Gauda, Radha, Vanga etc. After Sultan Shamsuddin **MUHAMMAD** conquered all these three regions and united the whole of Bengal, the name Bangalah emerged and he earned for himself the title of Shah-i-Bangalah and Sultan-i-Bangalah. Henceforth, the Muslim kingdom of Bengal came to be known as the kingdom of Bangalah. Historians began to call the kingdom Bangalah instead of Lakhnauti, and foreigners also adopted this name, when came the Mughal subah Bangalah and the British province of Bengal.

pendent Sultanate saw the expansion of Muslim power which spread into every nook and corner of the country, up to KAMARUPA in the north, Tippiam in the east and the sea in the south. Durgam was conquered by Fakhruddin Mubarak Shah (1338-1349); Faridpur was captured by NASIRUDDIN MUHAMMAD SHAH (1415-1432) and renamed FATHABAD. Khan Jahan Khan ruled the Khulna-Jessore area under the Muslim rule in the reign of NASIRUDDIN MUHAMMAD SHAH (1415-1432) and RUKNUDDIN BARID SHAH (1459-1474) conquered it. The expansion of Muslim power in Bengal was now complete, and the Muslim kingdom of Lakhnauti founded by Muhammad BAKHTIYAR KHILJI was turned into the Muslim kingdom of Bengal. The Mughals took over this kingdom. After the death of AURANGZEB, Mughal power declined, Bengal like other provinces of the empire was ruled by more or less independently. This position continued up to the BATTLE OF PALASHI,

the establishment of Muslim rule was not an end in itself, for Muslim power had to be established in a country where a large number of non-Muslims had been living from time immemorial. These indigenous people were diametrically opposed to the incomers in every aspect of religious, social and cultural life; they were opposed not only in their fundamental beliefs but also in their day to day life from birth to death. So the Muslim rulers of Bengal, from beginning till the end, built up institutions to disseminate Islamic learning and culture through those who professed the Islamic faith. They built MASJIDS and KHANQAHs for this purpose. Mosques form an important feature of Islamic society and culture, because they afford opportunity to offer prayers, one of the five pillars of the Islamic faith. In fact when a new area was brought under control and a settlement was established, a mosque was built to facilitate offering of prayers by the Muslims. Hence numerous mosques were built during Muslim rules down to the 18th century; many of them are still extant so that they can be used as prayer houses, while many have been destroyed. Those that are still extant were pucca constructions, but there must have been a large number of mud houses or thatched houses built for offering prayers whose existence or numbers are not known.

Many of the Persian inscriptions still exist, either fixed on the walls of the mosques, or removed to museums or other safer places. The inscriptions reveal that the mosques were built at the initiative of rulers or their officers. The inscriptions generally begin with a verse of the Holy QURAN or a HADITH of the Prophet (Sm) or both, promising the

builder the rewards that await him in the next world for founding such religious institutions. The rulers therefore built mosques in full realisation of their performance of a religious duty. Similarly madrasahs or schools or colleges were built to afford facilities to young Muslims to receive education. Mosques also served as maktabas to impart elementary religious education to the children. There were many madrasahs to impart elementary education, and institutions of higher learning, particularly in the towns and cities. The rulers got the madrasahs built at state expense, but individual philanthropists also built some. Some of the institutions called dar-ul-khairat or bina-ul-khair, were residential institutions, where teachers and students were provided board and lodging. Religious persons like the Ulama and the Sufis also built Madrasahs, but they were state patronised. The higher institutions of learning imparted instructions on ilm-i-deen and ilm-i-shara. Ilm-i-deen or religious knowledge and ilm-i-shara or knowledge of shariah may mean many things. In those days, as in the present day, a person had to pursue his study up to a certain level to become an Alim, and the subjects which he had to study were the Quran, Hadith, Tasawwaf, Mantiq, Kalam, and such other subjects, and the Arabic and Persian languages.

Khanqahs were built to afford facilities to the sufi-saints to pursue their spiritual activities and their followers. They were built either by the rulers or by the Sufis themselves, but they received state patronage. Khanqahs of some of the very famous saints like Shaikh JALAL-UD-DIN FARUKI, SHAH JALAL, Shaikh NUR QUTB ALAM survives even today. Khanqahs of Sufis of the Mughal period are also extant. The Muslim rulers granted lands for the maintenance of mosques, madrasahs and khanqahs. They also granted lands to the Muslim learned people Ulama and Mashayikh for their sustenance. They were granted by way of imam (reward) and wazifa (stipends) and madad-i-maash (assistance for subsistence). The Ulama and Mashayikh therefore, enjoyed economic security so that they could engage themselves in the pursuit of knowledge and meditation. The Muslim rulers always encouraged Muslim Ulama, Sufis and other religious leaders, built religious institutions and thus helped the growth of a Muslim society in Bengal.

The building up of Muslim society in Bengal was a long process of gradual growth. The composition of the society quite naturally differed from century to century with the immigration of foreign Muslims and the conversion of local people. The early immigrants were turks, and they belonged to different stocks, like the Khaljis, the Ilbaris and the Qasimis. Their supporters also came from far-off places. Arabs and Persians also came, and included people from various professions and other trades. One Bengal sultan, Ruknuddin Barbak

employed a good number of Abyssinian slaves to guard the palace and the royal family, and this led to a new element in the Muslim society.

After the occupation of Delhi by the Mughals, the Afghans lost control over northern India and lost control over outlying provinces including Bengal. The Afghans also became rulers in Bengal and their supremacy continued for several decades. Then came the Mughals and a fresh wave of Muslim migration to Bengal started. Mughal supremacy in Bengal lasted for several hundred years. So long the Muslim immigrants in Bengal were almost all Sunnis, and Shias were few and far between. With the supremacy of the Mughals there came Iranians, mostly belonging to the Shia community.

Mughal **SAHIBDARS**, some of whom were of royal blood were highly cultured. Many high persons from Upper India and outside made their homes and settled in this rich province. The increase of oceanic communications between Bengal and the Persian Gulf after the 17th century, tempted cultured Shias, Persian scholars, physicians, philosophers and traders to come and settle in Bengal. A voyage from Bandar Abbas or Basra to Bengal was much easier and cheaper than the overland journey across upper India, either through the Afghan passes or via the port of Surat.

Though Shias started coming to Bengal after the Mughal conquest or even before, they came in great number from the beginning of the 17th century after **JAHANGIR**'s accession to the throne. After his marriage with Nur Jahan, a Shiaite lady, her family became the controlling force in Mughal politics. Members of that family also came to Bengal as subahdars and held other high posts. In the reigns of Jahangir and **SHAHJAHAN**, a large number of Persian scholars adorned the court of Bengal subahdars. Even the court of **SHAH SHUJA**, who was himself a Shia, was surrounded by a good number of Shia scholars. Of course, he had received his education under a Shia teacher and his wife and mother belonged to Shia families.

Mughal subahdars like **MIR JUMLA** and **SHAISTA KHAN** were Shias. They were accompanied to Bengal by many Shia followers who occupied important posts. Shaista Khan came to Bengal with half a dozen grown up children, who were all trained soldiers and efficient administrators. From the provincial capital down to the **SARKARS** and **PARGANAS**, from the revenue department to the rent receiving stations, Iranians and Shias were found thronging with Sunnis and others. From **MURSHID QULI KHAN** to **SIRAJUDDAULA**, i.e. till the 18th century, the subahdars or nawabs, as they were called then, were all Shias. During this time

the Shias became predominant in all branches of administration, in the army, navy (in the revenue and other departments).

The nawabs, particularly Murshid Quli Khan and his son-in-law ^{SHUJA-UDDIN KHAN}, appointed their relatives to the key positions of the state; during the time of ^{ALIVARDI KHAN}, though officials did go up the ladder, he also confined the most important offices to his relatives, particularly his family members, children of his brother who were all his sons-in-law, although initially Sunni Muslims predominated in Bengal society, during the closing Muslim rule they gradually yielded place to Shias.

Chittagong being an important seaport, the Arab, Persian and many other foreign traders came there for commerce and trade. Prospects of better livelihood in the newly conquered areas and prospects of lucrative trade were responsible for attracting foreign Muslims to this country. While some may have left, many settled here in Bengal. There were also cases of conversion of local people to Islam, the question of conversion is of special significance and will be taken up later in this essay. There were also the children of mixed marriages; many immigrants including the rulers accepted local wives and there are examples of children of such marriages attaining high ranks in society, according to the status of their respective fathers.

So it is found that there were many elements in Muslim society, the Turks, the Afghans, Mughals, the Arabs, the Persians, the local converts etc. How were these various groups integrated into the society? Foodgrain The earliest reference to different groups in society is found in a proclamation of Sultan FIRUZ SHAH TUGHLAQ issued to the people of LAKSHMIPUR on the eve of his invasion of Bengal in 1354 AD. The proclamation was addressed to the (i) Shaikhs, Ulama, Mashayikh and others of similar nature; (ii) the Khans, Maliks, Umara, Sadrs, Amirs and Maarif and their retinue and followers. A Hindu poet, writing in 1495 AD, refers to the Mughals, Pathans, Shaikh, Sayyid, Mulla and QAZI. In the early 16th century ^{FRANCIS BARBOSA} wrote about the wealthy Arabs, Iranians, Abyssinians and Indians of GAUR and about the high living standard of these Muslims. The proclamation of Firuz Shah Tughlaq, an official document, addressed those whose co-operation and help were needed and sought against his opponent, the sultan of Bengal. So they were the people who formed the upper strata of the society, the Ashraf as they are called. They belonged to the religious class, the Shaikhs, Ulama, and Mashayikh, and the official class, the Khans, Maliks and Umara.

The Saadat or the Sayyids were the descendants of the Prophet (Sm), the Ulama or the scholars were those who were well versed in the Islamic sciences or theology. They received training

Law, Logic, Arabic Letters and religious literature. The Mashayikh or the Sufis were spiritual persons, sometimes otherworldly or ascetic. Of these the theologians, i.e. those who occupied a special position, because they occupied judicial and other religious functions. They were the exponents of the Law, having sufficient knowledge and expertise to settle disputes. The word Shaikh literally means old, but technically it means doctor in Law and Theology. In this sense Shaikhs were Ulama but they were Ulama who had attained or helped others attain spiritual development.

The Sufis of Bengal were called Shaikh, because they actually devoted themselves to the study of Islamic sciences alongside their mystic devotions. The Sufis were also called Makhdums, i.e. those who are served. Shaikh or Makhdum, by whatever name the Sufis were known, were people who were spiritually developed and who adhered to the spirit of Islam. They were renowned for their simplicity of life, strength of character, devotion to faith and to their parents; they influenced the people and society very deeply. The other groups of people were the Khans, Malikhs etc who belonged to the official class and bureaucracy; they were the military personnel and civil servants who ran the administration and were the backbone of political power.

Before the Muslim conquest, Bengal was predominantly a Hindu-Buddhist country. The relative numbers of Hindus and Buddhists cannot be ascertained, but it is a fact that Buddhists ruled Bengal for several centuries, though before Bakhtyar's conquest, the Senas, were holding the power. Raja LAKSMANASENA was then ruling over the whole of Bengal. Moreover, Buddhist monasteries were always present in Bengal, particularly outside the urban centres and in the part Bangalah; and Buddhism which was uprooted from the land of its birth, i.e. India, had been a great competitor of Hinduism on the eve of the Muslim conquest.

The Aryans had somehow identified themselves with the Buddhists and thus when Buddhist rivalry was very much present in the society, Islam came as a relieving force, and many found an easy opening to salvation and success. This probably led to the conversion of local people to Islam. It is interesting to note that whereas in northern India, the Hindu imperial domination for centuries, Islam was confined to urban centres, in deltaic Bengal it captured the rural society. The large number of Muslims in this area was not so much due to the introduction of foreign blood into the country as to the conversion of indigenous people for whom the rigid caste system of Hinduism had become intolerable. There is no evidence of forcible conversion in the context of India or Bengal.

During several hundred years of Muslim rule, it is not expected that all rulers were free from religious bias or the desire to win converts even by coercion, but there is a consensus that the extent was very limited. The theory of political patronage also cannot explain the conversion to Islam that took place in Bengal because a large number of Hindus occupying high services including the office of ministers. Hinduism had prohibited the outcast from performing any service in the same village as the twice-born Brahman, had forced him to perform the most menial and repulsive occupations and had virtually treated him as an animal undeserving of any respect. Islam announced that the poor, as well as the rich, the slave and his master, the peasant and the prince, were all equal in the eye of God. Above all, the Brahmans held out no hopes of salvation in this world but of an indefeasible inheritance in the next. So the 'hewers of wood and drawers of water', many a despairing chandal and kaibartta joyfully embraced Islam, and Islam proclaimed the equality of man.

The reasons for conversion may be either mundane, eg for gaining royal favour, social opportunities and economic gains, or genuine love for the faith and desire to be free from oppression from people belonging to higher castes. The last mentioned cause seems to have played a greater part in the matter of conversion in Bengal. Islam with its social principles of equality and fraternity came to the downtrodden people as a saviour when the entire local society was steeped in inequality and caste oppression. And their models in the new society were certainly not the kings and nobles, but the Sufis and Ulama whose unostentatious life must have set an example.

It is unnecessary to speculate what percentage of Muslims adhered to the fundamental principles of Islam ie Salat (prayers), Saum (fastings), Zakat (poor rates) and Hajj (pilgrimage to the holy cities), because it was incumbent for Muslims to follow them. There were facilities for practicing the fundamentals and religious leaders were there to preach them.

The great majority of the people, particularly those who entered the fold of Islam later, were not as religious. It is not unnatural that some popular elements had crept into the belief of the Muslims. It should be conceded that many of the converted Muslims retained their long-inherited customs, social behaviour and even love for Hindu epics. Jola (weavers), Jolai (livestock holders), pithari (cake-sellers), Kabari (fish-mongers), garasal (converts of low origin), sanakar (loom-maker), hajam (circumciser), Tirakar (bow-maker), kagaji (maker), Kalandar (wandering faqir or holy men), darji (tailors), rangrez (dyers), Kal (those who beg for alms at night), kasai (beef-sellers), gola or goala (milk-men) etc retained their

Some of these groups were linked with the village economy, others to the textile and still others like the tirakar provided weaponry to the armed forces while the kagaji broker supplied paper for the use of civil servants in the offices and teachers and for writing books. They continued the professions in which they were engaged before 1492.

Close contact between the Hindus and the Muslims had profoundly influenced both, so that the social and religious life of the Muslims profoundly influenced Hinduism, and in the process some practices of the Hindus entered into the life of the Muslims. As a result certain elements are also found in the religious practices of the Muslims. The most popular element is found in Pirism. The Persian word Pir is now very loosely used, these spiritual guides for which the Arabic words, Shaikh, Murxid were formerly

used. In old days, the Pirs were the people who adhered most strictly to the ideals and principles of Islam. They led an austere and puritan life. Pirism was hardly hereditary, because to attain spiritual development. But Pirism gradually degenerated and sometimes false dargahs were built and these even became famous. Wandering Muslim faqirs built, near Hindu temples and Buddhist Viharas, tombs and mausoleums in the name of Indian Sufis of Central Asia and thus earned their livelihood and found out ways and means to acquire followers. Through assiduous and persistent propaganda regarding the virtues of these saints they attracted people, particularly of the lower classes.

There also developed Satya-Pir and Panch-Pir movements and a good number of books have been written on the Satya-Pir cult. While the Muslim writers call him Satya-Pir, to the Hindus he was known as Satya-Narayana. In fact, there is no difference between Satya Pir and Satya-Narayana. Satya-Pir or Satya-Narayana worship could be noticed in the northern and eastern parts of Bengal even in the beginning of the 20th century. But the traditions about them go far back as the 16th century. The worship of Panch-Pir also gained popularity. Panch-Pir dargahs are found in several places, no accepted list of five Pirs is available. They vary in the lists, though one or two names of local Pirs are found common in all. A number of imaginary Pirs also receive reverence from the credulous masses. They are given names like Manik Pir, Ghora Pir, Kumbhira Pir and Madari Pir. Offerings are made seeking relief from dangers. For example, offerings of milk and fruits are made to them and folk songs known as Manik Pirer Gan are composed and sung in various parts.

In some dargahs people bind coloured threads to the branches of nearby trees and/or walls are washed with lime. Sometimes people offer edibles to fish or tortoises in tanks near the dargahs. The fish or tortoises are called madari. The disciples of Badiuddin Shah are called Madari, but the name Madari given to the fish or tortoise shows that the people have forgotten its original connotation.

Mullaism is another element of popular Islam. Mullas are usually consulted by the illiterate and less educated Muslims and they help the village Muslims in performing religious ceremonies, killing animals on festive and religious occasions, giving taviz (amulets) to seekers of relief from evils. They also teach children in mosques and maktabas and are paid for their services.

The Muslims also venerate stone representations of the footprint of the Prophet (P). In Bangladesh there are several buildings containing the footprint eg KADAM RASUL at Narail, Dhaka, Kadam Mubarak at Chittagong town and Kadam Rasul at Bagicha Hat, Chittagong.

The Shias also brought some practices and ceremonies. The most important of them is connected with the tragic death of Imam Husain (R) and his family at Karbala, the Muharram festival. In the late Mughal period, the festival was observed ceremoniously in places like Dhaka, Murshidabad. The Shia nawabs and high officials spent huge amount of money in observing it. Muslim poets have also written on Muharram. Folk songs called jarigan are very popular even today. In the past Taziah processions were organised with pomp, splendour and also in remembrance of the Karbala tragedy. The birth, marriage and death of Muslims are governed by set rules, but here also Hindu practices have infiltrated. In their social life also the Muslims were influenced by some Hindu practices. For example, the Axraf and Atraf (or difference among Muslims was not much different from the caste distinction of the Hindus. In the first half of the Muslim period, the social difference was not so acute, but during the latter period when Islam spread to the nooks and corners of the country, particularly in the rural area, the cultivators, the weavers, and others who adopted similar professions were relegated to the lower or Atraf class. Economically backward people also belonged to the Atraf class.

The advent of Islam in Bengal gave the Brahmanical ascendancy a rude shock. The influence of the superior castes in both political and social life was greatly reduced. It was not only this but several other forces, such as the Manasa, Chandi and Dharma cults, that were opposed to the Brahmanical system and were more amenable to the proselytizing influence of Islam.

to face these challenges, the Brahmins further tightened their caste rules. The policy of the Brahmins is exemplified by the foundation of the Navadvipa school of Nyaya, revision of a number of smṛti texts by Raghunandan and his contemporaries and general conservatism embodied in the Sanskrit texts. This was, however, a negative approach; by tightening the rules and thus keeping the lower class Hindus, Vaishyas and Shudras, away from the influence of Islam, they tightened the caste restrictions and thus isolated themselves further from the people. They lost their hold over society and in eastern and central India adherents to the local cults of Manasa, Chandi and the Nathas far outnumbered

it was possible for the Brahmins to keep themselves aloof for long. Living in the same contact with the Muslims, Buddhists and other lower class Hindus, whom they treated as untouchables, was inevitable. This affected their caste purity. Association with lower castes was called Yavana-dosa (dosa meaning offence). Besides Yavana-dosa, other factors going to brothels, marrying within the community, marrying wicked girls, committing adultery or fornication could affect the social life of Brahmins and lead them to lose their caste sanctity. So there was a reaction among the Brahmins against this negative and suicidal policy. The idea gained ground in some sections of the Brahmins that they could keep pace with the challenge of time and liberalise their social life; otherwise they would not be able to stem the tide of Islam. This group represented the reform element and their chief exponent was SRI CHAITANYA, the founder of

It was a great reformer who advocated a casteless society. So the most important factor in the rise of Islam in Bengal is to be found in the diminishing superiority of the Brahmins, the reaction among the Brahmins themselves, prominence of local cults like those of Jagaddi and Natha, and finally the rise of Gaudiya Vaisnavism as a means of saving Hinduism, chiefly with its casteless appeal.

The Muslims brought with them their food habits, culinary art and dress, but they had to adjust to the local climate. Islamic architecture was developed before the Muslims came to Bengal. Its architecture with its true arch, dome, minar etc took the place of the false arch and the pyramidal shape. Both religious and secular buildings represented Muslim style. The religious buildings were mosques and mazars (tomb), whereas the secular buildings were of miscellaneous kinds, like the houses, pavilions, gates, wells, bridges, gardens etc. The Muslims also introduced mortar in their buildings. But the most important contribution

of the Muslims in Bengal was the growth of Bengali literature. Muslims came to Bengal with two languages, Arabic as the language of religion and Persian as the language of culture. They also had their mother tongue, Turkish or Poshtu as the case may be. In Bengal the languages were Bengali and Sanskrit. But Sanskrit was the language of both religion and culture.

The Brahmins considered it sacrilegious to write religious books in a language other than that of the Vedas, i.e. Sanskrit. The shudras had no access to the religious texts. The Brahmin ascendancy in the Hindu period was, therefore, a great barrier to the growth of Bengali literature. In the Hindu period, the court language was also Sanskrit. So the rulers and educated people were interested in the Sanskrit language only. After the Muslim conquest, the position changed; Persian became the court language and Sanskrit receded to the background. Local talents got momentum in cultivating their own language and literature.

Fortunately, the Muslim rulers were tolerant. They encouraged the cultivation of local languages and literature; patronised Hindu poets and thus some very important books were written in the Sultanate period. Almost all these poets received patronage from the Muslim rulers. The names of Barbak Shah, Husain Shah, Nusrat Shah and the Muslim officers, Paragalkhan, Khan may be mentioned in this connection. From the 16th century onwards, Muslims themselves wrote poems in Bengali. Besides, as an impact of Muslim rule, many Arabic and Persian words became assimilated into the Bengali language. The loan words in Bengali from these languages may be several hundred or even thousand and thus the Bengali vocabulary has been enriched. The Muslims also introduced romantic literature in Bengali. Whereas the Hindus wrote chiefly on religious themes centring round gods and goddesses, the Muslims introduced love-stories of men and women.

The Muslims came in contact with the local people in various ways. In their military establishments such as thanas, or the settlements of peaceful persons, they could not remain isolated and confined amongst themselves. In their day to day life, in the market places, bazaars, in the ports and in the trading stations, people of both the communities came in contact. The Mughal revenue system brought the people even closer. Todar Mal's elaborate revenue system, called zabti, was never applied in Bengal but ambitious local Muslim and Hindu, of both of whom the mother tongue was Bengali, were now forced to learn Persian to get a share in the extended secretarial work of the Mughal provincial administration.

In Bengal the state revenue was collected through middlemen. Unlike the sultans of India, the Mughal subahdars had no occasion to learn Bengali, and hence the agents

Social & Cultural life of Bengal ✓

Social and Cultural Life of Ancient Bengal

From the coming of the Aryans the people of the ancient settlements in Bengal had developed social and cultural life. It is the oldest socio-cultural picture of Bengal. According to the Vedas, their language was called 'Nishad'. Thereafter the ancient people of Bengal mixed with another race called 'Alpine'. They together developed the culture of Bengal before the advent of the Aryans.

As it is known, the political consciousness of the people in the regions did not grow in a broader sense. Society was at that time divided into many sects. It was called 'Koumo' society. It is difficult to ascertain when the different societies merged and resulted into one big society.

The religious thoughts of the pre-Aryan and Aryan ages have later spread in the Hindu religion. Of them mention may be made of 'Karmafal' (consequences of one's deeds), Janmantar (birth), 'Yoga' (meditation), etc. Many social rituals, manners and behaviors are observed at a stage among the followers of Hinduism. They are such as offering betel leaves and nuts, reciting songs sung in praise of Lord Shiva, different folk tales, boat making, anointing the body with turmeric in marriages, wearing 'dhuti-saree' (long cloths worn by men and women) and using vermilion on the forehead by the women.

The first step in the cultural change of ancient Bengal was the culture of the Age of Aryans. The Aryans came from outside India. They had different thoughts and customs in the case of religion and social behaviour. The Aryan influence brought about an extensive change in the life of language, religion and culture of Bengal. Of course, many traits of the former culture faded side by side. The Aryan culture, however, could not have a deep influence on the lives of the people of this country.

At the whole, the Hindu, the Buddhist and the low caste people formed the society in ancient Bengal. The Maurya and the Gupta Kings ruled this country from the third century to the fifth century B.C. At that time, the people of the Hindu and the Buddhist religions respectively used to live in this society though small in number; there were also the followers of Jain religion. In this country, the ruling race greatly influenced the religious beliefs and social lives of the people. The religious attitudes of the Buddhist Palas were liberal, while those of the Brahmin Palas were conservative and narrow.

After the Aryan culture, the third change in culture was brought about by the Buddhist religion. In the ancient time, like any other places of the world, the people of Bengal also had a religion. People spontaneously accepted the Buddhist religion. During the reign of the Pala kings, the Brahmanic culture was established by spreading its influence over the Buddhist culture. The Pala kings patronized the Buddhist culture during their four hundred years of rule. As a result of the generous rule of the Palas, different religions and cultures came to flourish. A new culture was, thus, evolved.

The condition was again changed during the Sena rule. At that time, the Buddhists, who were in a minority, were suppressed due to the supremacy of the Brahminism. The Aryan system of caste distinction was revived. The people of Bengal were divided into four castes at that time. The Brahmins were in the highest caste. Their main profession was to conduct the religious activities. The

Kshatriyas belonged to the second caste and their profession was to fight during the war. Vaishyas constituted the third caste. They mainly carried on trade and commerce. Since they were rich, they enjoyed some status in the society. Those who were in the lowest were the Sudras. Generally, they were engaged in agriculture, fishing and other minor jobs. They were the majority in number, but they had no right in the society.

Origin of Bengali Language and literature

The language of the original inhabitants of Bengal was Austric. This language gradually disappeared after the coming of the Aryans. The name of the language of the Aryans was Aryan. The Aryans turned the Vedic language into a Vedic Language. This was later reformed. The scholars turned the Vedic language into a language of literature. As the old language was reformed, this new language was named 'Sanskrit' language. Many are of opinion that the Bengali language originated from the Sanskrit language.

The modern scholars, however, have not accepted this view. In the ancient time, the common people did not use this language. Only the Brahmins used it. The name of the language of the common people was called 'Prakrita Bhasa'. As time passed, changes began to come over the language. It gained excellence and quality through the writing of books. Two languages were born of the 'Prakrita' language. One was 'Pali' and the other was 'Apabhramsha'. The language of the common people, however, remained as 'Prakrita' language. Many new languages were born in many states of Eastern India at that time. These originated from the 'Apabhramsha' language. Our Bengali language was also born in this manner.

Sanskrit language has been used most in Bengal during the reigns of the Pala and the Sena dynasties. As a result Bengali language did not develop much during that time. The cultivation of the Bengali language increased later, in the Medieval Age. The language, too, developed a lot. During the period 1350 A. D.-1800 A.D, Bengali poetry was composed extensively by Hindu and Muslim poets. In the Age of the Muslims, Bengali language gradually secured a place of its own under the generous patronization of the Sultans.

Rise and Development of Bengali literature

With the rise of the Bengali language, Bengali literature, too, developed. It was in the Medieval Age, that Bengali language truly found its expression. It was cultivated to some extent in ancient times also. A collection of lyrical poems composed by the Buddhist Monks known as 'Charjapada' is supposed to be the earliest specimen of Bengali literature. The Buddhist Monks composed those poems during the reigns of the Pala and the Sena kings. The period up to the twelfth century was known as the ancient period of Bengali literature. The Buddhist king of the Pala dynasty patronized language, literature, art and culture. The 'Charjapada' began to be composed from that period. A Bengali book by the name 'Sadukti Karnamrita' was written in the ancient Bengal. There were names of one hundred and thirteen poets in the book. Most of them were Buddhists and the inhabitants of Bengal. Shridhar Das compiled the book. We learn from the 'Charjapada' that chess was the most popular game in ancient Bengal. Most of the 'Vina' (Indian lute) among the musical instruments is found in it. Marriage ceremonies were performed with great pomp. Women dressed their hair into a knot at the back of the head.

except long curly hair hanging down to the neck. They used to wear coronet on the occasion of marriage.

Some kings, Vallala Sena and Lakshman Sena were themselves great scholars. Lakshman Sena patronised the poets and scholars. However, most of the literary works at the time were written in Sanskrit.

Even after the Muslim rule, Ramai Pundit composed a book of verses called 'Shunnya Purana'. The legends and hymns of Hindu Gods and Goddesses like Mansha, Shitala, Chandi, etc. were at the disposal of all and sundry. Although the journey of Bengali literature started in ancient Bengal, it found its true expression in the Medieval Age.

Arts, Architecture, Sculpture and Painting of Ancient Bengal

The people of ancient Bengal have left their marks in architecture, fine arts, sculpture and painting. Many palaces, stupas, temples, monasteries etc., were built in the Hindu period. Most of them have now perished. It is possible to get some ideas about these constructions from the accounts of the foreign travellers, inscriptions on stones and copper plates. The oldest remains of Bengali architecture are the Buddhist monuments. These were built on the bones of Buddha or any objects used by him. Later, the Jains, too, made such monuments. The Jains regarded the stupas as sacred as the temples. Viharas were built on the dwelling places for the buddhist monks and for their pursuit of knowledge. It is learnt from the account of these travellers that the Viharas were of big in size and adorned with artistic works. The famous Mahavihara in Paharpur of Noagaon district was built in the Age of the Palas. Besides, some relics of a few monasteries have been found in Mainamati in Comilla district.

The art of sculpture of Bengal lies in the creation of statues of different Gods and Goddesses. Remains of such sculptures have been found in Paharpur and Mainamati. They were mostly made of terracotta. Besides, statues of different shapes and forms were found after the ninth century. Scholars, however, are of the opinion that the people of this country were skilled in sculpture even before the birth of the Christ.

It is supposed that the art of painting developed from the time of the Palas. The culture of painting started for religious purposes. Thus, it has been observed that in the beginning, there were paintings on the walls of the temples and the Buddhist Viharas. Pictures of Buddha and Hindu Gods and Goddesses were found in ancient Buddhist manuscripts. Various colours were used in the pictures.

General Condition of Ancient Bengal

Bengal is mainly an agricultural country. Hence, the economy of the country developed mainly on agriculture. Paddy was the main crop. Besides, there was sugarcane. Molasses and rum made from the juice of sugarcane were exported and a lot of money was earned. Bengal was famous for the cultivation of cotton, mustard and betel leaf. Among the fruit trees, mention of coconut, betelnut, mango, jackfruit, pomegranate, banana, lemon, etc. is worth mentioning.

One important source of Bengal's economy was cloth. Many industrial goods were prepared in Bengal. Bengal was famous for textile industry since the ancient time. Fine cotton and cloths were produced in great quantity in this country. In the first century, huge quantity of quality cloths were exported to foreign countries. The world famous Muslin cloth has been manufactured in Bengal since the ancient time.

Many small industries grew in the ancient time. Earthen pots, gold and silver ornaments, the bullock carts, decorated wooden materials, etc. were made at that time. Business flourished with the development of industry. Transportation of goods was convenient as there were many rivers in Bengal. A lot of markets, trade-centres and cities grew up on the banks of the rivers due to this. It has been mentioned before that Bengal had trade links with foreign countries. Hence, the Muslin cloth, pearls and different kinds of trees and plants were exported to foreign countries through the waterways.

Social and Cultural Life in Medieval Bengal

The Medieval Age in Bengal began with the assumption of power by the Muslims. Before the advent of the Muslims, people belonging to the Hindu and the Buddhist religions lived in Bengal. The Muslims under the leadership of Bakhtiar Khalji entered Bengal as a royal power in the beginning of the thirteenth century. Even five to six hundred years before that the Muslims who had come to do business were living on the coastal belt in Southeast Bengal. Sufis and the Saints began to come to Bengal to preach Islam from the eleventh century. Many of the common Hindus and Buddhists embraced Islam at the time. Thus, gradually a new social structure developed in Bengal. The Hindus and the Muslims lived side by side all over Bengal at the time. As a result, a sort of mixture began to take place between one another's thoughts and rituals. The culture which evolved in this way is called the Bengali culture.

Language and Literature

The Sufis and the Saints had an important role in the expansion of the Muslim society in Bengal. The abodes of the Sufis and the Saints were called 'Khankahs'. Along with the establishment of the 'Khankah' the Sufis also established almshouses, Maktabas, Madrasahs. In fact, they created the proper atmosphere for the establishment of a Muslim society in Bengal. The deprived Hindus during the Sena period got the equal privilege of learning during the Muslim period. Hence, some Hindu writers emerged in the society during the Muslim period. For example 'Karcha', 'Naladamyanti Kavya', and 'Devayan Upakhyaana' were written by goldsmith Govinda Das, barber Madhusudan and milkman Ram Narayan Gope respectively. The Hindus and the Muslims had good relations with each other in the Age of the Sultan. Many Hindus were appointed in high offices of the State. When Sree Chaitnya preached the new 'Vaishnava' religion, he received no opposition from the Muslim Sultans.

The Sultans patronized the growth and expansion of the Bengali language and literature. In this respect the first name that can be mentioned is Giasuddin Azam Shah (1393 A.D-1411 A.D) of the Ilias Shah Dynasty. It was during his reign that Shah Mohammad Sagir wrote his famous poem 'Yusuf-Zulekha'. Barbak Shah of the later Ilias Shahi Dynasty patronized Jashoraj Karmakar, the composer of 'Sree Krishna Vijay'. Alauddin Hussain Shah had a reputation for inspiring

cultivation of Bengali literature. He patronaged Maladhar Basu, Bipradasa, Vijayagupta and other poets. Sultan Nasiruddin Nusrat Shah also has reputation for such patronage. During his time, Kambhira Parameswar translated Mahabharata in Bengali. The cultivation of not only Bengali, but also of Arabic and Persian works were widely practised during the Sultanate period.

Fest and Ornaments

During the period of the Sultans, the aristocratic and rich men and women wore expensive, decent and attractive dresses. The men wore 'ljar' (pyajama) and long attire with round neck. A broad ribbon made of cloth was tied round the waist. They wore the turban on their heads. They wore decorated leather shoes and socks. Men with delicate taste used shoes with designs on them. The dress for the middle class Muslims was pyajama, long shirt and turban. They wore chukka too. The common Muslims wore 'lungi' (cloth worn from the waist to the ankles), 'nima' (short shirt) and the cap on their heads. The aristocratic Muslim women wore short 'kamiz' and 'shalwar'. They used to wear the scarfs made of cotton or silk. They wore costly sarees too. Common women wore sarees.

After the Muslim rule was established in Bengal a radical change took place in the dresses of the Hindus in general, and the aristocratic Hindus in particular. The influence of the Muslims on the dress of the aristocratic Hindus was so great that if an aristocratic Hindu at that time did not wear 'tilak' (mark of sandal paste on the forehead) and ear rings, it was difficult to differentiate him from an aristocratic Muslim. The common Hindus used the 'dhoti' (long cloth from waist to the ankles) and 'chadar' (wrapper). They also wore garment called 'angarakhi' which covered the body down to the knee. They wore 'Kharam' (wooden sandal) on their feet. The lower class Hindus wore only the 'dhoti'. This 'dhoti' was from the waist to the knees. The common dress for the Hindu women was the 'saree'. They wore 'saree' and scarf according to their social and economic status. The poor wore the 'saree' only. It is worth mentioning that the style of wearing the 'saree' changed after the Muslims came to Bengal. The old system fused with the foreign custom and a new manner of wearing the 'saree' was evolved.

Men and women, either Hindu or Muslim, both wore ornaments. However, the women were more fond of ornaments. They wore the tiara and, 'sinthipathi' on the head; earring, tops, 'kushul', 'kambala', 'balies' in the ears; nose-ring in the nose; necklace and 'hansuli' in the neck; 'kankon' bangles' string' 'churi' 'khar' 'penchi' 'angada' in the hands; rings in the fingers; 'kankani' and 'kinkini' in the waist; anklet' bangle of bells for the ankle and 'pansuli' in the toes. Men and women used various cosmetics. But women were more inclined and attentive to them. Women were more careful about their hairdo. They used to make bun. They made their hair tied into braid and sometimes allowed to fall hair on the back. They also used various kinds of perfumes. Noteworthy among them were musk, kumkum, incense, camphor etc. 'Surma' was invariably used for adorning oneself. They used 'surma' and 'kajal' in their eyes. To beautify their hands they used a substance called 'hena'. To redden their lips they ate betels. The ladies also used Sandal paste on their foreheads.

Architecture and Painting

Muslim architecture became quite developed in the Age of the Sultans. Noteworthy examples are the 'Dakhil Darwaza' of Gaur, the 'Kotwali Darwaza', the Chata Sona Masjid, the 'Alauddin Masjid', the 'Baro Sona Masjid', the 'Qadam Rasul', the 'Shat Gambuj Masjid' etc. High quality craftspeople of Bengal were skilled in making, pottery, plates, knives, scissors etc. High quality paper was made from the barks of trees. Sea faring vessels were also built in the shipbuilding factories. Silver coins were used as currency for buying and selling goods. The 'kari' a local medium of exchange, was in use at the same time.

Siraj-Ud-Daulah's army with 50,000 soldiers, 40 cannons and 10 war elephants was defeated by 3,000 soldiers of Robert Clive. The battle ended in 11 hours and Siraj-Ud-Daulah fled the battle post his defeat.

According to Robert Clive, 22 men died and 50 were injured from the British troops. Nawab army lost about 500 men, including several key officials and many of them suffered several casualties.

Who Fought the Battle of Plassey?

The table below will inform about the participants of the Battle of Plassey and their signals in the battle:

Participants of Battle of Plassey	Role in the Battle of Plassey
Siraj-Ud-Daulah (Nawab of Bengal)	- Involved in Black-Hole Tragedy (imprisoned 146 English persons who were lodged in a very tiny room due to which 123 of them died of suffocation) - Adversely affected by the rampant misuse of trade privileges by the EIC - Attacked and seized the English fort at Calcutta, it brought their hostility into the open
Robert Clive (EIC)	- Gave asylum to political fugitive Krishna Das, disappointing Siraj-Ud-Daulah - Misuse of trade privileges - Fortified Calcutta without the nawab's permission
Mir Jafar (Commander-in-Chief of Nawab's army)	- Bribed by East India Company (EIC) - Was to be made the Nawab by EIC for conspiring against Siraj-Ud-Daulah - Cheated Siraj-Ud-Daulah during the battle
Rai Durlabh (One of the Commanders of the Nawabs Army)	- Joined his army with Siraj-Ud-Daulah's but did not participate in the battle - Betrayed Siraj
Jagat Seth (Influential Banker)	Involved in the conspiracy involving the imprisonment and ultimate killing of Nawab Siraj-Ud-Daulah

Clive (Bengal
and)

- One of the principal authors of the conspiracy against Nawab and associated with the treaty negotiated by Robert Clive before the Battle of Plassey in 1757

Effects of Battle of Plassey

apart from the British getting political power of Northern India but only after Nawabs, there are several other effects in many forms that came out as a result of the Battle of Plassey. They can be categorized as:

- Political Effects
- Economic Effects

Political Effects

- 1 The Battle of Plassey resulted at the end of the French forces.
- 2 Mir Jafar was crowned as the Nawab of Bengal
- 3 Mir Jafar was unhappy with the position and instigated the Dutch to attack the British in order to consolidate his foundation.
- 4 Battle of Chinsura was fought between the Dutch and British forces on November 25, 1759
- 5 The British installed Mir Qasim as the Nawab of Bengal.
- 6 The British became the paramount European power in Bengal.
- 7 Robert Clive was titled "Lord Clive", Baron of Plassey and also obtained a seat in the British House of Commons.

Economic Effects

- 1 The economy of India was affected severely.
- 2 Post the victory, the British started imposing severe rules and regulations on the inhabitants of Bengal in the name of tax collection.

Battle of Buxar 1764

The advent of Europeans in India, the British East India Company gradually conquered territories. The Battle of Buxar is one such confrontation between the British army and Indian counterparts which paved the way for the British to rule over India for the next 183 years.

The Battle of Buxar took place in 1764 and is an important chapter in the history of the sub-continent.

A battle fought between the English Forces, and a joint army of the Nawab of Oudh, the Nawab of Bengal, and the Mughal Emperor. The battle was the result of misuse of trade rights granted by the Nawab of Bengal and also the colonialist ambitions of East India Company.

Background of the Battle of Buxar

Before the Battle of Buxar, one more battle was fought. It was the Battle of Plassey, that gave British a firm foothold over the region of Bengal. As a result of the Battle of Plassey, Siraj-ud-Daulah was de-throned as the Nawab of Bengal and was replaced by Mir Jafar (Commander of the British Army). After Mir Jafar became the new Bengal nawab, the British made him their ally. But Mir Jafar got involved with Dutch East India Company. Mir Qasim (son-in-law of Siraj-ud-Daulah) was supported by the British to become the new Nawab and under the pressure of the British, Mir Jafar decided to resign in favor of Mir Kasim. A pension of Rs 1,500 per month was fixed for Mir Jafar.

Reasons which were the key to the Battle of Buxar are given below:

Mir Qasim wanted to be independent and shifted his capital to Munger Fort from Calcutta.

He also hired foreign experts to train his army, some of whom were in direct conflict with the British.

He treated Indian merchants and English as same, without granting any special privileges for the latter.

These factors fuelled the English to overthrow him and war broke out between Mir Qasim and the Company in 1763.

Who were the combatants of the Battle of Buxar?

The table below will help us to know the participants of the battle of Buxar and significance on the battle:

Participants of Battle of Buxar	Role in the Battle of Buxar
Mir Qasim – (Administering Bengal in place of Mir Jafar – Nawab of Bengal)	He disliked misuse of dastak (a permit exempting European traders, mostly of the British East India Company, from paying customs or transit duties on their private trade) farmans by the English, hence tried to conspire against them by forming an alliance with Nawab of Awadh and Mughal Emperor Shah Alam II
Shuja-Ud-Daulah – Nawab of Awadh (Oudh)	Was a part of a confederacy with Mir Qasim and Shah Alam II
Shah Alam II – Mughal Emperor	He wanted to overthrow English from Bengal
Hector Munro – British Army Major	He led the battle from the English side
Robert Clive	Signed the treaties with Shuja-Ud-Daulah and Shah Alam II after winning the battle

The Course of Battle of Buxar

When the battle broke out in 1763, English gained successive victories at **Katwah, Murshidabad, Giria, Sooty and Munger**. Mir Kasim fled to Awadh (or Oudh) and formed a confederacy with the Shuja-Ud-Daulah (Nawab of Awadh) and Shah Alam II (Mughal Emperor). Mir Qasim wanted to recover Bengal from the English. Read the course of battle in the points below:

- Mir Qasim fled to Oudh
- He planned a confederacy with Shuja-Ud-Daulah and Shah Alam II in a final bid to overthrow the English from Bengal

- Qasim's soldiers met the English army troops directed by Major Munro in 1764.
- Two armies of Mir Qasim were defeated by the British.
- Qasim absconded from the battle and the other two surrendered to the English.
- The battle of Buxar ended with the **Treaty of Allahabad** in 1765.

Battle of Buxar

Qasim, Shuja-Ud-Daula and Shah Alam-II lost the battle on October 22, 1764.

Major Hector Munro won a decisive battle and Robert Clive had a major role in that. British became a great power in northern India.

Mir Jafar (Nawab of Bengal) handed over districts of Midnapore, Burdwan and Patna to the English for the maintenance of their army.

The English were also permitted duty-free trade in Bengal, except for a duty of two percent on salt.

After the death of Mir Jafar, his minor son, Najimud-Daula, was appointed nawab, but the real power of administration lay in the hands of the naib-subahdar, who could be appointed or dismissed by the English.

Clive made political settlements with Emperor Shah Alam II and Shuja-Ud-Daula of Awadh in the **Treaty of Allahabad**.

The Treaty of Allahabad (1765)?

Important treaties were concluded in Allahabad between Robert Clive, Shuja-Ud-Daulah and Shah Alam II. The key-points of the treaty of Allahabad are given below:

Treaty of Allahabad between Robert Clive & Shuja-Ud-Daulah:

- Shuja had to surrender Allahabad and Kara to Shah Alam II
- He was made to pay Rs 50 lakh to the Company as war indemnity; and
- He was made to give Balwant Singh (Zamindar of Banaras) full possession of his estate.

Treaty of Allahabad between Robert Clive & Shah Alam-II:

Shah Alam was commanded to reside at Allahabad which was ceded to him by Shuja-Ud-Daulah under the Company's protection.

The emperor had to issue a Farman granting the **Diwani of Bengal, Bihar and Orissa** to the East India Company in lieu of an annual payment of Rs 26 lakh;

Shah Alam had to abide by a provision of Rs 53 lakh to the Company in return for the **Muzammat functions** (military defence, police, and administration of justice) of the United Provinces.

Key-Facts about Battle of Buxar

- After the Battle of Buxar, English did not annex Awadh even after Shuja-Ud-Daulah was defeated because it would have placed the Company under an obligation to protect an extensive land frontier from the Afghan and the Maratha invasions.
- Shuja-Ud-Daulah became a firm friend of British and made Awadh a buffer state between English and foreign invasions.
- The treaty of Allahabad with Mughal Emperor Shah Alam-II made emperor a mere 'rubber stamp' of the Company. Besides, the emperor's Farman legalised the political gains of the Company in Bengal.

Administration System ✓

The British set up the infamous dual system of government administration in Bengal after the annexation of Alahabad.

Under the 'dual' or double government system, the Company got both the Diwani (revenue) and Nizamat (civil administration) functions of Bengal from two different sources: Diwani from the Mughal emperor and Nizamat from the Nawab of Bengal.

The Company was authorized to collect revenues of the province as the diwan, while through the right to nominate the deputy subahdar it was in a position to control the military or the police and judicial powers. The deputy subahdar could not be removed without the consent of the Company.

Under this system, the Nawab continued to handle the actual work of criminal, civil and police administration in lieu of a fixed payment by the Company.

This was a government system in which the native administrators held responsibility while the British enjoyed the authority or in other words, authority was completely divorced from responsibility. Bengal now had two masters-the Nawab and the Company. The Nawab was responsible for general administration, maintenance of law and order and justice (i.e., criminal cases). The Company had military power and the right to collect and use the revenue of Bengal. This arrangement was known as the Dual Government.

The company had no responsibilities and enjoyed power. On the other hand, the Nawab was burdened with the responsibility of administration without the resources necessary for running it efficiently i.e. responsibility without power. Indian officials were appointed by the company to collect the revenue. The greed, corruption and oppression of these officials left the peasants in conditions of utter misery. The company was indifferent to the people's welfare.

It was characterized by:

1. Corruption among servants of the Company who made full use of private trading to enrich themselves.

2. Excessive revenue collection and oppression of peasantry;

3. Company went into loss, while the servants were flourishing.

The Dual Government in Bengal failed miserably. It destroyed the trade, industry, and agriculture of Bengal.

- The Company also did not remain unaffected by the evils of its administration, both from revenue and trade suffered. The practice of private trade by the Company remained the primary concern of company also proved disastrous to the Company.

Later When Bengal was hit by a terrible famine, the conditions of the people and one third of the population perished. Neither the company nor the Nawab, case had neither the authority nor the resources to do so, took steps to help the people. The Company, through its power to nominate the deputy Nawab, continued in the general administration without taking on any responsibility. The evils of Government began to manifest themselves. The administration and economy

Permanent Settlement Act 1793 ✓

Permanent Settlement was introduced by the second governor-general of Bengal, Cornwallis in 1793. It was a settlement system that was first enacted in Odisha, Bihar, and Assam. The Permanent Settlement of Bengal was an official agreement between the British Government and the East India Company.

The Permanent Settlement System was aimed at fixing a specific amount of revenue for the land used for agricultural methods and its productivity. This settlement made the interaction between the company and Zamindars easier as after this system, the company had to have two deals with every farmer but with a limited number of Zamindars. This section will throw light on the Permanent Settlement Act, its features, merits, and demerits.

Permanent Settlement was introduced by Lord Cornwallis, in 1793, the 2nd governor-general of Bengal. The Permanent Settlement of Bengal was a grand contract between the British Government, the Company and the individual landholders belonging to Bengal. These landholders included talukdars and zamindars of Bengal. In the permanent settlement, the Zamindars, who had the right to collect the taxes on their land, were given the proprietorship or the ownership of the land. The condition was that the demand for land revenue was fixed by the British Government. If zamindars failed to pay on time, they may lose the land directly by the company or in the hands of the British Government.

As per the Permanent Settlement Agreement, the colonial state system was adopted by the government of Bengal. According to this, all the zamindars and talukdars had to pay a fixed amount of revenue to the government, and the landlords had the right to change the rate of revenue collected from their tenants. These landholders could also evict the tenants as per their will.

But, if the landholders wanted, they could make it default and generate the amount by selling their piece of land. This was a strong law known as the sunset law. However, the rights and privileges were not given to the cultivating raiyats.

Permanent Settlement

Features of Permanent Settlement are as follows:

Under the Permanent Settlement, the Zamindars, or landlords, were regarded as the **proprietors** in Odisha, Bihar, and Bengal.

The lands were owned by the landlords or zamindars, who were given the power of **hereditary** succession rights.

The zamindars were free to sell or transfer the land to whomever they wanted.

The zamindars had to pay a fixed amount of revenue to the government of the East India Company on the said date.

If the zamindars failed to generate revenue at the said time, they ceased their rights, and the respective land would be auctioned to generate revenue.

The revenue of the land was fixed for the landlords, and the government agreed on a **long-term** term that it would not increase the value of the permanently fixed revenue.

The government takes 10 out of 11 portions of the revenue, and the remaining 1/10th was left for the Zamindars.

Though the Permanent Settlement system was introduced in England, the tax rate was much higher than England's prevailing rates.

Along with this, the Zamindars provide a **patta** to the tenant. The patta represents the area allotted to a Zamindar and describes the rent they had to pay the landlord.

Permanent Settlement

Permanent Settlement significantly impacted the Zamindars, Peasants, and the East India Company. The effect of permanent settlement in Bengal can be explained below.

Permanent Settlement on Peasants

The farmers, and the Bengal cultivators thought the system oppressive as they were subjected to Zamindar's mercy.

They had to take loans to pay the tax. Sometimes, they were exploited by the zamindars.

If the landowners failed to pay the tax, they were evicted from their cultivated land.

Impact of Permanent Settlement on Zamindars

- They have a complete hold over the revenue.
- The benefit of Zamindars depends on the increase in land production.
- If Zamindars failed to pay the said revenue, their properties were confiscated by the Company.
- They became the intermediaries and served the Britisher's political aspects.
- In Permanent Settlement, the revenue was fixed because the zamindars could not increase it quickly.

Impact of Permanent Settlement on Company

- It ensured a constant flow of money to the Company.
- It was the Company's responsibility to improve the productivity of the land.
- It resulted in an increase in cultivation and a rise in market prices.

Benefits of Permanent Settlement

The *benefits of Permanent Settlement* were as follows:

- It became the responsibility of the Indian landlord to take care of and look after the farmers. This is because, due to their regional roots, they were able to reach all sections of the region and understand the local customs.
- There was a sense of security among all the farmers and peasants because the Permanent Settlement system was permanent in nature. Because of this permanent settlement, the company was sure how much amount they were going to get in revenue.
- Along with the Company, the landlords were also sure about the guaranteed amount they were going to get.
- Not only this, but the farmers also knew how much rent they had to pay instead of being concerned about pattas.
- Due to the permanent nature of the settlement, the Zamindars would take more care of the land, thereby maximizing their revenue.

of Permanent Settlement

Disadvantages of Permanent Settlement are more than the advantages. There was a major flaw in the permanent settlement system that its efficiency varied according to the character of the zamindars.

Some zamindars looked after the interest of farmers and the land very well when they were good, but some made the necessary changes to the land which would benefit whoever was the tenant.

A bad landlord, on the other hand, would be negligent to the conditions of farmers on their lands.

A class of hereditary landlords developed, who led luxurious and extravagant lifestyles among the upper aristocracy of society.

During the freedom struggle, Zamindar supported the British administration.

There was a lack of assessment of lands, and even the revenues were fixed capriciously for all types of productive and unproductive lands. This was a big problem for the farmers who had infertile or unproductive land.

The revenues in the Permanent Settlement system were so high that the zamindars became corrupt in no time, and soon it proved to be a disastrous move.

According to the British government, a proper land survey was required before this settlement could be established.

Bengal Famine 1776

as. They are a beastly people with a beastly religion. The famine was their own fault like rabbits."

urchill

and a ruthless economic agenda when it came to operating in India and that did not shy for native citizens. Under the British Raj, India suffered countless famines. But it was Bengal. The first of these was in 1770, followed by severe ones in 1783, 1866, 1897 and lastly 1943-44. Previously, when famines had hit the country, indigenous rulers had taken quick with useful responses to avert major disasters. After the advent of British rule, famines were a consequence of monsoonal delays along with the exploitation of the natural resources by the British for their own financial gain. Yet they did little to curb the havoc these actions wrought. If anything, they were irritated at the increase in taxation the famines brought about.

The first of these famines was in 1770 and was ghastly brutal. The first signs indicating the onset of a huge famine manifested in 1769 and the famine itself went on till 1773. It killed approximately 10 million people, millions more than the Jews incarcerated during the Holocaust. War. It wiped out one-third the population of Bengal. John Fiske, in his book "The World", wrote that the famine of 1770 in Bengal was far deadlier than the Black Plague in Europe in the fourteenth century. Under the Mughal rule, peasants were required to pay a tribute of 10-15 percent of their cash harvest. This ensured a comfortable life for the rulers and a wide net of safety for the peasants in case the weather did not hold its promise. In 1765, the Treaty of Allahabad was signed and the East India Company took over the task of collecting the tributes from the then Mughal emperor Shah Alam II. Instead of tributes, the British insisted on calling them tributes and not taxes for reasons of convenience. The tributes, increased to 50 percent. The peasants were not even aware that the money was going to the British. They paid, still believing that it went to the Emperor.

Due:

After the Battles of Plassey and Buxar, the British East India Company had acquired the political rights over Bengal.

The Nawab was only a nominal head with the real power resting under the company's control.

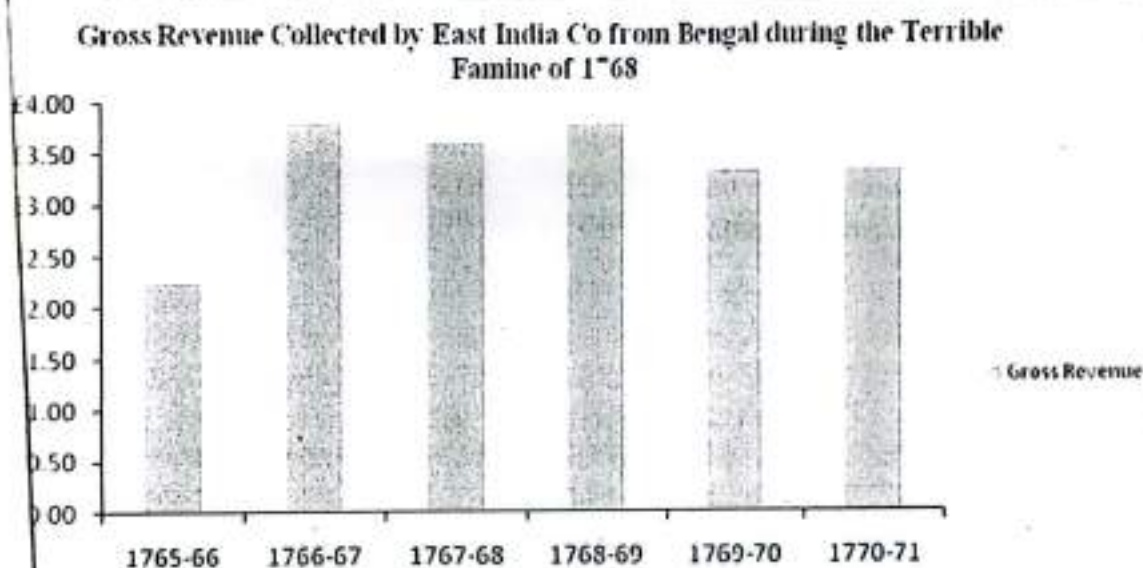
The company was only interested in maximising revenue and profits for itself while the welfare of the local farmers and others were completely neglected.

- Prior to the company's rule, the tax rate on land revenue was only about 10% of the agricultural produce. But the company increased it overnight to 50% of the produce.
- The farmers, who had previously stored excess produce for a lean season (due to the low tax), were not permitted to store produce, and starved, because of the terrible tax regime under the English.
- The British forced farmers to harvest cash crops like poppy and indigo for export, rather than food crops like paddy. This resulted in a shortage of grains for the people.
- There was a minor shortage of crops in 1768 which was not an alarming situation.
- But in 1769, there was a monsoon failure followed by severe drought. Starvation started by 1769, but the company officials ignored this situation.
- By 1770, the death count was increasing and almost 10 million people fell victim to man-made devastation.
- The company continued to collect taxes from farmers who could pay, by increasing the tax rate to make up for the loss in agricultural revenue due to the drought.
- This famine was caused, to a large extent, by the company's tax and revenue policies and the apathy of the company officials to rising starvation.

Partial failure of crops was quite a regular occurrence in the Indian peasant's life. The surplus stock, which remained after paying the tributes, was so important to their livelihood. With the increased taxation, this surplus deteriorated rapidly. When partial failure occurred in 1768, this safety net was no longer in place. The rains of 1769 were dismal and the signs of the terrible drought began to appear. The famine occurred mainly in the north-western part of Bengal and Bihar but also hit Orissa, Jharkhand and Bangladesh. Bengal was the worst affected area. Among the worst affected areas were Birbhum and Murshidabad in Bengal. Thousands fled from the area in hopes of finding sustenance elsewhere, only to die of starvation later. Those who stayed on perished nonetheless. Huge tracts of farmland were abandoned. The land started to thrive here, resulting in deep and inhabitable jungle areas. Tirhut, Champaran and Bettiah in Bihar were similarly affected. Prior to this, whenever the possibility of a famine emerged, the Indian rulers would waive their taxes and see compensatory measures like irrigation, instituted to provide as much relief as possible to the stricken farmers. But the British rulers continued to ignore any warnings that came their way regarding the famine. Starvation had set in from early 1770. Then the deaths started in 1771. That year, the British raised the land tax to 60 percent in order to recompense themselves for the lost lives of the peasants. Fewer peasants resulted in fewer crops, which in turn meant less revenue.

who had not yet succumbed to the famine had to pay even greater taxes so as to ensure that British treasury did not suffer any losses during this travesty. After taking over from the Mughal rulers, the British had issued widespread orders for cash crops to be cultivated. These were intended to be exported. Thus, farmers who were used to growing paddy and vegetables were now being forced to cultivate indigo, poppy and other such items that yielded a high market value for them but could be of no relief to a population starved of food. There was no backup of food crops in case of a famine. The natural causes that had contributed to the drought were ignored. It was the single-minded motive for profit that wrought such devastating consequences. No relief measure was provided for those affected. Rather, as mentioned above, the tax was increased to make up for any shortfall in revenue. What is even more ironic is that the East India Company generated higher profits in 1771 than they did in 1768.

Although the starved populace of Bengal did not know it yet, this was just the first of umpteen massacres, caused solely by the motive for profit, that were to scourge the country side. Although these massacres were deadly in their own right, the deadliest one to occur after 1771 was in 1770 when three million people died and others resorted to eating grass and human flesh in order to survive.



Churchill, the hallowed British War prime minister who saved Europe from a monster war, was disturbingly callous about the roaring famine that was swallowing Bengal's life. He casually diverted the supplies of medical aid and food that was being dispatched to the dying victims to the already well supplied soldiers of Europe. When entreated upon, he said, "Be it famine or no famine, Indians will breed like rabbits." The Delhi Government sent a

telegram to him painting a picture of the horrible devastation and the number of people died. His only response was, "Then why hasn't Gandhi died yet?"

Results of the Famine

The famine would have far-reaching consequences that would not only change the subcontinent but even the world forever:

- The famine situation soothed by 1770 with good rainfall but not before claiming the local population.
- Large swathes of land were depopulated as a result of the famine.
- Many agricultural lands became jungles for decades as a result of this famine.
- This also increased the menace of bands of thuggee or dacoits in Bengal.
- Globally, the profit of the East India Company increased from fifteen million 1765 to thirty million in 1777.
- Despite the soar in profits, the company continued to suffer financially and Parliament to pass the Tea Act in 1773.
- The Act allowed direct shipment of tea to the American colonies, without the taxes. This infuriated the local merchants to the extent that they began protesting this measure. One such protest was the Boston Tea Party of 1773.

Partition of Bengal of 1905 ✓

The Partition of Bengal was the most important event in the history of Bengal. The Partition of Bengal was announced in 7 July, 1905 by the Viceroy of India, Lord Curzon. The work for which Lord Curzon earned an immortal fame was his Partition of Bengal. In January 1905, Lord Curzon was appointed Viceroy of India.¹ Till the time of Curzon, the whole area covering Bengal, Bihar and Orissa remained under one administration. It was too big in size. The area of the province was 189,000 sq miles. Its population was nearly 78 million. Its population was nearly double the population of England.² Bengal in those days was the biggest province of India. Lord Curzon thought it unwise to keep such a huge area as one province.

In 1866, a devastating famine was appeared in Orissa. Millions of people died in that famine. The British administration formed an inquiry team to find out the reasons behind the famine. According to the report given by the inquiry team, this Bengal province is too big in size. They have to face many administrative difficulties. Administration could not take proper steps in emergency situation due to the vastness and geographical structure of the province. In 1867 Sir William Carey and in 1872 Sir John Campbell informed the upper authority in England that it is impossible for a governor to rule such a vast province, Bengal. But the authority did not give any response to their report. The government announced the idea for partition in January 1905. The idea was opposed by Henry John Stedman Cotton, Chief Commissioner of Assam (1896-1904).³ Partition, most significantly, is a lesson in abject failure of understanding between two very large communities- Hindus and Muslims. Unbelievable as it may sound now, the Hindus, Muslims, Sikhs, Christians, and other communities lived side by side for hundreds of years, mostly in peace, at times in conflict, but not along the rigid communal divides that British officials formulated to suit their "divide and rule" policy. It was started with the British desire to divide the mix of the population that they were ruling. The 1871 census gave rise to an emerging sense of separate identities among the cultural, ethnic, and religious groups. This census attempted to list every Indian according to language, caste, religion, etc. As it happened, spurious identities were attributed to groups when census takers were unsure because of the close and extremely intermingled nature of the religious practices that were being recorded. So clearly one became a member of this or the other group or even religion, as labeled by the census official, without being personally aware of his or her transformation. But historically, Bengal

¹ A Chatterjee, 'Partition Studies: Prospects and Pitfalls', *Star Weekend, The Daily Star* (August 25, 2017), P:39-42

² Anil Kumar Choudhury, 'How a nationalist movement turned communal', *Star Weekend, The Daily Star* (August 2017), P: 5, 6

³ J. K. Dasgupta, 'Partition: The pulsing heart that grieved', *Journal of Asian Studies* 73(2014):13-6

and cultural practices had overlapped and gotten entwined between groups of people. It would be quite common that one village or groups of villages took up certain religious practices of another.⁴ On July 20th 1905, the first partition of Bengal along religious lines was approved in London by the Secretary of State of India.

The decision Partition of Bengal was announced by Lord Curzon, then Viceroy of India in 1905. This partition came into effect in October 1905. Taking the eastern half of Bengal, namely the Dacca, Chittagong, and Rajshahi division and uniting those with Assam, Lord Curzon formed a new province, named as 'Eastern Bengal and Assam.' Dacca became the capital of the new province. The western half of Bengal with Bihar and Orissa remained as another province. Calcutta remain its capital. The area of the newly formed province was 106,504 sq miles and its population was 31 million and majority was Muslims. Sir Joseph Bampfylde Foulke was appointed as the Governor of this province. A managerial and a revenue board are also formed. But the Judiciary of the newly formed province was kept under the Calcutta High Court. The area of Western Bengal was 141,580 sq miles and its population was nearly 54 million and majority was Hindus. Sir Endro Frezer was appointed as the Governor of that province.⁵

In 1905, there were administrative, political, economic and social causes behind the Partition of Bengal and following issues are discussed below:

Administrative Reason:

Administrative problem was the main reason behind the Partition of Bengal. Bihar, Nagpur and Orissa were under 'Bengal Presidency' before the partition. In British period, 'Bengal Presidency' was the largest province in size and population. It was 179,000 sq miles in area and its population was about 70 million. It was too big in size and population for a governor to manage. Many governors informed upper authority in London about their administrative problems. The authority did not give any response to their report before Lord Curzon. In 1899, Lord Curzon was appointed as the governor of this subcontinent. At that time, organized Nationalist movement started against the British rule in India led by the Indian Congress. Lord Curzon realized that if he divided the vast province 'Bengal Presidency' into two parts and appointed a different governor for each province, then it will be easy to control and there will be no administrative problems what were seen in previous years. Besides, backward rural people will get enough opportunity for being educated. They will also get enough chance for developing their business. Lord Curzon believed that East Bengal was neglected and as a result it was underdeveloped. These were the administrative reasons behind the Partition of Bengal.⁶

⁴ Mahfuz Anam, 'Why this special issue on Partition?' Star Weekend, The Daily Star (August 25, 2017), p:2-3

⁵ ডঃ আবু রহিম, 'বঙ্গের মুসলমানদের ইতিহাস', পৃ ৩১২০০

⁶ রাধী বর্মণ প্রফেসর ইয়াসমিন আহমেদ, 'ব্রিটিশ ভারতে রাজনৈতিক ও সাংবিধানিক উন্নয়ন', পৃ ২১২

Real Reasons:

Following reasons are responsible for the Partition of Bengal:

Developing Nationalism Thought: Since the Indian Congress was formed in 1885, the middle Hindu people started developing their political position in Indian politics. The whole of Indian Sub-Continent was maintained from Bengal or Calcutta. For this reason Lord Curzon, Andro Frezer etc tried to scatter their communication. As majorities emerged with their confidence, so did the minorities with their fears, and the British played on both, specially the Hindus. And as it became more and more evident that due to the changing power dynamics and the consciousness of the Indian population there was like to be, in however limited a scale, a power sharing in the current days, identities and the numbers each group represented became vital.

Division between Hindu-Muslim: The British rulers had succeeded so many times on the basis of 'divide and rule' policy. By dividing the Bengal again, they practiced this and made this division. They tried to create conflict between Hindu and Muslim community.

Local Demand: Nawab Sir Salimullah, the representative from East Bengal demanded this division because he thought the East Bengal should come to the limelight. And for this, he tried to create consciousness among the people of East Bengal. The following issues were presented by Nawab Sir Salimullah to the British authority:

1. At that time, the Hindu people were majority and very much powerful. So they got the advantage in government services or other business related occupations.
2. Maximum of the Hindu Zamindars collected tax from the East Bengal and invested in Calcutta. So the people of East Bengal were lagging behind.
3. Before the partition of Bengal, Calcutta was the capital of Bengal. So the industries and commercial factories were built centering Calcutta. On the other hand, people of East Bengal were deprived from their rational rights. For example, Jute was produced in East Bengal but the factories were in West Bengal.
4. As Calcutta was the capital of Bengal, it was the center of politics and maximum rich Hindu people lived in Calcutta. So they did not think about the minority Muslim people of the East Bengal.⁸

8. Nawab Sir Salimullah thought about the Muslim and showed his logics for the Partition of Bengal.

⁸ Bhabha, *et al.* "History of Modern India", pp. 248-249

⁹ Gupta, P. "Partition of Contingency? Public Discourse in Bengal, 1946-1947," *Modern Asian Studies*

45 (1983), 1001-1020

Economic Reason:

Economic reasons were also responsible for the partition of Bengal. The economy of east Bengal was agriculture related. But they did not try to improve the position of the farmers.

~ At that time, Calcutta was the center of the business in east India. Almost every raw material was produced from east Bengal. For this reason, Calcutta was improving day by day. On the other hand, east Bengal was deprived and undeveloped. So they thought they could improve their economic condition if the partition of Bengal happened and they supported it.

~ Chittagong was the center of foreign trade in Assam and east Bengal. But as Calcutta was the center of the trade, so Chittagong could not flourish. So they thought if the partition happened they could bring the glory of Chittagong.

~ As the Zamindar lived in Calcutta, they collected the forceful revenue from the east Bengal and made their life comfortable. So the majority of east Bengal supported this partition.

Social Reason: In British period, the Hindu were privileged, on the other hand the Muslim were tortured on many ways. So when Lord Curzon proposed the partition of Bengal, the Hindu showed their support to his decision with very much humbleness. But on the other hand, the Muslims became furious. Even Rabindranath Tagore wrote his famous song "Ami Bangla" on the basis of this event.

Religious Cause: The maximum number of Hindu peoples were lived in the western part. On the other hand, the majority number of Muslim people lived in the eastern part. So on the basis of religion, the British made this plan to divide the Bengal province into two parts. It's the first time in British rule united India, but uniting the people of this subcontinent was never the intention of the British.⁹

Resistance: Around the partition, an organized national movement began to be formed against the British, which raised a great political storm in India, thereby resulting in a countrywide agitation. The partition not only brought the *Indian National Congress* unequivocally into politics, but it also brought the division between moderates and extremists inside Congress into the limelight.¹⁰

Effects and Reaction of partition of Bengal of 1905: The effects of the partition of Bengal were huge. There were opposite reactions between the Hindu and the Muslim.

⁹ Chakrabarty, "The partition of Bengal and Assam", page 142

¹⁰ Chatterji, "Spoils of partition", Page 244 - 245

Views of the Muslim community:

Muslim people of east Bengal were very much happy for the partition of Bengal because they thought they could be able to seek the attention of the British government. The Muslim of Bengal realized that they would be able to trade free and in a sound way. That would be good for the economy. They thought the zamindars will return back and give attention to the land. As a result the partition of Bengal was accepted by muslim community. The Muslim considered the Hindus as their antagonist and the Hindus were against the partition of Bengal. So they thought they had won against the Hindus.

Views of the Hindu community:

The partition of Bengal held in 1905 by lord Curzon, the neglected and lagged behind were happy but the Hindus could not accept the decision taken by the British authority. They thought they will not be able to flourish their progress of economy. The landlords and capitalist society could not accept the decision.

Following reasons were most worthy for the contradiction characters of the hindu:

The officials of the Calcutta assumed that Chittagong port will make room for the east and the importance of Calcutta port will decrease.

Business from Calcutta dependent on the customer from east Bengal. So they feared losing their business if a new high court establish in Dhaka, the capital of the newly formed province.

The maximum newspaper were published from western part and the owner of the newspaper were from west bangle. They feared if any newspaper introduce in the eastern part, they will face loss in their business.

The zamindars thought the cultivators of the east will go against the revenue system. So they were afraid of this partition of Bengal.

The officials of the west thought that they will lose their power on the Indian politics. That's why they were against the partition of Bengal.¹¹

The partition has also left a significant impact on the people of Bengal as well as those belonging to the subcontinent. Partition triggered riots and an unavoidable and colossal wave of population in hundreds and thousands of people moving to what they hoped would be their new territory.¹²

¹¹ Chatterjee (2000). *Partitioned lives : narratives of home, displacement, and resettlement*. New Delhi : Penguin (India) pp. 66-68.

¹² Chatterjee (2004). *The Partition of Bengal and Assam 1932-47*. New Delhi. p. 108.

In July 1905, when Lord Curzon decided dividing the Bengal and announced the Partition of Bengal in Simla, and there was a lot of reaction in Bengal. People of different parts of Bengal and newspapers started to protest against British imperialist plot. When Mr. Curzon declared his decision to declare "the decision of Partition of Bengal", Surendra Nath Banerjee assured him that "I will make a change of this firm decision".¹³ Lord Curzon remained firm on the decision of partition of Bengal on October 16, 1905, ignoring all protests and criticism of the people of Bengal. As a result, the entire Bengali became the target of protest on that day. According to Rabindranath Tagore's proposal, 'Rakhi Bandhan Utsav' was celebrated on the same day as a symbol of communal harmony.¹⁴ On the advice of Ramendrasundar Trivedi, 'Arandhan' was celebrated at home in the house as a symbol of unity among Bengalis. Hats, shops, school colleges, courts are closed. Millions of people in Bengal joined in a procession, protest meeting and strike. The movement against the partition of Bengal came in the form of a mass movement. The government followed strict harsh regimes to protest against the protesters. The nationalist journalism is a vocal tone. The publication of the *Jugantar* was stopped by the government order. The editor of 'Sandhya', the editor of *Brahmabandhopadhyay* Upadhyay, was charged with raising anti-British attitudes. Another newspaper 'Barisal Hitiyashi' was attacked by government suppression policy. The government was a bit relieved due to the absence of corruption. At this time, on July 13, 1905, in the editorial article 'Sanjivani', edited by Krishnakumar Mitra, the first public boycott movement was launched against the English government. He urged the countrymen to boycott foreign goods and to use swadeshi and pressurize the British government. His boycott and Swadeshi movement won the heart of the ideal countrymen.

The anti-British movement or Swadeshi Movement gained popularity as the anti-partition movement that started in 1905 against the partition of Bengal. A swadeshi of the joint character of this movement and the other is known as boycott. 'Swadeshi' and 'Boycott' were the main pillars of the anti-partition movement.

¹³ Banerjee, Surendra (1997). *Caste, Protest and Identity in Colonial India: The Namasudras of Bengal*. Calcutta: 1997. p. 115.

Lahore Resolution

The Resolution adopted at the general session of the Muslim League. In 1940 Mohammed Ali Jinnah called a general session of the All India Muslim League in Lahore to discuss the situation created due to the outbreak of the Second World War and the Government of India fighting the war without taking the opinion of the Indian leaders, and also to analyse the reasons for the defeat of the Muslim League in the general election of 1937 in the Muslim majority provinces.

Quaid-e-Azam Jinnah left with a small group of Muslim League workers for Lahore on 28 March 1940. AK Fazlul Huq led the Bengal Muslim League contingent and reached Lahore on 30 March. The Chief Ministers of Bengal and the Punjab were two dominant figures in the session.

Jinnah, in his speech, criticized the Congress and the nationalist Muslims, and espoused the Two-Nation Theory and the reasons for the demand for separate Muslim homelands. His speech caught the imagination of the Muslim masses. Sikandar Hayat Khan, the Chief Minister of the Punjab, drafted the original Lahore Resolution, which was placed before the Executive Committee of the All India Muslim League for discussion and amendments. The Resolution, radically amended by the Subject Committee, was moved in the general session by AK Fazlul Huq on 23 March and was supported by Choudhury Khaliquzzaman and other Muslim leaders. The Lahore Resolution ran as follows:

"The areas where the Muslims are numerically in a majority as in the Northwestern and Eastern zones of India should be grouped to constitute 'independent states' in which the constituent units shall be autonomous and sovereign.

The Resolution was adopted on 24 March with great enthusiasm. The Hindu Press dubbed it as 'Pakistan Demand', after the scheme invented by Rahmat Ali, an Indian Muslim living at Cambridge. The 1940 resolution nowhere mentioned Pakistan and in asking for 'independent states' the spokesmen of the League were far from clear what was intended. The Hindu press led to the Muslim leadership a concerted slogan, which immediately conveyed to them the idea of a state. It would have taken long for the Muslim leaders to explain the Lahore Resolution and convey its real meaning and significance to the Muslim masses. Years of labor of the Muslim leaders to propagate its full importance amongst the masses was shortened by the Hindu Press in naming the Resolution as the 'Pakistan Resolution'. By emphasizing the idea of Pakistan the Hindu press succeeded in converting a wordy and clouded lawyer's formula into a clarion

call for the Muslims of Bengal, who were searching for an identity throughout the nineteenth and early twentieth centuries, finally found it in the Lahore Resolution. The Lahore Resolution gave them

a sense of nationhood. Henceforth the dominant theme in Muslim politics was not against Hindu injustice, but a demand for separate political existence.

On 15 April 1941 the Lahore Resolution was incorporated as a creed in the constitution of the All-India Muslim League in its Madras session. It continued to be the League's creed until its dissolution after the independence of Pakistan in 1947.

Indeed, from 1940 onward, Pakistan was the great talking point of the Indian independence debate. When the cabinet mission arrived in India in March 1946 to consult Indian leaders to help facilitate self-government, the All India Muslim League decided to hold a Convention of the members of the Central and Provincial Legislatures belonging to the Muslim League on 7 April at Delhi to reiterate their 'Pakistan Demand'. The Working Committee of the Muslim League had appointed a Sub Committee with Choudhury Khaliquzzaman, Ispahani, and others to draft a resolution to be placed before the Convention. Khaliquzzaman prepared a draft of the resolution, which was discussed with other members after some minor changes here and there, was approved by the Sub Committee and the Subject Committee. This resolution made a fundamental departure from the original Lahore Resolution in using the word 'state' in the singular replacing the term 'states'.

The resolution that was placed before the Delhi Convention of Muslim Legislators included the principle that the zones comprising Bengal and Assam in the Northeast, Punjab, North West Frontier Province, Sind and Baluchistan in the Northwest of India be constituted into Pakistan zones, where the Muslims are in a dominant majority, be constituted into a separate independent 'state' and that an unequivocal undertaking be given to implement the establishment of Pakistan without delay. The Committee did not question the change.

The resolution was proposed in the open session by Suhrawardy and seconded by Choudhury Khaliquzzaman. Abul Hashim claimed that he raised the voice of protest against the resolution at a point of order in the Subject Committee on the previous day when Jinnah placed it before the Committee. He maintained that the draft resolution looked like an amendment of the Lahore Resolution though it had not been said or it was not placed in the form of amendment to the Lahore Resolution. He claimed to have argued that the Lahore Resolution envisaged sovereign states in Northeastern and Northwestern zones of India, and the Resolution accepted by the All-India Muslim League in its Madras session of 1941 as the creed of the political party. He claimed to have insisted that the Convention of the Muslim League was not competent to alter or modify the contents of the Lahore Resolution.

Jinnah at first took the plural 's' of the Lahore Resolution as an 'obvious printing mistake'. When, on Abul Hashim's insistence, the original minute book was checked, Jinnah found his own signature the plural 's'. Abul Hashim claimed that he had suggested for erasing the 'one' and replace it with 'a'. Jinnah is said to have accepted Abul Hashim's suggestion. As

am, Suhrawardy placed in the open session of the Convention a modified form of the on Jinnah's advice.

therefore, appear that even after the Delhi Convention of the Muslim Legislators Jinnah thinking in terms of amending the Lahore Resolution. The Subject Committee presided Jinnah seemingly accepted the constitutional position that the Convention of the Muslim was not the forum competent to amend the Lahore Resolution. Nor could Jinnah after the General Election in the country in which the Muslim League contested on the the Lahore Resolution. He assured the Muslim League leaders from Bengal who met a deputation that the Lahore Resolution was not amended. At his Malbari Hill House on 9-16 Jinnah encouraged Abul Hashim to work on the basis of the Lahore Resolution.

Riot of 1946 ✓

Just before India got Independence from British rule, Bengal witnessed one of the worst communal riots and massacres in its history on August 16, 1947. Known as 'Direct Action Day' or 'the Great Calcutta Killings', violence erupted between Hindu and Muslim communities. The Muslim League, under Muhammad Ali Jinnah, held a mass rally demanding a separate country, which later became Pakistan.

The communal riots left around 5,000 people dead and a lakh residents homeless in Calcutta in 72 hours. The widespread violence laid the groundwork for India's Partition.

What Led To The Communal Riots?

By 1940, the Muslim League, one of the two largest parties apart from the Indian National Congress, started demanding independent states for the Muslim-majority areas in the northwest and the east -- which later became Pakistan and Bangladesh respectively.

In 1946, then British Prime Minister Clement Attlee had sent a three-member Cabinet mission to India in a bid to finalise plans for the transfer of power to the Indian leadership.

The commission, while rejecting the Muslim League's demand for a separate state, proposed a three-tier structure -- a centre, groups of provinces, and separate provinces. The commission recommended that these "groups of provinces" would accommodate the Muslim League's demand of independent states in Muslim-majority regions.

Both the Muslim League and Congress accepted the suggestions initially.

However, things took a turn after then Congress president Jawaharlal Nehru, in a press conference on July 10, 1946, said the party had the right to modify the plan of the Cabinet Mission plan.

His remark was vehemently objected by the Muslim League leaders, who feared a domination by the majority Hindus in the Central government after the transfer of power from British.

Backed by Muslim League politicians, Jinnah rejected the British Cabinet mission's plan for transfer of power to a caretaker government and decided to boycott the Constituent Assembly.

Days later, Jinnah announced that his Muslim League would take "direct action" if a separate state of Pakistan was not allowed to be created.

On July 29, 1946, the Muslim League passed a resolution declaring August 16 as "Direct Action Day" and announced a nationwide protest against the Congress' stand and called for suspension of all business.

The tension was palpable and the entire country was on tenterhooks. The rift between Hindus and Muslims had already deepened.

What Happened On August 16, 1946, In Bengal?

In 1946, Bengal was under Muslim League's rule and was thus a suitable place for the Muslim League to carry out its demonstration. Then Saheed Suhrawardy was the chief minister of Bengal.

As August 16 came, Jinnah, in a warning to the Congress, said, "We do not want war. We want war we accept your offer unhesitatingly. We will either have a divided India or a desolate India."

A massive rally by Suhrawardy was planned and members of the Muslim League and people from the community from different parts gathered at Ochterlony Monument, now Shaheed Minar, near the Maidan in Calcutta.

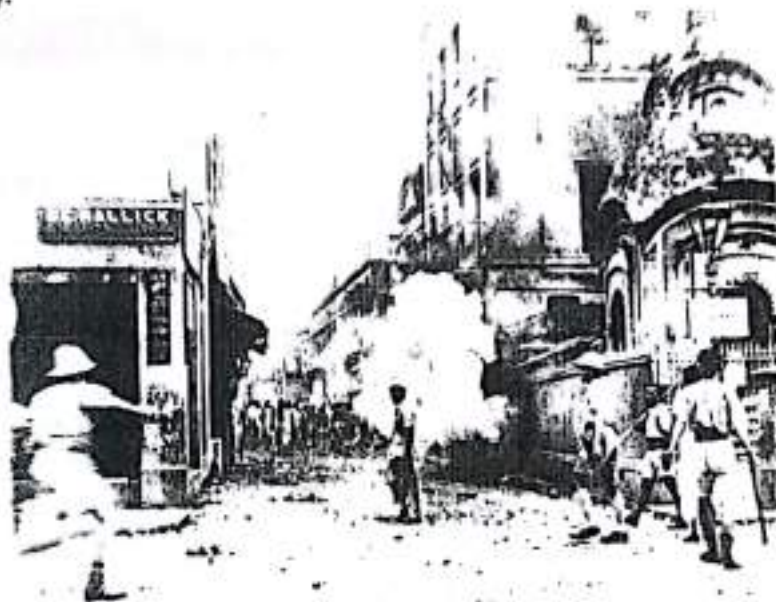
Inflammatory speeches by Muslim League leaders at the rally whipped up the crowd leading to large-scale violence and arson. Even before the rally began, tensions were running high with instances of forced shutting down of shops and pelting of stones in the morning.

The riots saw women being raped and torching of several institutions in Calcutta. The riots had a domino effect and soon spread to Noakhali in East Bengal, where houses of Hindus were on fire, Punjab and the North Western Frontier Province regions.

The violence, which continued for nearly a week, came to be known as the "Week of the Knives". The cycle of riots finally came to an end when Bengal was put under Governor's rule on August 21.

While the riots left a deep scar in the history of Calcutta, it brought to fore the brave activists like Gopal Chandra Mukherjee, also known as 'Gopal Patha', who played a significant role in mobilising groups of youths to protect Hindu families and give shelter to those homeless.

The unprecedented violence finally resulted in Congress under Nehru accepting the Partition of the country.



Policemen attempt to stop riots in Calcutta (Getty)

Partition of India 1947 ✓

partition of India has had various factors which has been put forward by the scholars. It includes religious issues, ethnicity, citizenship, politics and a civil conflict. Also other factors included the British which was blamed for manipulating religion since Britain was divide and rule. Therefore one can address the issue as a blunder on both sides of Hindu and Moslem because they failed to work together to solve their difference. More so the fact that Moslem in India which was not popular and the fact that Moslem religion was foreign to Indians which made Moslems unpopular. The other issue was civilisation which led to the partition of India. Other issues are the words which Hindus used such as minority and majority which led the Moslem to want a separate state so that they could have their own. Some scholars used the death of Gandhi as way to notify that it was not possible for Muslims and Hindu to coexist together.

One major cause of the partition was religion which most scholars have argued that this was the blow for India. Muhammad Ali Jinnah's two nation theory projected the argument for partition as one rooted in a vision of Hinduism and Islam as embodying opposing ways of life according to Gottschalk¹. This shows that the Muslims wanted live separately with Hindus in the same way the same with Hindus. Therefore one can argue that religion was the central idea for the partition of India since conflict of religion was obvious which could lead to civil war. However some scholars argue against the point that religion plays no role in the partition. However Gottschalk stated that their story nevertheless provides a critical overarching frame for the history of the religious polarities that produced partition². This shows religion was never a major problem which could have led to the partition because in the past no history of clash was recorded which could lead to partition. Moreover religion plays a role in the partition because it was used as an outstanding factor therefore religion was major cause of the partition.

Furthermore power hungry leaders of India are blamed for the partition of India because these leaders wanted to grasp power without considering the consequences of partition. Some writers of history hold the view that the Indian leader's mostly tired old men, sacrificed national causes by seizing the first opportunity to grasp power and this hastily accepted the partition of India according to Ali, Rabia Umar³. This was true in the case of India because the partition could have been not taken place but the fact was that Indian Politicians could wait to grasp power for the first time and agree to the fact of partition the idea which still hounds Indians today. One can argue that the Indians could have prevented the partition by rejecting the proposal of partition by the Muslims and try to sort out the difference between Muslims and Hindus. Also some politicians saw the partition as way of getting rid of some of their opponents which was not the case. Therefore one can argue that power hungry leaders of India also contributed to the partition of India.

¹ Gottschalk (2015). The Historiography of India's Partition: Between Civilization and Religion. *The Journal of Asian Studies*, 74, p.25

² p. 14

³ Rabia Umar "Planning for the Partition of India: 1947 A Scuttled Affair," *Journal of History and Culture* XXX, 1 (2009): 113-130.p.117

situation to advocate for the separate which take place which means that the fact Britain was the major reason for the partition.

Furthermore the Muslim families who own land are also a contributing factor in the partition of India. Strong support for the idea of an independent Pakistan came from large Muslim landowning families in the Punjab and Sindh, who saw it as an opportunity to prosper within a captive market free from competition according to C.Bates⁴. This show that the Muslim did not want competition from Hindus which lead to the partition of India. Also other scholars agree that some Muslims were indebted to the Hindus which then culminated many Muslims supporting partition of India. Therefore one can argue that the partition of India was as result of the conflict of elites who wanted some gains and power during the independence of India. More so one can states that both Muslims and Indians played a crucial role in the partition of India because factors are not one sided but from both sides.

In addition the voting system which was used by the Muslim league which has been contributed by the scholars as the contributing factor. The leaders of the Muslim advocated for a separate electoral system which favored Muslim. Indeed, the structural framework offered by separate electorates provides us a critical backdrop for understanding the Muslim League's adoption in 1940 of the demand for Pakistan according D .Gilmartin⁹. This show that separate electorate system allowed Muslim to maneuver the idea of creating a different state Pakistan which cater for the need of a Muslim state. Therefore one can argue that nationalism of Muslims can be traced in the 1940 when they advocated a different electoral system in order to pave way a for a partition of India.

All in all several factors played crucial role in the partition of India which include religion, citizenship, Britain tactics such as divide and rule which lead to separation between Muslims and Hindus and the platforms such as Muslim league which enable Muslims to voice ideas which lead to partition. Therefore in a nutshell religion was a major factor which contributes to the partition of India.

Bibliography

- Ali, Palwa Umar. "Planning for the Partition of India: 1947 A Scuttled Affair." *Pakistan Journal of History and Culture* XXX. 1 (2009): 113-130.
- Bates C. The Hidden Story of Partition and its Legacies, Edinburgh University, 2011
- Bates C. The Hidden Story of Partition and its Legacies, Edinburgh University, 2011,p.6
- Gilmartin, Partition, Pakistan and South Asia History: IN Search of a Narrative, The Journal of Asian Studies and 57, NO.40, 1998, P.1079, WWW.JSTOR.ORG, ACCESSED 14-03-2018

Gilmartin, D. Partition, Pakistan and South Asia History: IN Search of a Narrative, The Journal of Asian Studies, vol. 57, No. 40, 1998, WWW.JSTOR.ORG, ACCESSED 14-03-2018

Gilmartin, D. (2015). The Historiography of India's Partition: Between Civilization and Modernity. The Journal of Asian Studies, 74,

Pandey, G. Can a Muslim Be an Indian?, Comparative Studies in Society and History, Vol. 41, No. 1 (Oct., 1999), www.jstor.org.com, accessed 03-06-09.

Two-Nations
partition Theory

CHAPTER 10

Partition

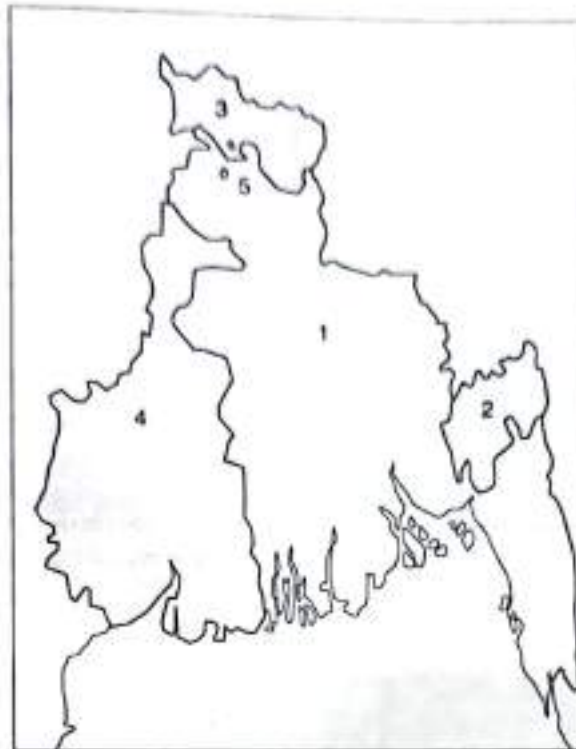
In the early 1940s, the Bengal famine had played havoc with the delta's social fabric. Now, in 1947, the Partition of India tore that fabric asunder. Without an understanding of Partition and its effects, it is not possible to make sense of contemporary Bangladesh. True, the shock of 1947 is no longer a living memory for the vast majority of Bangladeshis – but it created economic facts, historical myths and political mindsets that continue to haunt society today.

The Partition of India was a geographical solution to a political fiasco. The partitioner's knife cut through three provinces (Bengal, Assam and Punjab) and through innumerable trade routes and family ties. It created two long borders and left the partitioned societies in shambles, ruining millions of lives and upsetting cherished social arrangements. Many of the effects were unintended, unanticipated and long term.

The province of Bengal bore the full brunt: it was divided between the two new states. It is usually assumed that Bengal was cut in two. The reality is far more complicated: it was cut into no fewer than 201 pieces (Map 10.1). Pakistan received the largest part of the province's territory (64 per cent) and the majority of its population (65 per cent). Smaller sections to the west, north and east joined the new Republic of India, and the two states divided 197 tiny enclaves between them (see box 'Lives in limbo').

Pakistan's territory was augmented by the addition of most of Sylhet, a district that had been administered as part of Assam. The combined territory was generally referred to as East Pakistan (although from 1947 to 1955 its official name was East Bengal). It shared a 4,000 km-border with India. When East Pakistan seceded from Pakistan in 1971 to become Bangladesh there were no changes to its territorial shape. In other words, the geographical unit that we now know as Bangladesh was fashioned in 1947, well before anybody could imagine an independent Bangladesh.

two Boundary Commissions (for Punjab and Bengal) were formed to decide where the new borders between Pakistan and India should be drawn. These commissions – both headed by the same chairman, Cyril Radcliffe – were besieged by lobbyists trying to sway the verdict. In the end, neither of the two commissions could come to a unanimous decision and the chairman had to take responsibility for the territorial dismemberment of the colony.



Map 10.1. The 201 parts of partitioned Bengal. 1, East Bengal (sixteen districts of Bengal that joined Pakistan in 1947); 2, The Princely State of Tripura that joined India in 1949; 3, North Bengal (two districts that joined India in 1947, and the Princely State of Cooch Behar that joined India in 1950); 4, West Bengal (twelve districts that joined India in 1947); 5, 197 enclaves.

Lives in limbo

One of the most bizarre outcomes of the Partition of India was the creation of 197 enclaves in north Bengal. For some people in the northern borderland, Partition meant the end of effective citizenship. Although they were in every respect similar to their neighbours, these people happened to be living in villages that were now – for quirky historical reasons going back to the precolonial period – distributed to India and Pakistan, even though they were completely surrounded by the territory of the other state. Thus in a band of some 100 km there were 123 Indian enclaves that lay surrounded by Pakistan and 74 Pakistani enclaves that lay dispersed in Indian territory. To make matters worse, India and Pakistan were not on good terms and refused to let each other's officials cross their territory to reach the enclaves. As a result, state presence in the enclaves came to an end. There was no taxation, but also

no police, schools, health services, land registration, banks, postal services or road maintenance. Neither India nor Pakistan was happy with this unanticipated situation and soon talks were underway to exchange the enclaves. It proved impossible to agree, however, and today little has changed, except that the Pakistani enclaves have become Bangladeshi.

The inhabitants of the enclaves are forced to lead shadowy lives. They must break numerous laws as they go about their daily business. For example, imagine you are Abdul Bari, a young inhabitant of the Bangladeshi enclave of Nolgram, surrounded by the territory of West Bengal (India) (Plate 10.1). When you visit your uncle or go to market in the next village (there are no markets in the enclaves), you cross an international border (between Nolgram and India) without a proper passport or a visa, and without permission to take across whatever you buy or sell, or indeed to use Indian currency. You are a non-citizen, an illegal entrant and a smuggler.

Abdul Bari may be a Bangladeshi citizen but only in the most tenuous sense: he has never had any dealings with Bangladeshi officials (who cannot visit the enclave and who are unaware of his existence), and he does not possess any documents to prove his identity. He has been effectively stateless since his (unregistered) birth. His siblings cannot go to school or see a doctor



Plate 10.1. People and border pillar in Nolgram, a Bangladeshi enclave surrounded by Indian territory.

without giving a false (Indian) identity. And who will protect him and his possessions against robbers? There are no police in Nolgram and the Indian police cannot enter there.

To cope with this absurd life thrust upon them by bureaucratic caprice and political stalemate, enclave people have developed their own local institutions, such as enclave citizens' committees, land registration systems or some semblance of public works through *corvée* labour. These differ from one enclave to the next but all enclave people share a sense of pride in their resilience after sixty years of living in limbo: 'We people of the enclave can cope with anything.'



Map 10.2. The Partition border and Muslim (grey) and non-Muslim (white) majority areas in 1947. 1, Khulna; 2, Chittagong Hill Tracts; 3, Murshidabad.

Map 10.2 shows that it was not easy to translate the idea of a homeland for Muslims into a geographical reality. The Boundary Commission allocated considerable non-Muslim-majority areas to Pakistan (for example Khulna in the south-west and the Chittagong Hill Tracts in the south-east) and, conversely, allocated Muslim-majority areas such as Murshidabad to India. The members of the Boundary Commission never explained or justified these anomalies. Historians assume, however, that one reason for Murshidabad – whose population was 57 per cent Muslim – to be awarded to India was an attempt to keep the port of Kolkata linked to the

Ganges/Bhagirathi river system serving its hinterland. Similarly, the Chittagong Hill Tracts – whose Muslim population was a mere 4 per cent – went to Pakistan to keep the port of Chittagong connected with the Karnaphuli river system. Border-making threw up many other anomalies, surprises and ambiguities, and these led immediately to recrimination between India and Pakistan. Over time quite a few points of disagreement were sorted out, but today India and Bangladesh still bicker about numerous territorial issues. These frictions show up in frequent border incidents, often with casualties, all along the partition border.²

Some parts of the new international border followed old divisions between lowland and hills or pre-existing administrative borders between districts – but other stretches of the new border lopped off parts of districts and necessitated their rearrangement.³ Thus Pakistan received half of Dinajpur and Nadia (renamed Kushtia) and other districts gained territory (for example Rajshahi) or lost it (for example Jessore, Sylhet). When the dust of Partition settled, East Pakistan had sixteen districts. In 1969 that number rose to eighteen when two more districts were created: Tangail was carved out of Mymensingh and Patuakhali out of Barisal (Map 10.3).

The point of Partition was to create a homeland for Muslims. In Bengal, Islam had become a mass religion in the Mughal period, when the fertile eastern delta was brought under the plough. It was no surprise, therefore, that East Pakistan's centre of gravity was the active eastern delta and that its population was overwhelmingly rural. Dhaka, the city now chosen to be the provincial capital, was the very one that the Mughals had built up to control the marshes and riverscapes of what they had called 'Bhati' and the British later referred to as 'Lower Bengal'.

For the first time in its history, the Bengal delta was encased in a modern international border, a phenomenon that its inhabitants had no previous experience of whatsoever. The new border encircled most Muslim-majority areas of Bengal and in that sense East Pakistan became the homeland of most of Bengal's Muslims. But millions of Bengali Muslims were now in Indian territory and millions of non-Muslims continued to live in East Pakistan. No less than 42 per cent of the total Pakistani citizens; they made up one fifth of East Pakistan's population. This ensured that the political fiasco that had prompted Partition in the first place – the inability to overcome communalist politics – was set to carry on under the new dispensation. In Bengal, it took a course that



Map 10.3. Districts of East Pakistan, 1947-71.

differed from the one in Punjab where a swift, bloody and almost complete exchange of Muslim and non-Muslim inhabitants occurred in the months around Partition. The scenario in Bengal did include massive population exchange, but it was a much slower, longer and complicated process.⁴

Intaz the fivefold citizen

Intaz Ali was born in 1947 and he grew up in a Muslim family in Chor Madhobpur, a rural community on the south bank of the Ganges. When he was an infant Bengal was partitioned and his village became part of the territory of East Pakistan. Intaz became a Pakistani boy. Soon the villagers learned that the new states of India and Pakistan were quarrelling over them. India claimed possession of Intaz's village and of many others on the banks and islands (chor; *car*) of the Ganges (Plate 10.2). There were border skirmishes and conferences, but to no avail. Not being able to resolve the issue themselves, the governments of India and Pakistan decided to go for arbitration. They set up an international tribunal and promised to abide by its decision.

When Intaz was in primary school, he and his fellow villagers learned that the Bagge Tribunal – named after its Swedish chairman – had awarded their village to India. What to do? Were they Indians or Pakistanis? More to the point: should he now go to high school in the nearest town in Pakistan or in India? It was a hard decision to take because nobody knew whether the tribunal's verdict was going to be implemented. It was now unclear to them whether their community was still in Pakistan or had become part of India. In late 1959 Intaz's father could wait no longer. He made up his mind and sent Intaz to a high school on the Indian side. He also changed his son's citizenship to Indian so that he could attend that school. But three years later anti-Muslim disturbances broke out in Intaz's village, and his father sent him across to Pakistan for safety. It was there, in the nearby border town of



Plate 10.2. On a Ganges river island, near the Indian border.

Rajshahi, that Intaz completed his high school and eventually became a Pakistani citizen again. A few years later, however, East Pakistan broke away from Pakistan to become Bangladesh. Now Intaz made the fourth 'nation-switch' of his twenty-four-year life. A fivefold serial citizen, he had become something of a record holder – from British Indian to Pakistani to Indian to Pakistani to Bangladeshi.

The states of India and Pakistan set out to demarcate the border and take control of their sides of the new borderland.⁵ Meanwhile, those who lived there realised only gradually what had happened. At first the vivisection of their social world seemed unreal and many thought that Pakistan and India would reunite after some time. As the irreversibility of Partition sank in, however, they had to come to terms with the fact that geography was destiny: they were now assigned the citizenship of one of a pair of distinct – and squabbling – states (see box 'Intaz the fivefold citizen'). A new state, Pakistan, took charge of the territory and the people of eastern Bengal. It built up institutions and set in motion new processes, many of which would survive the demise of Pakistan in 1971.

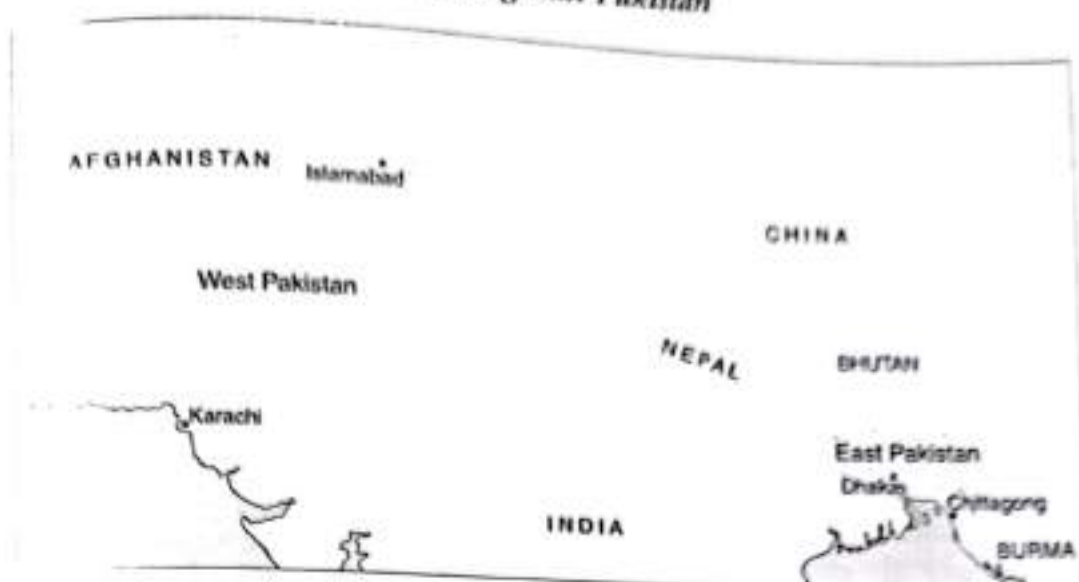
The Pakistan Experiment

Under its new name – East Pakistan – the Bengal delta now joined a unique experiment in state-making.¹ There were three reasons why Pakistan was a very special state. First, it was founded upon religious nationalism. Religion was supposed to cement a new national identity, something that had not been tried before – the only other modern example of a religiously based nation-state being Israel, which was founded a year later than Pakistan. Second, Pakistan was a state administering two discrete territories, separated from each other by about 1,500 km of Indian terrain (Map 12.1). West Pakistan was by far the larger of these two wings, but East Pakistan was more densely populated. In fact, most Pakistani citizens lived in East Pakistan: the first population census in 1951 revealed that Pakistan had 78 million inhabitants, of whom 44 million (55 per cent) lived in East Pakistan.

These two factors combined with a third: Pakistan did not become heir to any of the colony's central state institutions. India, on the other hand, inherited the capital New Delhi as well as most of the civil bureaucracy, armed forces and police. The bulk of the colony's resources and industries, and its major port cities of Mumbai (Bombay) and Kolkata, also went to India. By contrast, Pakistan inherited largely raw-material producing regions. Whereas the new rulers of India supplanted the British in the old centre of colonial power, the new rulers of Pakistan had a much longer time to establish themselves. In other words, Pakistan was uniquely experimental: no other post-colonial state combined the loss of its administrative hub, the need to govern two unconnected territories and the ambition to base a national identity on a religious one.

In the eastern 'wing' of the country the situation was especially difficult. In August 1947, 'the new East Pakistan government was hastily housed in a College for Girls [Eden College in Dhaka], with a large number of improvised

¹ Initially the eastern wing of Pakistan was known officially as 'East Bengal'. It became 'East Pakistan' in 1956.



Map 12.1 The two wings of Pakistan, 1947-71.

bamboo sheds added to it for greater accommodation. On partition, East Pakistan received only one member of the former Indian Civil Service [the élite corps of colonial bureaucrats, the “steel frame” that had kept the colony together] who belonged to that region. Six others were hastily promoted from the Provincial Civil Service.” As a result, the civil service of East Pakistan was largely non-local, and decision-making was in the hands of officials with little knowledge of East Pakistan’s needs. An official publication described the predicament of the administrators in heroic terms:

For the many directorates there was no accommodation at all and these were sent to outlying districts. One Minister sat in a boat on the Buriganga river, disposing of files and transacting official business. Hundreds of officers chummed together in one-room tenements. Even camps were a luxury and bamboo constructions sprang up to provide shelters for officials and staff who were used to comfortable colonial flats and rooms.²

The General Officer Commanding (East Bengal), who arrived in January 1948, later reminisced:

The provincial government ... was newly formed and poorly staffed. But worse still, it was politically weak and unstable. There was no army. All we had in East Pakistan at the time of Independence were two infantry battalions [one with three companies and one with only two companies]. We had very poor accommodation: at Headquarters there was no table, no chair, no stationery ... we had virtually nothing at all; not even any maps of East Pakistan.³

These initial uncertainties and the artificial nature of Pakistan's unity fuelled the desire for a strong, centralised state and a robust national identity. The ruling party, the Muslim League, benefited from the prevailing mood in Pakistan, which was one of exultation. Having attained a sovereign homeland, Muslims could now safeguard their political, religious and cultural rights and they could complete their economic emancipation. But it did not take long for them to realise that the road ahead was anything but smooth: the two elements that most Pakistanis shared – an Islamic identity and a fear of India – proved insufficient to keep them united. Immediately fights broke out over the equitable distribution of resources, both material and symbolic. Only three months after independence a first serious crack in the edifice of Pakistan appeared over the question of the national language. It was the initial portent of enormous tensions over how the new state should be organised and imagined. These strains would gradually spoil the prospect of building a Pakistani nation. Right from the beginning, they took the form of a confrontation between Pakistan's two wings over issues such as language, autonomy, food security and economic policy. In the unfolding drama of Pakistani politics, the Bengal delta would play the role of the disenfranchised sibling clamouring consistently and unsuccessfully for rights withheld. Throughout the twenty-four years of the Pakistan experiment, the country's various rulers shared two nightmares: to be humiliated by India and to see control of the state pass democratically to East Pakistan. The latter fear would be their undoing. It animated an extraordinary political obstinacy that would, in the end, lead them to wage war on the majority of Pakistan's citizens. This strategy blew up in their faces, resulted in their utter humiliation by India and left them no other choice but to separate themselves from East Pakistan and hang on to what was left of their power in the western wing, which they renamed Pakistan.

LANGUAGE

In 1947 the new Pakistani elite faced the difficult task of welding its citizens into a united Pakistani nation. Immediately the question arose of the language in which to conduct Pakistan's state business. The Pakistan Educational Conference of November 1947 proposed Urdu as the national language, a suggestion that was opposed by representatives from East Pakistan. A few months later an East Pakistan member of the Constituent Assembly tabled an amendment to allow the Bengali language to be used in the Assembly alongside Urdu. He was sharply rebutted by the prime minister, Liaquat Ali Khan, who averred:

Pakistan has been created because of the demand of a hundred million Muslims in this subcontinent and the language of a hundred million Muslims is Urdu . . . It is necessary for a nation to have one language and that language can only be Urdu and no other language.⁴

This was a quite extraordinary statement in view of the fact that Pakistanis spoke dozens of languages and that Urdu was spoken by only 3 per cent of them. Bengali was very clearly the principal language of the country: it was spoken by 56 per cent of all Pakistanis.⁵ So why was the prime minister so adamant about Urdu?

The language issue stood for a more general cultural and political divide within the fledgling state. Muslim politicians in Bengal had imagined Pakistan differently from their counterparts in northern India. The Bengalis had dreamed of a land free from the economic domination of Hindus, and they imagined a leading role for themselves as representatives of the majority of Pakistan's citizens. Northern Indian Muslim politicians, on the other hand, had pictured themselves as the natural leaders of Pakistan because they considered themselves to be the guardians of the Muslim renaissance movement in South Asia and, therefore, arbiters of the future of all Muslims. They insisted that their vision of Pakistan should rightfully take precedence.

From the beginning, the 'northern Indian' view dominated the institutions of state. There were two regional groups that endorsed it. The first became known as the Muhajirs (= migrants). They were largely members of Urdu-speaking intellectual and trading elites from northern India who moved to Pakistan's cities in their hundreds of thousands and immediately exerted an influence on politics and social life that was way out of proportion to their numbers. What made them unusual immigrants was that many of them expected the local population to adapt to them rather than the other way around. They took hold of almost all higher positions in the administration and the executive power. Most of these immigrants settled in West Pakistan, but over 100,000 Muhajirs made their new homes in East Pakistan.

The second regional group was Muslims from Punjab. They were heavily over-represented in the armed forces, manned the state administration and controlled valuable irrigated land. The Punjabis progressively outflanked the Muhajirs to become the hegemonic power in Pakistan. This was symbolised in 1959 by the transfer of the capital from Karachi (Pakistan's prime Muhajir city) to the Punjab garrison town of Rawalpindi and from there to newly constructed Islamabad a decade later (Map 12.1).

The Bengali political elite took exception to the northern Indian view of Pakistan's future. But after Partition, ironically, power in the East Pakistan

The Pakistan Experiment

branch of the Muslim League had shifted away from them. A non-Bengali coterie now ran the provincial party: 'the Muslim League remained mired in the hands of the Urdu-speaking nawabs of Dhaka, for its leadership, to the owner of the daily *Azad* for its publicity, and to the commercial house of the [immigrant] Ispahanis for its finance'.⁶ The Muslim League hardly represented the voice of East Pakistan, and it was weakly pushed back against the northern Indian view. Predictably, political opposition began to build up immediately.

In their search for legitimacy, Pakistan's new rulers used Islam as a political idiom to justify their actions. This attitude broke with the 500-year tradition of Muslim rulers in Bengal who had never propagated Islam as a political idiom to discipline their Bengali subjects. The West Pakistani political idiom caught the Bengalis in a quandary: their protests were easily dismissed as un- or anti-Islamic. But using Islam was no mere tactical ploy on the part of West Pakistani politicians: for them, it was a civilising mission. There was a widespread perception in West Pakistan that Bengali Muslims were only socially inferior but also lesser Muslims because they did not adhere to many of the cultural practices that northern Indians considered proper Islamic. The message from West Pakistan was that however passionate Bengalis might think of themselves as Muslims, they fell short of the norm and they could not be fully fledged Pakistanis unless they shed much of their Bengali identity. In this climate the dilemma for politicians from East Pakistan was that they needed constantly to underline their Islamic *bona fides* and at the same time defend a regional religious and cultural interest.

The language issue became the focal point of this conflict because imposing Urdu was part of a mission to 'Islamise' East Pakistan. Most in West Pakistan knew very little about the Bengali language but thought of it as in need of 'purification' from Hindu influences. To them Bengali script (evolved from Sanskrit), the Sanskrit vocabulary, the dominance of Hindus in the Bengali literary pantheon were all irksome (see box 'The Bengali script').⁷ The Bengali Muslims' obvious attachment to their language and literature was puzzling and their rejection of Urdu rather suspect.

The Bengali script

South Asia is a subcontinent of many languages but also of many different scripts. Most major languages use their own alphabet. Bengali or Bangla (*bāṅla*) is no exception. Written from left to right, its elegantly rounded letters hang from a headline (unlike English letters, which stand on a baseline) (Plate 12.)

The Bengali (or East Nagari) script evolved over centuries from the Brahmi script (see Chapter 2). It has more letters than the English alphabet (eleven vowels, thirty-six consonants and many composite letter forms) and these render sounds that are difficult to reproduce in English writing. Hence transliterations of Bengali have recourse to inconvenient dots and dashes (diacritical marks) to distinguish various sounds, such as *n/n̄h*, *s/s̄h* and *a/ā/ā̄*.

The visual distinctiveness of written Bengali had always been a matter of pleasure and appreciation for literate Bengalis. After the emergence of Pakistan, however, it took on a new meaning. The language movement made it politically significant. Now it was not just the language itself that grew into a symbol of resistance and cultural pride. Each Bengali letter could be used as a badge in the cultural guerrilla war. As a result, even today, the Bengali script is much more than just a way to write a language. It has become a deeply emotive emblem of cultural distinctiveness and self-respect.

আমার ভাইয়ের রক্তে রাঙানো একুশে ফেব্রুয়ারী আমি কি ভুলিতে পারি

Plate 12.1 A sample of Bengali writing.
*'How can I forget the twenty-first of February, splattered with my
brother's blood . . . ?'*

These are the first lines of a famous song of the 1950s, composed by Abdul Gaffar Chowdhury. They can be transcribed as 'Amar bhaier rokte rangano ekushe February ami ki bhulite pari?' Their formal transliteration is 'Āmār bhāiyer rakte rāṅāno ekuśe phebruyārī āmi ki bhulite pāri?'

When students in East Pakistan came to know about the plan to make Urdu the national language, they held meetings and demonstrations and then formed the first Language Action Committee in December 1947. Things came to a head in March 1948, when general strikes were observed in East Pakistan's towns and the movement's leaders were arrested and injured. Mohammad Ali Jinnah, governor-general of Pakistan at the time, visited Dhaka a few days later. Addressing a large audience, he stated that the Bengali language could be used in East Pakistan:

but let me make it clear to you that the state language of Pakistan is going to be Urdu and no other language. Anyone who tries to mislead you is really the enemy of Pakistan. Without one state language, no nation can remain tied up solidly together and function. Look at the history of other countries. Therefore, so far as

the state language is concerned, Pakistan's language shall be Urdu. But as I have said, it will come in time.⁸

This uncompromising attitude led to rapid disillusionment with the Muslim League government among East Pakistani intellectuals, civil servants, politicians and students.⁹ This was not just a matter of regional pride, cultural identity and democratic principles but also a reflection of frustrated career ambitions. Urdu-speaking candidates were preferred for jobs in the state bureaucracy; in East Pakistan, this excluded almost all locals (fewer than 1 per cent spoke Urdu as a second language) and favoured northern Indian immigrants.

The language movement, or Bhasha Andolon (*bhāṣā āndalan*), gave rise to a new type of politician in East Pakistan: the Bengali-speaking student agitator.¹⁰ Throughout the Pakistan period students at schools, colleges and universities often played a decisive role in turning political grievances into popular resistance and forcing the Pakistan state to change its policies. But in the late 1940s the state elite was undeterred in its civilising mission: in 1949 a government committee proposed that henceforth the Bengali language be written in the Arabic script:

East Pakistan being the major area of the new State, the language of this area should grow according to Muslim ideology . . . Adoption of the Arabic script is the first pre-requisite for the above purpose. It will help a natural flow of Arabic words and phrases . . . Persian and Urdu are the two best illustrations of the importance of the script and its effects on the cultural development of language.¹¹

The most critical event of the language movement, and a pivotal moment for the Pakistan experiment, occurred in early 1952. There was a growing sense of deprivation and disappointment in East Pakistan, and a feeling was spreading that a new form of colonial rule had replaced British imperialism. The language movement, which had declined after 1948, reignited when the new prime minister of Pakistan, Khwaja Nazimuddin, came to Dhaka and addressed a large crowd at a central green. When he announced that the people of East Pakistan could decide what would be the provincial language but only Urdu would be Pakistan's state language, there was a very angry reaction. Students responded with the slogan 'We demand Bengali as a national language!' (*rāṣṭrabhāṣā bāṅlā cāi!*). Dhaka University went on strike and a number of organisations called a protest meeting, chaired by Maulana Abdul Hamid Khan Bhashani. Bhashani was a long-term supporter of the idea of Pakistan who had broken with the Muslim League in 1949 to form a new party, the Awami [People's] Muslim League.¹² The meeting sharply denounced the decision

to make Urdu the state language and also rejected the government plan to introduce Arabic script for written Bengali. It decided to call a general strike (*hortal*; *hartal*) and demonstrations throughout East Pakistan on 21 February 1952.

The government imposed a ban on these demonstrations in Dhaka, and although some organisers hesitated to violate it, many students were determined to persevere. Thousands of boys and girls from schools and colleges all over Dhaka assembled on the campus of Dhaka University together with university students. They then started marching and shouting slogans. As soon as they passed the campus gates armed policemen baton-charged them. The students retaliated by throwing bricks, upon which the police used tear gas and then fired into the crowd. Many were injured, and five people, including a nine-year-old boy, were killed. Over the next few days more demonstrations, killings and arrests occurred, and a memorial was hastily erected on the spot where the first killings had taken place (Plate 12.2).

This memorial was removed by the authorities and recreated several times before it was replaced by a concrete monument, the Martyrs'



Plate 12.2 Students making a memorial for those who died defending the Bengali language, February 1952.

Memorial or Shohid Minar (*shahid minār*), in 1962 (Plate 12.3).¹³ Today this monument continues to be a focal point of national identity politics and there are martyrs' memorials in every delta town. The twenty-first of February (*Ekushe*) became a key national holiday, and in 1999, following a proposal by the Bangladesh government, UNESCO created International Mother Language Day, celebrated annually on 21 February.

The events of 1952 were critically important, and not just because the Pakistani armed forces had turned murderously violent against fellow Pakistanis demonstrating for their rights, thus exposing the brutal nature of the state's leadership. This had happened before, for instance in July 1948, when the army put down a police revolt in Dhaka. What made 1952 a defining moment was that it marked a sharp psychological rupture.¹⁴ For many in the Bengal delta, it signified the shattering of the dream of Pakistan and the beginning of a new political project, still hazy and fully supported by only a few: the search for a secular alternative to the communal idiom of Pakistan politics and for an autonomy that the delta had last experienced in pre-Mughal times.¹⁵



Plate 12.3 Central Martyrs' Memorial or Shohid Minar, Dhaka.

The Pakistan government completely failed to understand the depth of feeling underlying the language movement and the demand for regional autonomy for East Pakistan, first voiced formally during constitutional discussions in 1950. It critically misinterpreted the movement as a conspiracy by 'clever politicians and disruptionists from within the Muslim community and caste Hindus and communists from Calcutta as well as from inside Pakistan'.¹⁶ The Pakistan government would use this conspiracy theory time and again in an attempt to expose any East Pakistani protest as the work of puppets of, or conspirators with, the 'enemies of Pakistan' – among whom Hindus, communists and Indians figured prominently.

ELECTORAL POLITICS

The events of February 1952 turned East Pakistanis categorically against the Muslim League government. This became clear to all in 1954, when East Pakistan held its first provincial elections (the rulers of Pakistan did not dare concede national general elections until 1970, twenty-three years after the state was formed).¹⁷ The elections of 1954 were also the first elections ever in the Bengal delta on the basis of a universal adult franchise. Throughout East Pakistan, the ruling Muslim League was routed and deeply humiliated: out of 109 seats, it won only seven. In a West Pakistan newspaper this debacle was blamed on 'the attitude of businessmen and Government officers from West Pakistan [that] caused certain misunderstanding in the minds of the people of East Pakistan'.¹⁸ The language movement continued until 1956, when the Pakistan Constituent Assembly agreed to accept both Urdu and Bengali as state languages after all and Pakistan finally had a constitution.¹⁹ By that time, however, the struggle for autonomy among East Pakistanis had moved beyond the question of language.

The elections of 1954 were won by an alliance known as the United Front and its style of politics has dominated politics in the Bengal delta ever since. This style is best described as mobilising the street: it depends heavily on drumming up popular support by means of fiery speeches delivered at enormous public rallies, organising protest marches and general strikes, and issuing political manifestos. The United Front was a shaky coalition of parties sharing little more than being against the incumbent Muslim League. The largest of these parties was the Awami Muslim League; it alone topped about 46 per cent of the seats, replacing the discredited Muslim League as a new political organisation with broad legitimacy. The United Front's election manifesto consisted of twenty-one points. Four of these had

to do with language questions; others dealt with autonomy, citizens' rights and economic emancipation.

The economic demands reverberated strongly with the rural electorate. Most people in the eastern delta had imagined Pakistan first and foremost as a peasant utopia that would bring deliverance from Hindu landlords, merchants and moneylenders as well as an end to agrarian stagnation. Prosperity was far more important to them than the division of state power, language issues or religious disputes. They were enthusiastic about the manifesto points demanding that the zamindari system be abolished, agriculture modernised and floods controlled. The middle classes, on the other hand, were attracted to the idea of rationalising pay scales, reforming education and nationalising the jute trade. Economically, the first years of Pakistan had been a struggle. The defeat of the Muslim League was as much a verdict on its failure to bring prosperity as on its political and cultural arrogance.

The mid-1950s were a brief period of rekindled hope for East Pakistan's middle classes. To many it seemed that it might yet be possible to bring the state under the control of the people. In the British period the state had been distant and autocratic, and the early Pakistan state had turned out to be quite similar. Only a minuscule elite from East Pakistan had been allowed to take part in the Pakistan state, always on terms not of their own making. As a result, even the most powerful East Pakistanis never had a sense of owning the post-1947 state. The elections of 1954, however, gave them renewed hope of a real partnership. This hope was soon tempered, however, when the new government was summarily (and undemocratically) dismissed, initiating a four-year period of political confusion and instability.

In 1955 the Awami Muslim League renamed itself Awami League in order to stress its non-communal character. The party carried its reformist and secular message to a wide readership through its daily newspaper *Ittefaq* (Harmony). Events at the apex of the Pakistan state strengthened its appeal. Awami Leaguers walked out of the Constituent Assembly in protest against Pakistan's first constitution, which did not meet the party's long-standing demands. Nevertheless, the constitution came into force in March 1956 and the National Assembly was inaugurated (Plate 12.4). The constitution declared Pakistan an Islamic state and installed a president with extensive powers. In the ensuing political confusion, the Awami League leadership was actually asked to join a new provincial government in East Pakistan and, after much discussion, decided to do so. One of the junior members of the new cabinet was a thirty-six-year-old party organiser by the name of Sheikh Mujibur Rahman. The decision to join the

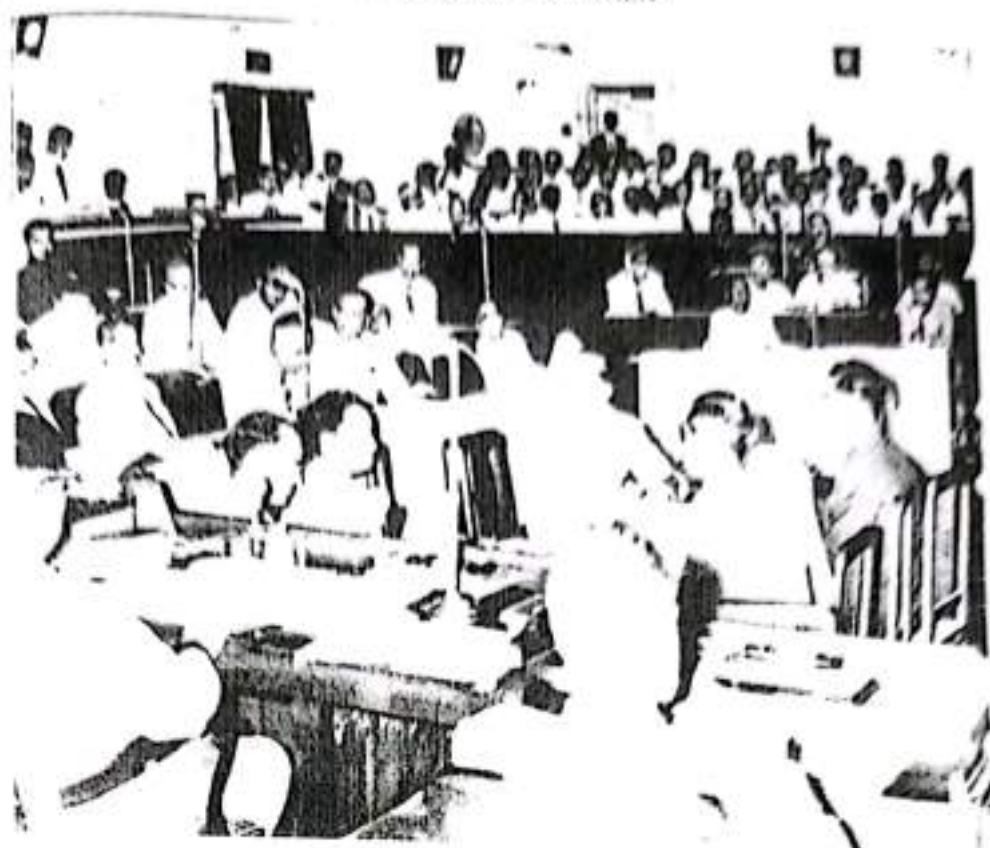


Plate 12.4 The National Assembly of Pakistan in session, Dhaka, October 1956.

government caused a schism in the party. Its founder and president, Maulana Bhashani, called a conference in Kagmari (Tangail district) in early 1957 to demand political reform towards regional autonomy and a non-aligned foreign policy. He warned that 'if East Bengal were not granted autonomy, the people would ultimately say "Assalamu Alaikum" (good-bye) to Pakistan'. Later that year, Bhashani left the party to form the National Awami Party (NAP), which attracted many left-wing and rural followers because it reaffirmed the need for class struggle, religious tolerance and regional autonomy.²⁰

Soon, however, all this political turmoil was of little direct relevance. The entire political class was swept aside when, in October 1958, the Pakistan army staged a *coup d'état*, abrogated the constitution and imposed martial rule. Thus ended Pakistan's first experiment with electoral politics and parliamentary democracy. A dictator now headed the state. He was Ayub Khan, the commander-in-chief of the armed forces.

The coup capped a process in which, during the mid-1950s, Pakistan's bureaucratic and military institutions had gradually risen to a position of

dominance over elected institutions. Another way of putting it is that the popular, participatory nation lost out to the non-democratic state apparatus that Pakistan had inherited from British rule. This was reflected not only in the timing of the coup – just months before the first national elections that had been scheduled for early 1959 but were now cancelled – but also in the personality now taking charge of Pakistan's affairs. Unlike the politicians he brushed aside, Ayub Khan had spent his whole life in the service of the colonial state (from military training in Britain in the 1920s to fighting for the British empire in Myanmar (Burma) in the 1940s) and then in that of the Pakistan state (becoming commander-in-chief in the 1950s). Throughout his rule, his main concern would be to strengthen the state and make it impervious to popular forces.

The coup of 1958 was as critical an event as the language movement for understanding contemporary Bangladesh. It provided a crucial model for successive military rulers, who used it after Bangladesh became independent and who would rule the country during most of the final quarter of the twentieth century. Whereas the language movement was a clear manifestation of the popular, participatory nation attempting to influence the state, the coup of 1958 augured in a state that was relatively autonomous from the nation. Rather than depending on links with the structures of economic power and social control within the country, senior civil and military officials came to rely increasingly on their connections with international guarantors. This constellation gave rise to intense misgivings about the legitimacy of their power.²¹ Bangladesh was to inherit this state structure designed to favour the military and bureaucratic top brass and in perpetual need of external financial and political support against popular forces within the country.

DICTATORSHIP

The coup of 1958 signalled the determination of Pakistan's elite – its army leaders, top bureaucrats and richest businessmen – to put a stop to what they saw as the politicians' ineptitude and corruption. The defeat of the Muslim League in East Pakistan had left the country without any party that could claim to have nationwide legitimacy. Building a unified Pakistani nation seemed harder than ever. The coup leaders were confident that the army was the only institution in the country that could provide the firm hand that Pakistan needed to put it on the right track. To this end they abolished parliamentary democracy, locked up troublesome politicians, curtailed the judiciary, muzzled the press, suspended citizen's rights

and introduced martial law. Now army men took control of the civil service, and the executive branch of the state became all-powerful. Initially the military became involved in economic policy-making as well, but when this led to chaos they decided to exert control from the background, leaving the limelight to the civil service.

For East Pakistan, all this took on a special meaning. Here military rule meant that power was now even more decisively in the hands of non-locals. East Pakistan's elite had wielded power mainly through political mobilisation, not through the army or the bureaucracy. The headquarters of Pakistan's army, air force and navy were all in West Pakistan. The vast majority of the armed forces' personnel were recruited from West Pakistan; a mere 3 per cent of the higher ranks were East Pakistanis. West Pakistanis dominated Pakistan's central administrative apparatus (filling 93 per cent of the higher posts) and even East Pakistan's provincial administration. Even though the new regime inducted more East Pakistanis, particularly in the provincial administration, this did not alter the general impression among East Pakistanis that their province was essentially an internal colony of West Pakistan, or, more precisely, of its dominant province, Punjab. Ayub Khan's personal views of Bengalis were in fact classically colonial. In his autobiography he described Bengalis as having 'all the inhibitions of downtrodden races and [having] not yet found it possible to adjust psychologically to the requirements of the new born freedom. Their popular complexes, exclusiveness, suspicion, and a sort of defensive aggressiveness ... should be recognized and catered for and they be helped so as to feel equal partners and prove an asset.'²²

True to the tradition of many military dictators, Ayub Khan declared that the coup had been carried out in the defence of democracy. It was aimed 'not against the institutions of democracy, but only against the manner in which these were functioning'. In his view, the prevalent forms of democracy were too complex to be operated successfully by the 'simple and illiterate peoples of Pakistan, and too remote to attract their active participation'.²³ A new system was introduced in 1959, ostensibly to teach the populace democratic ways and to prepare them for eventual full participation in representative government. The system was given the name 'basic democracies'. It was reminiscent of the British colonial system of political tutelage known as 'local self-government', and, like this precursor, it aimed at bringing political processes under bureaucratic control and at localising political issues. Rejecting the parliamentary form of government, banning political parties and restricting urban influence, the basic democracies combined paternalism and full control by state officials with some trappings of electoral representation, but only at the lowest level.

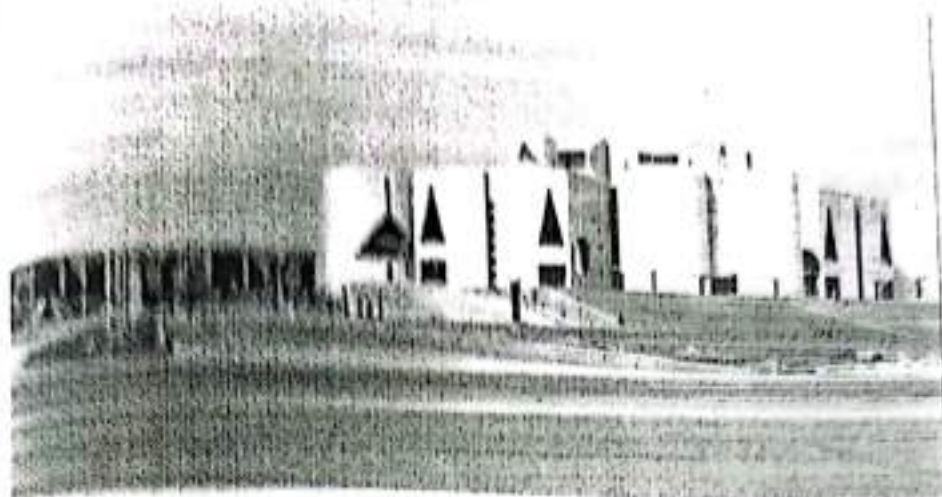


Plate 12.1 The Bangladesh Parliament, originally conceived as Pakistan's National Assembly Building. Designed by Louis Kahn in 1962, it was completed in 1982.

In 1962 an authoritarian constitution was promulgated with a perpetuating the regime indefinitely. It breathed an utter distrust of power and representative government, gave extraordinary powers to the president (as Ayub Khan now styled himself) and created a feeble assembly. Islamabad would be the seat of the national government. Dhaka (now designated the 'second capital') would be the principal site of the national assembly. Soon a complex of prize-winning futuristic buildings materialised on the outskirts of Dhaka to accommodate the assembly – a statement of 'dictator chic'²⁴ – house the Bangladesh Parliament (Plate 12.5).

The military regime saw itself as stern, fair, constructive, efficient and avuncular. Most East Pakistanis, however, saw it as autocratic, imperialistic and geared to perpetuating the vice-regal power of Ayub Khan. The Ayub regime was even less prepared than Pakistan's politicians had been to give concessions to East Pakistan – not surprising in view of the fact that both the civil service and the army were essentially West Pakistani institutions. The regime thought that firm paternalism was the magic soothsayer to allay the perennial fear of Pakistan's rulers: disruption of national unity. East Pakistan was given its democratic share of power. Instead of the flamboyant pyrotechnics of political rivalry and 'narrow-minded provincialism', the regime promised competent economic management, steady growth and a robust state and national harmony. Its mantra was economic development.

Language Movement 1952

Language Movement began in 1948 and reached its climax in the killing of 21 February 1952, which led to the adoption of Bangla as one of the state languages of Pakistan. The question as to what would be the state language of Pakistan was raised immediately after its creation. The Urdu-speaking leaders and the Urdu-speaking intellectuals of Pakistan declared that Urdu would be the state language of Pakistan, just as Hindi was the state language of India. The students and intellectuals of East Pakistan, however, demanded that Bangla be made one of the state languages. After a lot of controversy over the language issue, the final demand from East Pakistan was that Bangla must be the official language and the medium of instruction in East Pakistan and for the central government it would be one of the state languages along with Urdu. The first movement on this issue was mobilised by Tamaddun Majlish headed by Professor Kashem. Gradually many other non-communal and progressive organisations joined the movement, which finally turned into a mass movement.

Meanwhile, serious preparation was being taken in various forums of the central government in Pakistan under the initiative of Fazlur Rahman, the central education minister, to make Urdu the only state language of Pakistan. On receipt of this information, East Pakistani students became agitated and held a meeting on the Dhaka University campus on 6 December 1947, demanding that Bangla be made one of the state languages of Pakistan. The meeting was followed by student processions and more agitation. The first Rastrabhasa Sangram Parishad (Language Action Committee) was formed towards the end of December with Professor Nurul Huda of Tamaddun Majlish as the convener.

Constituent meeting at Amtala in Dhaka University (1952)

The Constituent Assembly of Pakistan was in session at Karachi-then the capital of Pakistan-on 23 February 1948. It was proposed that the members would have to speak either in Urdu or English at the Assembly. Dhirendranath Datta, a member from the East Pakistan Congress, moved an amendment motion to include Bangla as one of the languages of the Constituent Assembly. He noted that out of the 6 crore 90 lakh population of Pakistan, 4 crore lakh were from East Pakistan with Bangla as their mother tongue. The central leaders, including Liaquat Ali Khan, prime minister of Pakistan, and Khwaja Nazimuddin, chief minister of Bengal, opposed the motion. On receiving the news that the motion had been rejected, students, intellectuals and politicians of East Pakistan became agitated. Newspapers such as *Azad* also criticised the politicians who had rejected the motion.

A new committee to fight for Bangla as the state language was formed with Shamsul Huq as its chief. On 11 March 1948 a general strike was observed in the towns of East Pakistan in protest against the omission of Bangla from the languages of the Constituent Assembly, the use of Bangla letters in Pakistani coins and stamps, and the use of only Urdu in recruitment for the navy. The movement also reiterated the earlier demand that Bangla be declared one of the state languages of Pakistan and the official language of East Pakistan. Amidst

processions, picketing and slogans, leaders such as Shawkat Ali, Kazi Golar Shamsul Huq, Oli Ahad, sheikh mujibur rahman, Abdul Wahed and others w Student leaders, including Abdul Matin and abdul malek ukil, also took part in th and picketing.

A meeting was held on the Dhaka University premises. Mohammad Toaha was sev while trying to snatch away a rifle from a policeman and had to be admitted to hos were observed from 12 March to 15 March.

Under such circumstances the government had to give in. Khwaja Nazimudd agreement with the student leaders. However, although he agreed to a few terms an he did not comply with their demand that Bangla be made a state language. m jinnah, the governor general of Pakistan, came to visit East Pakistan on 19 March. I two meetings in Dhaka, in both of which he ignored the popular demand for reiterated that Urdu would be the only state language of Pakistan. This declaration protested with the Language Movement spreading throughout East Pakistan. University Language Action Committee was formed on 11 March 1950 with Ab its convener.

By the beginning of 1952, the Language Movement took a serious turn. Boti Liaquat Ali Khan were dead-Jinnah on 11 September 1948 and Liaquat Ali Khan o 1951. Khwaja Nazimuddin had succeeded Liaquat Ali Khan as prime minister With the political crisis, the economic condition in East Pakistan also deteriorated of East Pakistan started losing faith in the Muslim League. A new party, the Aw League-which would later become the awami league-was formed under the I maulana abdul hamid khan bhasani in 1949. There was a growing sense of def exploitation in East Pakistan and a realisation that a new form of colonialism British imperialism. Under these circumstances, the Language Movement momentum in 1952.

On 27 January 1952, Khwaja Nazimuddin came to Dhaka from Karachi. Addressi at Paltan Maidan, he said that the people of the province could decide what y provincial language, but only Urdu would be the state language of Pakistan. T instantaneous, negative reaction to this speech among the students who respon slogan, 'Rashtrabhasha Bangla Chai' (We want Bangla as the state language).

A strike was observed at Dhaka University on 30 January. The representative political and cultural organisations held a meeting on 31 January chaired by Moul An All-Party Central Language Action Committee was formed with Kazi Golam its convener. At this time the government also proposed that Bangla be written in /

processions, picketing and slogans, leaders such as Shawkat Ali, Kazi Golam Mahboob, Shamsul Haq, Oli Ahad, Sheikh Mujibur Rahman, Abdul Wahed and others, were arrested. Student leaders, including Abdul Matin and Abdul Malek Ukil, also took part in the processions and picketing.

A meeting was held on the Dhaka University premises. Mohammad Toaha was severely injured while trying to snatch away a rifle from a policeman and had to be admitted to hospital. Strikes were observed from 12 March to 15 March.

Under such circumstances the government had to give in. Khwaja Nazimuddin agreed to an agreement with the student leaders. However, although he agreed to a few terms and conditions, he did not comply with their demand that Bangla be made a state language. Muhammad Ali Jinnah, the governor general of Pakistan, came to visit East Pakistan on 19 March. He addressed two meetings in Dhaka, in both of which he ignored the popular demand for Bangla. He reiterated that Urdu would be the only state language of Pakistan. This declaration was strongly protested with the Language Movement spreading throughout East Pakistan. The Dhaka University Language Action Committee was formed on 11 March 1950 with Abdul Matin as its convenor.

By the beginning of 1952, the Language Movement took a serious turn. Both Jinnah and Liaquat Ali Khan were dead. Jinnah on 11 September 1948 and Liaquat Ali Khan on 16 October 1951. Khwaja Nazimuddin had succeeded Liaquat Ali Khan as prime minister of Pakistan. With the political crisis, the economic condition in East Pakistan also deteriorated. The people of East Pakistan started losing faith in the Muslim League. A new party, the Awami Muslim League which would later become the Awami League, was formed under the leadership of Maulana Abdul Hamid Khan Bhasani in 1949. There was a growing sense of deprivation and exploitation in East Pakistan and a realisation that a new form of colonialism had replaced British imperialism. Under these circumstances, the Language Movement got a new momentum in 1952.

On 21 January 1952, Khwaja Nazimuddin came to Dhaka from Karachi. Addressing a meeting at Paltan Maidan, he said that the people of the province could decide what would be the provincial language, but only Urdu would be the state language of Pakistan. There was an instantaneous, negative reaction to this speech among the students who responded with the slogan, 'Raddiaddharha Bangla Chai' (We want Bangla as the state language).

A strike was observed at Dhaka University on 30 January. The representatives of various political and cultural organisations held a meeting on 31 January chaired by Moulana Bhasani. An All Party Central Language Action Committee was formed with Kazi Golam Mahboob as its convenor. At this time the government also proposed that Bangla be written in Arabic script.

This proposal was also vehemently opposed. The Language Action Committee decided to call a hartal and organise demonstrations and processions on February 21 throughout East Pakistan.

As preparations for demonstrations were underway, the government imposed Section 144 in the city of Dhaka, banning all assemblies and demonstrations. A meeting of the Central Language Action Committee was held on 20 February under the chairmanship of abul hashim. Opinion was divided as to whether or not to violate Section 144.

The students were determined to violate Section 144 and held a student meeting at 11.00 am on 21 February on the Dhaka University campus, then located close to the Medical College Hospital. When the meeting started, the Vice-Chancellor, along with a few university teachers, came to the spot and requested the students not to violate the ban on assembly. However, the students, under their leaders - Abdul Matin and gaziul haque - were adamant. Thousands of students from different schools and colleges of Dhaka assembled on the university campus while armed police waited outside the gate. When the students emerged in groups, shouting slogans, the police resorted to baton charge; even the female students were not spared.

The students then started throwing brickbats at the police, who retaliated with tear gas. Unable to control the agitated students, the police fired upon the crowd of students, who were proceeding towards the Assembly Hall (at present, part of Jagannath Hall, University of Dhaka). Three young men, rafiuddin ahmed, abdul jabbar and abul barkat (an MA student of Political Science) were fatally wounded. Many injured persons were admitted to the hospital. Among them abdu salam, a peon at the Secretariat, subsequently succumbed to his wounds. A nine-year-old boy named Ohiullah was also killed.

At the Legislative Assembly building, the session was about to begin. Hearing the news of the shooting, some members of the Assembly, including maulana abdur rashid tarkabagish and some opposition members, went out and joined the students. In the Assembly, nurul amin, chief minister of East Pakistan, continued to oppose the demand for Bangla.

The next day, 22 February, was also a day of public demonstrations and police reprisals. The public performed a janaza (prayer service for the dead) and brought out a mourning procession, which was attacked by the police and the army resulting in several deaths, including that of a young man named Shafiur Rahman. Many were injured and arrested. On 23 February, at the spot where students had been killed, a memorial was erected. In 1963, the temporary structure was replaced by a concrete memorial, the shaheed minar (martyrs' memorial).

The East Bengal Legislative Assembly adopted a resolution recommending the recognition of Bangla as one of the state languages of Pakistan. The language movement continued until 1956. The movement achieved its goal by forcing the Pakistan Constituent Assembly in adopting

The East Bengal Legislative Assembly adopted a resolution recommending the recognition of Bangla as one of the state languages of Pakistan. The language movement continued until the movement achieved its goal by forcing the Pakistan Constituent Assembly in 1952 to declare both Bangla and Urdu as the state languages of Pakistan. While the Assembly was debating the language issue, Member Adel Uddin Ahmed (1913-1981; Faridpur) made an amendment proposal, which was adopted unanimously by the Assembly (16 February 1952). Both Bangla and Urdu were thus enacted to be the state languages of Pakistan.

Since 1952, 21 February has been observed every year to commemorate the martyr Language Movement. With UNESCO adopting a resolution on 17 November 1999 proclaiming 21 February as international mother language day, it is an honour bestowed by the international community on the Language Movement of Bangladesh.

United Front Election 1954

United Front an alliance of the opposition parties to contest seats in the elections to the East Bengal Legislative Assembly held between 8-12 March 1954. The result was a complete victory for the alliance or front composed mainly of four parties of East Bengal, namely League, Krishak Sramik Party, Nizam-e-Islam and Ganatantri Dal.

The Front campaigned on an election manifesto that incorporated a package of twenty-point programme adopted by the Front in November 1953. In addition to full regional autonomy, the manifesto demanded that the central government should delegate to the province all subjects except defence, foreign affairs and currency. It also called for recognition of Bangla as a state language, release of political prisoners, transformation of the then residence (Burdwan House) of the chief minister of East Bengal into Bangla Academy, construction of Shaheed Minar at the site of the police firing in 1952, declaration of 21 February as a public holiday, more autonomy for Dhaka and Rajshahi universities, introduction of economic and social rights for industrial workers in keeping with the principles of nationalisation of jute, guarantee of fair prices for commodities, and public supply of cooperatives and cottage industries.

During the early period of Pakistan, economic disparity, poor representation of Bangla in government, and politico-cultural repression pursued by the ruling elite of Pakistan accentuated political problems in East Bengal. Most importantly, the deprivation of Bangladeshi from participation in the decision-making process gave rise to the politics of regionalism in Bengal. The resultant development was that the political forces of East Bengal were gradually pushed to launch new political platforms and organise movements against the central government based in the western part of the country.

The general elections to the East Bengal legislative assembly due in 1951 could not be held until 1954. Several postponements of the elections under various pretexts only pro-

political and economic reasons. The decision to form a united front was initially endorsed on 14 November 1953 at the historic council session of the Awami League held at Mymensingh. Subsequently, the Front for a while dominated the political landscape of East Bengal and had its usefulness as an effective political platform to unite diverse political groups.

The United Front won 223 seats out of 309 Muslim seats in the assembly, whereas the ruling Muslim League managed to capture only 9 seats, and all five members of the Muslim League Ministry including the chief minister (Nurul Amin), were defeated. As many as 1285 candidates contested in the election held on the basis of adult franchise. In all 986 candidates contested for 228 Muslim seats, 101 candidates for 30 general seats and 151 candidates for 36 scheduled caste seats. The Pakistan National Congress, the United Progressive Party and the Schedule Caste Federation were the main contenders for the non-Muslim seats, 37 candidates contested for 9 seats reserved for Muslim women. The United Front candidates captured all the seats reserved for the women.

For Muslim constituencies, the turnout of voters was 37.6 percent. Although low by contemporary international standards, the turnout seemed considerable in view of the inadequate communication facilities, and the poor turnout of the women voters because of the prevailing conservative outlook in the society. For some reasons, communists did not campaign under their own party banner but preferred to contest as nominees of the United Front; 15 seats were won by them.

The resultant development after the election was that the United Front leader, A.K. Fazlul Huq, was invited on 3 April 1954 by the provincial governor to form the government. Importantly, however, the election result was a signal to the end of the dominance of the national elite in the politics of East Bengal; landowners had given away to a younger generation of professional university-trained elite, comprising lawyers, journalists, teachers and businessmen. A vast majority of the elected members were new, relatively young and inexperienced in government and politics. Out of the 223 members elected under the United Front banner, 130 belonged to the Awami League.

The architects of the United Front victory in East Bengal were the triumvirate, A.K. Fazlul Huq, Huseyn Shaheed Suhrawardy, and Maulana Abdul Hamid Khan Bhasani, and it was most likely that the charisma of each of them influenced voters much. However, within a year or so after the election, the United Front disintegrated because of clashes of personalities, intra-alliance disagreements and dissension, and divergent party programmes.

Elections 1954 held in East Pakistan in March 1954 under the India Act of 1935, and on the basis of universal adult franchise. The contesting parties in the elections were the ruling Muslim League and a five-party alliance called United Front. The major partners of the Front were the Awami Muslim League led by Maulana Abdul Hamid Khan Bhasani, the Krishak Sramik Party

Elections 1954 held in East Pakistan in March 1954 under the India Act of 1935, and on the basis of universal adult franchise. The contesting parties in the elections were the ruling Muslim League and a five-party alliance called United Front. The major partners of the Front were the Awami Muslim League led by Maulana Abul Husein Ali Haque, the Krishak Samik party led by AK Fazlul Haq, Nazam-e-Islam led by Maulana Abul Ali, Ganatantri Dal led by Hujj Mohammad Danesh and Khilafat-e-Rabbani Party.

In the elections held from 8 to 12 March 1954 candidates contested for 304 seats, 5 seats having been won uncontested. Of them, 98% were Muslim candidates for 228 seats, 101 Hindu candidates for 30 seats, and 14 scheduled caste candidates for 46 seats. The seats for the non-Muslims were contested by candidates mostly from the Pakistan National Congress, United Progressive Party and the Scheduled Caste Federation. The total electors numbered 1,97,48,568 of whom 73,44,216 (37.19%) cast their votes. The lower turnout was ascribed to poor communications in rural areas and the reluctance of conservative Muslim women to come out of their houses.

The elections resulted in a landslide victory for the United Front which won 228 seats in a House of 309 (including nine reserved seats for women). On the other hand, the Muslim League, the party in power directly or indirectly ever since 1937, managed to get only 7 seats. Of the total of 228 elected Front members, 143 belonged to Awami Muslim League, 48 to Krishak Samik Party, 22 to Nazam-e-Islam, 11 to Ganatantri Dal and 2 to Khilafat-e-Rabbani Party. Of the non-Muslim seats, Congress got 28, Scheduled Caste Federation 27, and the United Front of the Minorities 14.

The United Front campaigned on a 41-point election manifesto that spoke for recognition of Bangla as one of the state languages of Pakistan, abolition of zamindari system, nationalising jute trade, introduction of cooperative banking, rehabilitation of refugees, flood control, modernising agriculture, reforming the education system, rescinding all black laws, rationalising the pay scales, trial of officers of the police, separating judiciary from the executive, erection of a monument in memory of the martyrs, converting Hurdwan House into a Bangla language development centre, declaring 21 February as Shuhed Day and a public holiday, and establishment of a public library. These popular demands were put up by leaders like AK Fazlul Haq, Husein Ali Haque, and sheikh Mujibur Rahman. With the support of the political workers, the United Front leaders could operate with considerable ease at the grassroots level. The United Front could fully exploit issues like the killing of students on 21 February, the rise and fall in prices of essential goods, particularly of salt and rice. The large-scale mobilisation of experienced political workers also made the people susceptible of the intentions of the United Front.

The United Front's victory in the elections had taken the euphoria were out. On March 25, East Pakistan government, the United Front asked Krishak Samik Party leader AK Fazlul Haq to form the ministry. But in the ministry formed on 1 April the Awami Muslim

of nearly 1500 workers. The communist activists were held responsible for the tragedy, and the Fazlul Huq government was blamed for its failure in controlling the situation. On May 30, the ministry was dismissed and direct governor's rule was imposed. Around 1600 Front leaders and workers, including 30 members of the legislature, were put behind the bars. The Awami League, however, returned to power on its own on 30 August 1956 with Ataur Rahman Khan as chief minister, but only to resign a few months later.

Six Points Movement

Six-point Programme a charter of demands enunciated by the Awami League for removing disparity between the two wings of Pakistan and to put an end to the internal colonial rule of West Pakistan in East Bengal.

The Indo-Pak War of 1965 ended with the execution of Tashkent Treaty. To the old grievances of economic disparity added the complaint of negligence and indifference of central government towards the defence of East Pakistan. Bangabandhu Sheikh Mujibur Rahman was vocal on this issue.

The leaders of the opposition parties of West Pakistan convened a national convention at Lahore on 6 February 1966 with a view to ascertain the post-Tashkent political trend. Bangabandhu reached Lahore on 4 February along with the top leaders of Awami League, and the day following he placed the Six-point charter of demand before the subject committee as the demands of the people of East Pakistan. He created pressure to include his proposal in the agenda of the conference. The subject committee rejected the proposal of Bangabandhu. On the day following, the newspapers of West Pakistan published reports on the Six-point Programme, and Sheikh Mujibur Rahman was projected as a separatist. Consequently Sheikh Mujib abandoned the conference.

The Six-point Programme along with a proposal of movement for the realisation of the demands was placed before the meeting of the working committee of Awami League on 21 February 1966, and the proposal was carried out unanimously. A booklet on the Six-point Programme with introduction from Bangabandhu Sheikh Mujibur Rahman and Tajuddin Ahmad was published. Another booklet titled *Amader Banchar Dabi: 6-dafa Karmasuchi* (Our demands for existence: 6-points Programme) was published in the name of Sheikh Mujibur Rahman, and was distributed in the council meeting of Awami League held on 18 March 1966.

1. The Constitution should provide for a Federation of Pakistan in its true sense on the Lahore Resolution, and the parliamentary form of government with supremacy of a Legislature directly elected on the basis of universal adult franchise.
2. The federal government should deal with only two subjects: Defence and Foreign Affairs, and all other residuary subjects shall be vested in the federating states.
3. Two separate, but freely convertible currencies for two wings should be introduced; or if this is not feasible, there should be one currency for the whole country, but effective constitutional provisions should be introduced to stop the flight of capital from East to West Pakistan. Furthermore, a separate Banking Reserve should be established, and separate fiscal and monetary policy be adopted for East Pakistan.
4. The power of taxation and revenue collection shall be vested in the federating units and the federal centre will have no such power on the issue. The federation will be entitled to a share in the state taxes to meet its expenditures.
5. There should be two separate accounts for the foreign exchange earnings of the two wings; the foreign exchange requirements of the federal government should be met by the two wings equally or in a ratio to be fixed; indigenous products should move free of duty between the two wings, and the Constitution should empower the units to establish trade links with foreign countries.
6. East Pakistan should have a separate militia or paramilitary force.

The opposition leaders of West Pakistan looked at Mujib's Six-point Programme as a device to disband Pakistan, and hence they rejected his proposal outright. The Ayub government projected Sheikh Mujib as a separatist and later instituted the agartala conspiracy case against him. He was arrested and put on trial. The case led to widespread agitation in East Pakistan culminating into the mass uprising of early 1969. Under public pressure, the government was forced to release him unconditionally on 22 February 1969.

The Awami League sought public mandate in favour of the Six-point Programme in the general elections of 1970 in which Sheikh Mujib received the absolute mandate from the people of East Pakistan in favour of his Six-point. But Zulfikar Ali Bhutto refused to join the session of the National Assembly scheduled to be held on 3 March 1971 unless a settlement was reached between the two leaders beforehand. Sheikh Mujibur Rahman and his party sat in a protracted dialogue from 15 March 1971. The dialogue failed to produce any positive result. The army crackdown of 25 March sealed the fate of the Six-point including the fate of Pakistan.

Agartala Conspiracy Case a case framed by the Pakistan Government in 1968 during the Ayub regime against Awami League chief Sheikh Mujibur Rahman, some in-service and ex-service army personnel and high government officials. They were accused of involvement in a conspiracy to secede the East wing from Pakistan with the help of the government of India. The petitis principii in the petition was that the conspiracy was concocted between the Indian party and the accused persons at Agartala city of Tripura in India. The case was thus called Agartala Conspiracy Case. However, the Pakistan government was compelled to withdraw the case in the face of a mass movement in East Pakistan.

Since the inception of Pakistan, the people of East Pakistan were deprived of their legitimate rights in all spheres. Consequently, a general resentment against the Pakistani rulers brewed among the people of East Pakistan. The demand for autonomy as placed through the six-point programme of the Awami League chief Sheikh Mujibur Rahman thus received the spontaneous support of the people of East Pakistan.

The acute disparity in the armed forces led some Bangali army officers and soldiers to be united secretly. Knowing full well that the interest of the Bangalis could never be served under the rulers of West Pakistan, they decided to make East Pakistan independent through an armed revolt. With this end in view, they began to mobilise army personnel secretly. The conspiracy was, however, detected by the intelligence department of the government. Nearly one thousand five hundred Bangalis throughout Pakistan were arrested by the intelligence force.

The Home Department of Pakistan declared through a press-note issued on 6 January 1968 that the government had detected in December 1967 a conspiracy detrimental to the national interest of Pakistan. The press-note disclosed the news of the arrest of 8 persons including 2 CSP officers and alleged that the persons seized were involved in attempting to separate East Pakistan through armed revolt. Through a separate declaration issued on 18 January 1968 the Home Department implicated Sheikh Mujibur Rahman in the conspiracy. He was then detained in jail along with many others since 9 May 1966. They were released, only to be arrested again under martial law regulations and were taken to Dhaka Cantonment under military custody.

Initially the government decided to court martial the accused, but subsequently in the interest of the proper holding of the general elections of 1970 the government resolved to frame charge only against 35 concerned political personalities and high government officials under civil law. The persons included in the charge-sheet were Sheikh Mujibur Rahman, Commander Moazzem Hossain, Steward Mujibur Rahman, former LS Sultanuddin Ahmad, LSCDI Nur Mohammad, Ahmed Fazlur Rahman CSP, Flight Sergeant Mahfiz Ullah, Corporal Abdus Samad, former Havildar Dalil Uddin, Ruhul Quddus CSP, Flight Sergeant Md. Fazlul Haq, Bibhuti Bhushan Chowdhury alias Manik Chowdhury, Bidhan Krishna Sen, Subedar Abdur Razzaque, former clerk Mujibur Rahman, former Flight Sergeant Md. Abdur Razzaque, Sergeant Zahurul Haq, AB Khurshid, Khan Mohammad Shamsur Rahman CSP, AKM Shamsul Haque, Havildar Azizul Haq, Mahfuzul Bari, Sergeant Shamsul Haq, Shamsul Alam, Captain

Haque, Havildar Azizul Haq, Mahfuzul Bari, Sergeant Shamsul Haq, Shamsul Alam, Captain Md. Abdul Motaleb, Captain A Shawkat Ali Mian, Captain Khondkar Nazmul Huda, Captain M Nuruzzaman, Sergeant Abdul Jalil, Mahbub Uddin Chowdhury, Lt. M Rahman, former Subedar Tajul Islam, Ali Reza, Captain Khurshid Uddin Ahmed, and Lt. Abdur Rauf.

A special tribunal was formed after an amendment was made in the penal code to that end for the disposal of the case. The hearing of the case started on 19 June 1968 under Sections 121-A and 131. Sheikh Mujibur Rahman was enrolled as accused No.1. The case was entitled 'State vs Sheikh Mujibur Rahman and others'. The tribunal started proceedings of the case in a highly protected chamber inside Dhaka Cantonment. A charge-sheet consisting of 100 paragraphs against the 35 accused was placed before the tribunal. There were 227 witnesses including 11 approvers. However, 4 approvers were declared hostile by the government.

Thomas William, a British lawyer and a member of the British Parliament, filed a writ petition in Dhaka High Court on behalf of Sheikh Mujibur Rahman challenging the legality of the formation of the tribunal. He was assisted in conducting legal proceedings in the special tribunal by Abdus Salam Khan, Aatur Rahman Khan, and others. The government lawyers, leading the case were the former foreign minister Manzur Quader and Advocate General TTI Khan. Justice SA Rahman, the Chairman of the three-member tribunal, was a non-Bangali. The other members MR Khan and Maksumul Hakim were Bangalis. The government was bent on identifying Sheikh Mujibur Rahman as a separatist and an Indian agent thereby arousing public support against him. But the approvers on the witness-box declared that the government had compelled them by threat and persecution to submit false evidence in its favour. Thus the governmental machination against the accused got exposed. By this time the Sarbadaliya Chhatra Sangram Parishad supported by maulana abdul hamid khan bhasani organised mass movement against the conspiracy of the government and demanded immediate withdrawal of the case and release of all prisoners including Sheikh Mujibur Rahman.

At a point when the streets of Dhaka became a hot bed of turmoil, Sergeant Zahurul Haq, 17th accused in the case, was mercilessly shot to death while in confinement in Dhaka Cantonment. The news of his death led a furious mob to set fire to the State Guest House as well as other buildings. S.A Rahman, Chairman of the tribunal, and Manzur Quader, chief lawyer on the government side, who were then residing in the guest house, evacuated secretly. Some of the files concerning the case were burnt to ashes. In the face of the mass movement, the Ayub government was ultimately compelled to withdraw the Agartala Conspiracy Case on 22 February 1969. All the accused, including Sheikh Mujibur Rahman, were released unconditionally. On the following day (23 February), a grand public reception was accorded to the accused at Paltan Maidan in Dhaka where Sheikh Mujibur Rahman was vested with the appellation of 'Bangabandhu'.

Mass Upsurge, 1969

Mass Upsurge, 1969 started with the student unrest of 1968 against the tyrannical rule of Ayub Khan, President of Pakistan. The movement soon engulfed the whole of the then East Pakistan, peasants, artisans, workers joined the movement almost en masse. Due to continuous exaction of undue demands the labouring class of the industrial belts and low and medium income groups soon turned the movement into a struggle for economic emancipation. The racial repression and the deprivation of the Bangalis within the frame work of Pakistan and, to the contrary, starting from the language movement the feeling of separate identity together with struggle for autonomy had direct influence on the mass upsurge of 1969. Indeed, this mass upsurge was the greatest mass awakening ever since the creation of Pakistan.

The student agitation of 1968 turned into a mass upsurge when Maulana Abdul Hamid Khan Bhasani asked his followers to besiege Governors House, and formulated and declared his other programmes. As a part of joint programmes the National Awami Party (NAP) of Maulana Bhasani, East Pakistan Workers' Federation of Toaha and East Pakistan Peasants' Association led by Abdul Huq arranged a public meeting at Paltan Maidan to observe the Repression Resistance Day on 6 December 1968. After the meeting was over, a huge procession 'gheraoed' the Governor's House. The Maulana declared a Hartal the next day following the clash between the people and the police. On the call of the main opposition parties namely two factions of NAP (Bhasani and Muzaffar), Awami League, People's Party, Nezam-i-Islam, Jama't-i-Islami etc a hartal was observed throughout East Pakistan on 8 December. Repression Resistance Day was very successfully observed throughout the province on 10 December at the call of Awami League (pro-six point). On the 14th the gherao programme was declared by the NAP (Bhasani). Accordingly the programme was launched with the gherao of the bungalow of the DC of Pabna on the 29 December 1968.

On 4 January 1969 leaders of the East Pakistan Students Union (Menon Group), East Pakistan Students League, East Pakistan Students' Union (Matia Gr.) and a section of the National Students' Federation formed the Students' Action Committee (SAC) and declared their 11-point Programme. The 11 Points included the Six Points of Awami League as declared by Sheikh Mujibur Rahman including provincial autonomy, the demands centring round students' own demands as well as the demands relating to the problems of the workers. As a matter of fact the step the student leaders took through the 11-Point programme was timely and appropriate. On the basis of these points the important opposition parties could be united on a minimum point of agreement to continue with the movement against Ayub regime. Moreover the demand for Sheikh Mujib's release and withdrawal of the agartala conspiracy case began to get the utmost priority. Together with the Dhaka University Central Students' Union (DUCSU) the student leaders of SAC holding different positions throughout East Bengal played a very important role in the 1969 mass upsurge.

Immediately after the 11-Point programme had been launched on 8 January 1969 eight political parties, including Awami League and NAP (Muzaffar) formed the Democratic Action Committee (DAC). They demanded Federal form of government, election on the basis of

universal adult franchise, immediate withdrawal of emergency and release of all detainees including Sheikh Mujibur Rahman, Khan Abdul Wali Khan and Zulfikar Ali Bhutto. They took the decision to invigorate the movement to achieve their goal. But some parties in the DAC refused to support the 11-Point programme of the SAC. In spite of this, the movement gradually got momentum and the spirit of 11-points reached every nook and corner of the province. Even a portion of the pro-government student front NSF came to support their 22-point programme and openly opposed the government. To voice the protest against government repression the students arranged a meeting at the Dhaka University campus and resolved to bring out a procession. In the procession police opened fire and Asad, a leader of the Students Union (Menon), was killed.

The death of Asad stirred the entire nation and the movement took the shape of a popular upsurge. The situation of Dhaka went beyond control of the police when Matin, a high school class IX, died of police firing on 24 January and Rustam was stabbed to death. A police officer deployed in the city and curfew was imposed for an indefinite period. Indiscriminate firing by the army and the FPR caused death to a woman while sucking her baby. The incident had widespread repercussions in the socio-political arena. Sergeant Zahrul Huq, an under-trial prisoner in the Agartala Conspiracy Case, died of bullet injury in the Dhaka Cantonment on 25 February 1969.

The death of an under-trial prisoner was so provocative that Maulana Bhasani declared a public meeting held that very evening that there will be no payment of taxes if the 11 demands were not fulfilled and all political prisoners were not released within two months. He further declared, if necessary, Sheikh Mujib would be forcibly taken out of jail repeating what happened at the falling of the Bastille during the French Revolution. After the meeting people began to set on fire the houses of the ministers. On 18 February 1969 Dr Mohamud Shamsuzzoha, Proctor of the Rajshahi University, was bayoneted to death. The news spread like wild fire throughout the country. Thousands of people thronged the Dhaka streets and highways ignoring curfew.

The Shaheed Day of 1969 imbued the people with a new spirit of opposing tyranny. A seminar arranged at the Teacher Student Centre and presided over by Professor Abdul Haq was resolved that the movement for language based nationality would continue. Amidst the popular demand Ayub had to give way and declare that he would not contest the Presidential Election. The same day Sheikh Mujib and the other accused in the Agartala Conspiracy Case and 14 political detainees were released.

In this struggle for democracy and endeavour to get rid of tyranny the toiling masses of rural areas did not stop at merely chanting slogans against oppressive government but raised their voice against the oppressing class or its representatives. The situation took such a dimension that in many cases the peasants, with the assistance of students, killed cattle lift, burnt them or set their houses on fire, crippled the thieves and robbers and sometimes

killed them. In several places the students with the assistance of peasants put on trial the local tax-collectors, the subordinate police and their officers, circle officers and moved them around market places garlanding them with shoes. Students exacted from them the amount they had taken as bribes, sometimes they were fined. Students forced chairmen and members of union councils to resign, removed brothels and wiped out liqueur shops. In the urban areas corrupt officials were bodily manhandled, their record books ransacked and sometimes even set on fire. Low-income groups and mid-level employees chanted for their long cherished but unfulfilled demands and joined the processions in the highways, thousands of workers used the gherao movement as the fruitful means of achieving their demands.

In these circumstances Sheikh Mujib came out of jail and declared his intention to join the Round Table Conference (RTC) summoned by Ayub. He asked the people to maintain peace and order. Maulana Bhasani, on the other hand, refused to join the RTC and was dubbed as the 'prophet of violence' when he, as per his usual thoughts and principles, declared the 1969 upsurge as the struggle between the oppressor and the oppressed. In the long run the strongman of Pakistan, General Ayub Khan, had to hand over power to General Yahya Khan, chief of Pakistan Army. Martial Law was re-imposed, but simultaneously it was agreed that elections would be arranged soon on the basis of universal adult franchise, and parliamentary democracy would be introduced.

Fear of police and civil and military bureaucrats minimised to a very great extent from the minds of the people, and in the estimation of the people the bureaucrats lost much of their image and importance especially in the rural areas. Moreover, class consciousness grew and advanced a step forward. The demand for a separate state became stronger than ever before among the people of Eastern Bengal. Bangali nationalism became sufficiently strong to sustain during the war of liberation in 1971.

Election of 1970

General elections were held in Pakistan on 7 December 1970 to elect members of the National Assembly. They were the first general elections since the independence of Pakistan and ultimately the only ones held prior to the independence of Bangladesh. Voting took place in 300 general constituencies, of which 162 were in East Pakistan and 138 in West Pakistan. A further thirteen seats were reserved for women (seven of which were in East Pakistan and six of which were in West Pakistan), who were to be elected by members of the National Assembly.

The elections were a fierce contest between two social democratic parties, the west-based Pakistan Peoples Party (PPP) and the east-based Awami League. The Awami League was the sole major party in the east wing, while in the west wing, the PPP faced severe competition from the conservative factions of Muslim League, the largest of which was Muslim League (Qayyum), as well as Islamist parties like Jamaat-e-Islami (JI), Jamiat Ulema-e-Islam (JUI) and Jamiat Ulema-e-Pakistan (JUP).

The result was a victory for the Awami League, which gained an absolute majority, winning 160 of the 162 general seats and all seven women's seats in East Pakistan. The PPP won only 81 general seats and five women's seats, all in West Pakistan. In the provincial elections held ten days later, the Awami League again dominated in East Pakistan, while the PPP were its winning party in Punjab and Sindh. The Marxist National Awami Party emerged victorious in Northwest Frontier Province and Balochistan.

The National Assembly was initially not inaugurated as President Yahya Khan and the PPP chairman Zulfikar Ali Bhutto did not want a party from East Pakistan in federal government. Instead, Yahya appointed the veteran Bengali politician Nurul Amin as Prime Minister, asking him to reach a compromise between the PPP and Awami League. However, this move failed as the delay in inauguration had already caused significant unrest in East Pakistan. The situation deteriorated further when a genocidal crackdown occurred under the orders of Yahya resulting in a civil war that led to the formation of the independent state of Bangladesh.[3] The Assembly was eventually inaugurated in 1972 after Yahya resigned and handed power to Zulfikar Ali Bhutto. Bhutto became Prime Minister in 1973 after the post was recreated by a new constitution.

On 23 March 1956, Pakistan changed from being a Dominion of the British Commonwealth and became an Islamic republic after framing its own constitution. Although the first general elections were scheduled for early 1959, severe political instability led President Iskander Mirza to abrogate the constitution on 7 October 1958. Mirza imposed martial law and handed power to the Commander-in-Chief of the Pakistan Army, General Muhammad Ayub Khan. After assuming presidency, President Ayub Khan promoted himself to the rank of Field marshal and appointed General Muhammad Musa Khan as the new Commander-in-Chief.

On 17 February 1960, President Ayub Khan appointed a commission under Muhammad Ghulamuddin, the Chief Justice of Pakistan, to report a political framework for the country. The commission submitted its report on 29 April 1961, and on the basis of this report, a new constitution was framed on 1 March 1962. The new constitution, declaring the country as Islamic Republic of Pakistan, brought about a presidential system of government, as opposed to the parliamentary system of government under the 1956 Constitution. The electoral system was made indirect, and the "basic democrats" were declared electoral college for the purpose of electing members of the National and Provincial Assemblies. Under the new system, presidential elections were held on 2 January 1965 which resulted in a victory for Ayub Khan. As a result of political opposition against President Ayub Khan mounted. In East Pakistan, leader of the Awami League, Sheikh Mujibur Rahman, was one of the key leaders to rally opposition to President Ayub Khan. In 1966, he began the Six point movement for East Pakistan autonomy.

The general elections of 1970 are considered one of the fairest and cleanest elections in the history of Pakistan, with about twenty-four political parties taking part. The general elections presented a picture of a two party system, with the Awami League, a Bengali nationalist party, competing against the extremely influential and widely popular Pakistan Peoples Party, a leftist

and democratic socialist party which had been a major power-broker in West Pakistan. The Pakistani government supported the pro-Islamic parties since they were committed to strong federalism. The Jamaat-e-Islami suspected that the Awami League had secessionist intentions.

The continuous public meetings of the Awami League in East Pakistan and the Pakistan Peoples Party in Western Pakistan attracted huge crowds. The Awami League, a Bengali nationalist party, mobilised support in East Pakistan on the basis of its Six-Points Program (SPP), which was the main attraction in the party's manifesto. In East Pakistan, a huge majority of the Bengali nation favoured the Awami League, under Sheikh Mujib. The party received a huge percentage of the popular vote in East Pakistan and emerged as the largest party in the nation as a whole, gaining the exclusive mandate of Pakistan in terms both of seats and of votes.

The Pakistan Peoples Party failed to win any seats in East Pakistan. On the other hand, the Awami League had failed to gather any seats in West Pakistan. The Awami League's failure to win any seats in the west was used by the leftists led by Zulfikar Bhutto who argued that Mujib had received "no mandate or support from West Pakistan" (ignoring the fact that he himself did not win any seat in East Pakistan).

The then leaders of Pakistan, all from West Pakistan and PPP leaders, strongly opposed the idea of an East Pakistani-led government. Many in Pakistan predicted that the Awami League-controlled government would oversee the passage of a new constitution with a simple majority. Bhutto uttered his infamous phrase "idhar hum, udhar tum" (We rule here, you rule there) – thus dividing Pakistan for the first time orally.

The same attitudes and emotions were also felt in East Pakistan whereas East-Pakistanis absorbed the feeling and reached to the conclusion that Pakistan had been benefited with economic opportunities, investments, and social growth would swiftly depose any East Pakistanis from obtaining those opportunities.

Some Bengalis sided with the Pakistan Peoples' Party and tacitly or openly supported Bhutto and the democratic socialists, such as Jalaludin Abdur Rahim, an influential Bengali in Pakistan and mentor of Bhutto, who was later jailed by Bhutto. Jamat-e-Islami, while supporting allowing the Awami League to form a government, was also against the fragmentation of the country. Conversely, several prominent figures from West Pakistan supported allowing the Awami League to rule, including the poet Faiz Ahmad Faiz and rights activist Malik Ghulam Jilani, father of Asma Jahangir, G.M Syed the founder of Sindh nationalist party Jeay Sindh Qaumi Mahaz (JSQM) and Abul Ala Maududi, the leader of Jamat-e-Islami.

The elected Assembly initially did not meet as President Yahya Khan and the Pakistan Peoples Party did not want the majority party from East Pakistan forming government. This caused

great unrest in East Pakistan. The military junta responded by executing a genocidal crackdown which led to the Bangladesh War of Independence, with East Pakistan becoming the independent state of Bangladesh. The Assembly session was eventually held when Yahya resigned four days after Pakistan surrendered in Bangladesh and Zulfikar Ali Bhutto took over. Bhutto became the Prime Minister of Pakistan in 1973, after the post was recreated by the new Constitution.

Liberation War of 1971

War of Liberation, The began on 26 March 1971 and ended with the liberation of Bangladesh on 16 December 1971. The armed struggle was the culmination of a series of events, situations and issues contributing to the progressively deteriorating relations between East and West Pakistan. The questions of land reforms, state language, inter-wing economic and administrative disparities, provincial autonomy, the defense of East Pakistan and many other consequential questions had been straining the relations between the two wings of Pakistan ever since independence of the country from Britain in 1947.

The general elections of 1970 had made Bangabandhu Sheikh Mujibur Rahman, chief of AWAMI LEAGUE which bagged 167 seats out of 169, the sole spokesman of the people of East Pakistan and majority leader in the Pakistan National Assembly. But the Pakistan civil and military ruling clique had refused to transfer power to the majority leader Sheikh Mujibur Rahman and his party. Sheikh Mujib also refused to yield to the pressure put on him for undue accommodation. Sheikh Mujib's historic address on 7 March 1971 made this point quite clear to the Pakistani military junta. Then began the civil disobedience movement. Meanwhile talks started between Sheikh Mujib and President Yahya Khan to resolve the outstanding issues.

While holding talks, the Pakistani military junta was bringing more troops to Bangladesh, and at the same time wantonly killing innocent civilians all over the country. This clearly showed that they were totally insincere about handing over power to the elected representatives of East Pakistan. No sooner the talks failed, the GENOCIDE began with the Pakistan army's crackdown on the people of East Pakistan on the midnight of 25 March 1971. The Bangali soldiers serving in the then Pakistan Armed Forces and para militia forces declared instantly their solidarity with the people's liberation war.

The Pakistan Army was ordered to launch operation on Bangali people at midnight of 25 March. According to the plan for operation Search Light two headquarters were established. Major General Rao Farman Ali with 57 Brigade under Brigadier Arbab was responsible for operation in Dhaka city and its suburbs while Major General Khadim Raja was given the responsibility of the rest of the province. Lieutenant General Tikka Khan assumed the overall charge of the operation.

The students and the nationalist political activists put up resistance outside the cantonment. Road blocks were raised to obstruct the march of the Pakistani column to the city areas. The wireless set fitted jeeps and trucks loaded with troops groaned on the streets of Dhaka City at midnight of 25 March.

The first column of the Pakistan army faced obstruction at Farmgate, about one kilometre from the cantonment, due to a huge road block created by placing big tree trunks across the road. The hulks of old cars and unserviceable steam roller were also used in creating the blockade. Several hundred people chanted the slogan *Joi Bangla* which lasted for about 15 minutes. But

soon guns silenced them. The army moved into the city before scheduled time and started the genocide.

The military forces killed everybody in sight on the footpath and destroyed everything on their way. The tanks roared through the streets of Dhaka blasting indiscriminately at the people and official and residential buildings. They gunned down clusters of settlements and set fire on them. Scores of artillery bursts were pounded, while the tanks rumbled into the city roaring the main streets. The student halls of residence at Dhaka University were raided and numerous students residing there were brutally killed and maimed. They also killed many teachers of Dhaka University. The Hindu concentrated areas of old Dhaka were particularly targeted. They started killing the people, burnt their houses, looted their valuables and raped their women. The genocide that was perpetrated on the unarmed people was flashed in the world press. On the night of 25 March Sheikh Mujibur Rahman was taken prisoner by the Pakistan army.

There were spontaneous uprisings throughout Bangladesh following the declaration of independence on 26 March 1971. These uprisings were participated by government officials, political activists, students, workers, peasants, professionals and members of the public. After initial resistance, many freedom fighters crossed over into Indian territory to have safe sanctuary, due mainly to the enemy's overwhelming superiority of trained soldiers and modern weapons. The scattered and temporarily retreating rudimentary liberation forces were soon brought under a unified command.

On 4 April, the senior officers of the liberation army assembled at the headquarters of 2nd East Bengal at Teliapara, a semi hilly area covered by tea gardens where Colonel MAG Osmany, Lieutenant Colonel Abdur Rob, Lieutenant Colonel Salahuddin Mohammad Reja, Major Kazi Nuruzzaman, Major Khaled Mosharraf, Major Nurul Islam, Major Shafat Jamil, Major Mainul Hossain Chowdhury and others were present. In this meeting four senior commanders were entrusted with the responsibility of operational areas. Sylhet-Brahmanbaria area was placed under the command of Major Shafiullah. Comilla-Noakhali area was given to Major Khaled Mosharraf while Chittagong-Chittagong Hill Tracts was given to Major Ziaur Rahman. Kushtia-Jessore area was placed under command of Major Abu Osman Chowdhury. In the meeting the organisational concept of the freedom fighter forces and the command structure were chalked out. Colonel MAG Osmany was to command the liberation forces, later named as MUKTI BAHINI.

An exile government called the People's Republic of Bangladesh Government alias MUJIBNAGAR GOVERNMENT was formed on 10 April with Bangabandhu Sheikh Mujibur Rahman as President of the Republic, Syed Nazrul Islam as Vice President and Tajuddin Ahmed as Prime Minister. On the day following Tajuddin Ahmed announced the names of three more regional commanders, Captain Newazish for Rangpur region, Major Najmul Haque for Dinajpur-Rajshahi-Pabna and Major Jalil for Barisal-Patuakhali region. All these regions were later named as sectors. All of Bangladesh was divided into eleven such sectors and different sub-sectors for operational purposes during the Sector Commander's conference held from 10 to 17 July 1971.

On 27 March, Prime Minister of India Mrs. Indira Gandhi expressed full support of her government to the freedom struggle of the Bangalis. Indian Border Security Force (BSF) opened Bangladesh-India border to allow the tortured and panic stricken Bangalis to have safe shelter in India. The governments of West Bengal, Bihar, Assam, Meghalaya and Tripura established refugee camps along the border. These camps became ready ground for recruitment

of the freedom fighters. The students, peasants, workers and political activists joined the Mukti Bahini with high spirit to liberate Bangladesh from the Pakistan army. They were given training on tactics and the use of arms and explosives. On completion of training, they were posted to different sectors to fight the enemy. The headquarters of the Bangladesh Forces was established at 8 Theatre Road, Calcutta which started functioning from 12 April 1971. Lieutenant Colonel M A Hossain and Group Captain A K Khandaker were appointed as Chief of Staff and Deputy Chief of Staff respectively.

Besides Mukti Bahini, many other bahinis were organised inside Bangladesh at different places to fight Pakistan Army. These Bahinis included Kader Bahini of Tangail, Latif Mirza Bahini of Sirajganj, Akbar Hossain Bahini of Jhinaidah, Hemayet Bahini of Faridpur, Quddus Molla and Gafur Bahini of Barisal, Atsar Bahini of Mymensingh and Aftab Bahini of Mymensingh. A crack platoon consisting of daring youths operated most valiantly in Dhaka city as well. These bahinis were established as a local force based on their own strength taking part in a number of battles with the occupation army. Siraj Sikdar, leader of Sarbahara Party, also organised his force in Barisal. Another Bahini named as Mujib Bahini was organised in India with the active assistance of Major General Oban of the Indian army who was an expert in guerrilla warfare. Mujib Bahini was trained at Dehradun. Student League leaders Sheikh Faruk Haq Mondol, Tofael Ahmed, Abdur Razzak and Sirajul Alam Khan were organisers of this Bahini.

Mukti Bahini consisted of the regular and the irregular forces. The regulars were later called 'Teluktes Bahini' (regular force) and the irregulars were called 'Gana Bahini' (people's force). The regulars included East Bengal Regiment and EPR troops. The irregular forces, which after initial training joined different sectors, consisted of the students, peasants, workers and political activists.

Irregular forces were inducted inside Bangladesh territory to adopt guerilla warfare against the enemy. The regular forces were engaged in fighting in conventional way. The first conventional brigade named as 'Z' Force was created in July. Major Ziaur Rahman was appointed commander of this brigade and the brigade was named as 'Z' Force after the first letter of his name. This brigade consisted of 1, 3 and 8 East Bengal. Second regular brigade 'S' Force was created in October and consisted of 2 and 11 East Bengal. 'S' Force was named after the initial letter of the name of its commander Shafiullah. Similarly the 'K' Force created with 4, 9 and 10 East Bengal was commanded by Khaled Mosharraf.

Bangladesh Air Force, which was organised by Air Commodore A K Khondaker, was created in Bangladesh on 28 September. Squadron Leader Sultan Mahmud, Flight Lieutenant Badrul Alam, Captain Khaleq, Sattar, Shahabuddin, Mukit, Akram and Sharfuddin and 67 others initially joined the Bangladesh Air Force, which had only few Dakota, Anson type aircraft and Alouette helicopters.

Similarly, Bangladesh Navy was also established with the Naval troops deserted from the Pakistan Navy. On 9 November 1971, the first naval fleet 'Bangabandhu Naubahar' consisting of six small ships was inaugurated. The command structure of the Bangladesh Forces was fully organised with the regular brigades, sector troops and guerilla forces, the Bangladesh Air Force and the Navy.

The Mukti Bahini had fought many successful battles in putting up initial resistance. But within a short time, they were temporarily contained by the Pakistan army and were compelled to withdraw to the safe sanctuary in the Indian territory. The Mukti Bahini was, however, re-

equipped, reorganised and retrained. As a result, it got into fighting with fresh zeal after April-May 1971.

At the international level, the United States of America and the People's Republic of China considered the crisis as an internal affair of Pakistan. On the other hand, India, Soviet Union and her allies, and general masses in Japan, and Western countries stood solidly behind Bangladesh. In order to gain strategic advantage vis-a-vis Sino-US-Pakistan axis, Indo-Soviet Friendship Treaty was signed on 9 August 1971. It provided a new dimension to the War of Liberation.

Having realised that the Pakistan army could not be defeated by conventional warfare method, it was decided to create large guerilla forces all over the country. All Sector commanders were accordingly ordered to recruit, train and induct guerillas inside the country.

The joint command of the Mukti Bahini and the Indian army was underway from November 1971. Lieutenant General Jagjit Singh Aurora, Commander, Eastern Command of Indian Army, became the commander of the joint forces. The joint command of the Mukti Bahini and the Indian Army, however, started operation from the evening of 3 December, when the Pakistan Air Force bombed Amritsar, Sreenagar and the Kashmir valley. Immediately, the Indian armed forces were ordered to hit back the Pakistan army and thus the Indo-Pak war broke out. The Mukti Bahini and the Indian army continued advancing inside Bangladesh and the defeat and surrender of the Pakistan army became a matter of time. International efforts for a cease-fire failed due to Soviet veto in the United Nations Security Council.

The Indian troops and the freedom fighters of Sector 11 reached Tongi on 14 December, and Savar in the morning of 16 December. Major General Jamshed, commander 36 Division of the Pakistan Army received Major General Nagra at Mirpur Bridge near Dhaka City. The Mukti Bahini and the Indian forces entered Dhaka city at 10.10 a. m. Major General Jacob, the chief of staff of the Indian Eastern Command landed at Dhaka airport at 1 p.m with the draft instrument of surrender.

A fleet of helicopters landed on the tarmac of Dhaka airport at about 4 p.m with Lieutenant General Aurora and his staff. Group captain AK Khandaker, deputy chief of staff, Bangladesh forces, represented the Mukti Bahini. Lieutenant General AAK Niazi received Lieutenant General Aurora. The instrument of surrender was signed by Lieutenant Jagit Sing Aurora and Lieutenant General Niazi at the Ramna Racecourse (now Suhrawardy Udyan) at one minute past 5 p.m on 16 December 1971. [Rafiqul Islam]

Sectors of War of Liberation In the War of Liberation in 1971 the whole geographical area of the then East Pakistan was strategically divided into eleven sectors with a sector commander for each of them. For better efficiency in military operations each of the sectors were divided into a number of sub-sectors under a commander.



Sector 1 comprised of the districts of Chittagong and Chittagong Hill Tracts, and the eastern area of the Noakhali district on the banks of the river Muhuri in the Belonia Buffer. The headquarters of the sector was at Harina. The sector commander was Major Ziaur Rahman, later replaced by Major Rafiqul Islam. The five sub-sectors of this sector (and their commanders) were: Rishmukh (Captain Shamsul Islam); Sreenagar (Captain Matiur Rahman, later replaced by Captain Mahfuzur Rahman); Manughat (Captain Mahfuzur Rahman); Tabulchhari (Subedar Ali Hossain), and Dimagiri (a subedar).

A contingent of nearly ten thousand freedom fighters fought in this sector. They included about two thousand regular troops which comprised of 1400 EPR personnel, 200 policemen, army personnel and 100 men from the navy and air force and about eight thousand paramilitary troops. The guerrilla fighters of this sector were deputed to operate inside the country in groups.

Sector 2 comprised of the districts of Dhaka, Comilla, and Faridpur, and part of Noakhali district. This sector was raised from the nucleus of 4 East Bengal and the EPR troops of Comilla and Noakhali. The sector was located at Melaghar about 20 miles south of Agartala. The sector commander was Major Khaled Mosharraf, later replaced by Major ATM Haider. About the five thousand guerrilla fighters fought in this sector. Nearly six thousand of them were members of regular armed forces. The six sub-sectors of this sector (and their commanders) were: Tangra (Captain Akhaura and Kader (Mahbub, later replaced by Lieutenant Farooq, and Lieutenant Humayun Kabir); Mandalbhay (Captain Gaffar); Shaladadi (Abdus Saleq Chowdhury);



Sector 6 comprised of entire Rangpur district and Thakurgaon subdivision of Dinajpur district. The sector was formed mostly from EPR troops of Rangpur and Dinajpur. Wing Commander M Khdemul Bashar was the sector commander. The headquarters of the sector was at Burimara near Patgram, and this was the only sector which had its headquarters inside Bangladesh territory. The number of soldiers in this sector was 700, which rose to about eleven thousand in December consisting of 2000 regular force and 9000 Gana Bahini. The five sub-sectors of the sector (and their commanders) were: Bhajanpur (Captain Nazrul, later replaced by Squadron leader Sadruddin and Captain Shahriyar); Patgram (initially, some junior commissioned officers of the EPR, and later Captain Matiur Rahman); Sahebganj (Captain Nawazesh Uddin); Mogalhat (Captain Delwar); and Chilahati (Flight Lieutenant Iqbal). The northern areas of Rangpur district were held by the troops of this sector. The guerillas of the sector established 35 bases all over Rangpur and Dinajpur.

Sector 7 comprised of the districts of Rajshahi, Pabna, Bogra and southern part of Dinajpur district. This sector was organised from the EPR troops who had given the initial battles at Rajshahi under Captain Ghiyas and Captain Rashid. The sector commander was Major Nazmul Haq, later replaced by Subedar Major A Rab and Major Kazi Nuruzzaman. The headquarters of the sector was at Tarangapur near Balurghat. About 2500 regulars and 12500 guerillas fought in this sector. The eight sub-sectors of the sector (and their commanders were): Malan (initially some junior commanding officers, and later Captain Mohiuddin Jahangir); Tapan (Major Nazmul Haq, later replaced by some junior commanding officers of the EPR); Mehdiপুর

atinagar (Lieutenant Didarul Alam); Nirbhoypur (Captain Akbar, later replaced by Lieutenant Ahub); and Rajnagar (Captain Jafar Imam, later replaced by Captain Shahid, and Lieutenant amuzzaman). Due to the operations of this sector the Dhaka-Chittagong highway in between Comilla and Feni was denied to the Pakistanis throughout the nine months of war of liberation. One of the most successful operations of this sector was the defence of the Belonia Bulge. The entire Belonia Bulge was kept liberated by the combined forces of 1 and 2 sectors till 21 June. In this sector, a number of regular companies operated deep inside Bangladesh. These were the Bakhali Company under subedar Lutfar Rahman operating around Begumganj, the Chandpur Company under subedar Zahirul Alam Khan operating in Chandpur Matlab area, a large force under Captain Abdul Halim Chowdhury operating in Manikganj-Munshiganj area in Dhaka and a force under Captain Shawkat at Faridpur. The urban guerrillas carried out a number of successful operations in Dhaka city itself.

Sector 3 comprised of the area between Churaman Kathi (near Sreemangal) and Sylhet in the north and Singerbil of Brahmanbaria in the south. The sector commander was Major KM Rafiullah, later replaced by Major ANM Nuruzzaman. This sector was formed by some of the troops of 2 East Bengal and the EPR troops of Sylhet and Mymensingh. The sector headquarters was at Hejamara. Nineteen guerilla bases operated in this sector. By November 1971, the number of the guerilla fighters in the sector stood at nearly thirty thousand. They blew up a number of bridges on Comilla-Sylhet road which cut off Pakistan army's lines of communication. One of their most successful operations was the blowing up of a train by anti-tank mine near Shayestaganj. The ten sub-sectors of this sector (and their commanders) were: Grambari (Captain Aziz, later replaced by Captain Ejaz); Baghaibari (Captain Aziz, later replaced by Captain Ejaz); Hatkata (Captain Matiur Rahman); Simla (Captain Matin); Anchabati (Captain Nasim); Mantala (Captain MSA Bhuyan); Vijoyanagar (Captain MSA Bhuyan); Kalachhara (Lieutenant Majumdar); Kalkalia (Lieutenant Golam Helal Morshed); and Bamutia (Lieutenant Sayeed).

Sector 4 comprised of the area from Habiganj sub-division of Sylhet district on the north to Jangrahat thana on the south along the 100 mile long border with India. The sector was organised from amongst the EPR troops of Sylhet and student freedom fighters. The sector commander was Major Chittarajan Datta, later replaced by Captain A Rab. The headquarters of the sector was initially at Karimganj and later at Masimpur in Assam. The freedom fighters in this sector included about nine thousand guerilla fighters and about four thousand regular members of the armed forces. The six sub-sectors of this sector (and their commanders) were: Jalalpur (Masudur Rab Sadi); Barapunji (Captain A Rab); Amlasid (Lieutenant Zahir); Kukital (Flight Lieutenant Kader, later replaced by Captain Shariful Haq); Kailas Shahar (Lieutenant Vakiuzzaman); and Kamalpur (Captain Enam).

Sector 5 comprised of the area from Durgapur to Dauki (Tamabil) of Sylhet district and the entire area upto the eastern borders of the district. Sector commander was Major Mir Shawkat Ali. The headquarters of the sector was at Banshtala. The sector was composed of 800 regulars and 5000 guerillas. The sector covered most of the marshy areas of Sunamganj and Chhatak. The six sub-sectors of this sector (and their commanders) were: Muktapur (Subedar Nazir Hossain, freedom fighter Faruq was second in command); Dauki (Subedar Major BR Chowdhury); Shela (Captain Helal, who had two assistant commanders, Lieutenant Mahbubar Rahman and Lieutenant Abdur Rauf); Bholaganj (Lieutenant Taheruddin Akhunjil who had Lieutenant SM Khaled as assistant commander); Balat (Subedar Ghani, later replaced by Captain Salahuddin and Enamul Haq Chowdhury); and Barachhara (Captain Muslim Uddin). Troops of this sector blew up a number of bridges on Sylhet, Tamabil and Sylhet-Sunamganj roads. The most successful operation of this sector was the raid on Chhatak.

(Subedar Hiyas, later replaced by Captain Mahiuddin Jahangir); Hamzapur (Captain Idris); Anginalbad (a freedom fighter); Sheikhpara (Captain Rashid); Thokrabari (Subedar Muazzam); and Lalpola (Captain Gheyasuddin Chowdhury). The troops of this sector raided Maheskanda and Paratapur in June and the Mohanpur police station in August inflicting heavy casualties to the enemy. Captain Idris, commander of the Hamzapur sub-sector, ambushed several Pakistani columns and blew up a train near Parbatipur.

Sector 8 In April 1971, the operational area of the sector comprised the districts of Kusthia, Jessore, Khulna, Barisal, Faridpur and Patuakhali. At the end of May the sector was reconstituted and comprised the districts of Kusthia, Jessore and Khulna, Satkhira sub-division, and the northern part of Faridpur district. The sector commander was Major Abu Osman Chowdhury, later replaced by Major MA Manzur. The headquarters of the sector was at Kalyani. The sector had 3000 regulars and 25,000 guerillas. The regular forces held a number of liberated areas while the guerillas established several bases deep inside Bangladesh. In this sector a new tactics was followed. Regular troops were made to infiltrate 7 of 8 miles inside Bangladesh and take up all-round defence around a tactical feature, thereby inviting the Pakistan army to attack on them. By doing so, they inflicted heavy casualties to the attacking enemy. The seven sub-sectors of the sector (and their commanders) were: Boyra (Captain Khondakar Nazmul Huda); Hakimpur (Captain Shafiq Ullah); Bhomra (Captain Salahuddin, later replaced by Captain Shahabuddin); Lalbazar (Captain AR Azam Chowdhury); Banpur (Captain Mostafizur Rahman); Benapole (Captain Abdul Halim, later replaced by Captain Tawfiq-e-Elahi Chowdhury); and Shikarpur (Captain Tawfiq-e-Elahi Chowdhury, later replaced by Lieutenant Jahangir).

Sector 9 comprised of the districts of Barisal and Patuakhali, and southern part of Khulna and part of Faridpur district. The headquarters of the sector was established at Taki near Bashirhat. The sector commander was Major M Jalil, later replaced by Major MA Manzur and Major Joynal Abedin. The sector had about 20,000 freedom fighters. The three sub-sectors of the sector were: Taki, Hingalganj, and Shamshearnagar. In this sector even regular troops operated deep inside Bangladesh. Captain Shahjahan Omar led a large group of guerillas in Barisal. Captain Mehdi Ali Imam operated in Patuakhali from an established base. Lt Zia organised a huge force in Sundarbans. Captain Huda commanded the bulk of the regular troops near the border. He captured Uksha border outpost in June and kept it liberated throughout. The troops of this sector also raided Debhata Shyamnagar police stations. The water channels of Barisal-Patuakhali area mostly dominated by river patrolling. Prior to the final offensive in December this sector was merged with sector 8 and placed under the command of Major Manzoor.

Sector 10 This sector was constituted with the naval commandos. Eight Bangali officers of Pakistan Navy trained in France were the pioneers in forming this force. These officers were Ghazi Mohammad Rahmatullah (Chief Petty Officer), Syed Mosharraf Hossain (Petty Officer), Amin Ullah Sheikh (Petty Officer); Ahsan Ullah (ME-1), AW Chowdhury (RO-1), Badiul Alam (ME-1), AR Miah (EN-1), Abedur Rahman (Steward-1). These eight officers were given special training on the river Jamuna near Delhi under the auspices of the Indian Navy. They were joined by a number of sailors who had defected from Pakistan Navy. A group of 150 student volunteers were selected from various sectors who were known to be good swimmers and sent to this camp for training. They were trained in fragmenship and use of limpet mines for destruction of ships and vessels. On completion of training in the first week of August, four groups were sent to the ports of Chittagong, Narayanganj, Daudkandi and Mongla for

destruction and sabotaging of coastal vessels anchored there. On the day of independence of Pakistan, all the four groups struck simultaneously and destroyed a good number of ships and other vessels. The Chittagong group led by AW Choudhury destroyed seven ships including the Pakistani cargo ships MV Ohmazd and MV Al-Abbas which were carrying huge amounts of military cargo. Later in October and November, a few more similar operations were carried out successfully and a good number of sea-going and coastal vessels were sunk in the ports off over Bangladesh. The force was later commanded by Indian commander MN Sumanta.

Sector II comprised of the districts of Tangail and Mymensingh excluding Kishoreganj sub-division. Major M Abu Taher was the sector commander. After Major Taher was seriously wounded in a battle, he was replaced by Squadron Leader Hamidullah. The headquarters of the sector was at Mahendraganj. About twenty five thousand freedom fighters fought in this sector. The eight sub-sectors of the sector (and their commanders) were: Mainkarchar (Squadron Leader Hamidullah); Mahendraganj (Lieutenant Mizan); Purakhasia (Lieutenant Hamidullah); Dhalu (Lieutenant Taher Ahmed, later replaced by Lieutenant Kamal); Rangra (Major Rahman); Shivabari (some junior commanding officers of the EPR); Bagmara (some junior commanding officers of the EPR); and Maheshkhola (a member of the EPR). Guerilla activities were predominant in this sector, and regular forces held liberated areas near the border. Aftab held a huge chunk of liberated territory at Rahumani throughout the nine months of the war. In this sector, even women took up arms to fight the Pakistanis. Besides, Quader Siddiq, a renowned free lance freedom fighter from Tangail, organized 16,000 guerillas in his district and carried out a number of successful operations against the Pakistan army quite independently.



Geopolitics of Bangladesh's Liberation

Suruti S. Pattanaik*

Abstract

Bangladesh's tumultuous birth in 1971 is one of the most significant geopolitical events that shaped the history of the subcontinent. The genocide unleashed by the Pakistan Army on 25 March only strengthened the Bengalis' resolve for independence. Yet this birth was not easy, as the Muslim countries and Western countries mainly the United States opposed it and continued to treat it as an internal problem of Pakistan. Its indebtedness to Pakistan for facilitating rapprochement with China remained a major consideration. As ten million refugees fled to India, India signed a 25-year treaty with the Soviet Union that changed the Cold War geopolitics and shaped the constellation of power. Bangladesh continued to suffer birth pangs as Pakistan withheld recognition and China vetoed its entry to the United Nations. The issue of the prisoners of war, trial of Pakistani officers for

* Suruti S. Pattanaik, Ph.D., is a Research Fellow at the Manohar Parrikar Institute for Defence Studies and Analyses, New Delhi. Her email address is: surutispattanaik@gmail.com.

war crimes and the repatriation of stranded Bengalis in West Pakistan was lengthy and became complex, as Pakistan refused to negotiate with Bangladesh. Once referred to as an international basket case, the country has made rapid economic strides and has proved all the naysayers wrong. This article explores Bangladesh's journey especially in the context of the geopolitics of the 1971 Liberation War and its progress as a nation-state.

Bangladesh's emergence in 1971 was no less than an epoch-making event in international politics. The birth of Bangladesh in 1971 was the culmination of a long struggle that East Bengal started soon after the creation of Pakistan. The military operation of 25 March—'Operation Searchlight'—was the fallout of a failed negotiation between Sheikh Mujib and Yahya Khan's regime and also the military regime's decision not to transfer power to the Awami League. While Bengalis took up arms to seek liberation, traversing through the geopolitics of the Cold War era which was not ready to criticise the genocide in East Pakistan as it was perceived to be an internal matter of Pakistan, the struggle was equally challenging. News coming out of East Pakistan was sparse as the Government regulated the media. The Bengali struggle for freedom, received international sympathy and support mostly from civil society in different countries. In some cases there was a complete disconnect between the state's approach to Bangladesh's liberation and the effort of individual citizens of that country to support the refugees that had gathered in India. For example, the approach of the United States (US) was shaped by the Cold War politics. It was indebted to Pakistan as a major ally which facilitated Kissinger's visit to Beijing that paved the way for President Nixon's visit and facilitated the US-China rapprochement. Geopolitical compulsions forced it to close its eyes to the genocide perpetrated by Yahya Khan. As the US looked away, cultural activists and former Beatle George Harrison and Indian sitar maestro Pandit Ravi Shankar collaborated in a live concert at New York's Madison Square Garden along with other artistes.

collect funds to support the cause of Bangladesh and collected Rs. 243,418, that were donated to the UNICEF to be used for the refugees' welfare. Most importantly, this concert highlighted and sensitised the international community, especially the United States, to the developments in East Pakistan. Similarly, the US and China supported the Yahya regime and referred to the Liberation War as Pakistan's 'internal matter'; India supported the Liberation War while the Soviets provided necessary international support as part of the P-5 in the UN Security Council. A majority of the Muslim countries saw this as a ploy to divide a fellow Muslim country. This article focuses on the US and Soviet approaches and how they were shaped by the Cold War politics that determined their attitude to Bangladesh's liberation. It dwells on the politics of recognition and how Pakistan used the issue of recognition to get all the Prisoners of War (PoWs) repatriated including 173 officers for whom Mujib had insisted on a trial. The article also delves on Bangladesh's negotiations to get back Bengali officers and their families who had been stranded in Pakistan.

Cold War Geopolitics

The Cold War shaped both the United States' (US) and Soviet Union's approach to the unfolding crisis in East Pakistan. Pakistan had emerged as a Cold War partner for the US in 1954 when the two countries signed the Mutual Defense Assistance Agreement. India that strived to stay away from bloc politics and pursued non-alignment foreign policy was weighing its options to strengthen its defence especially after the India-China war of 1962. The US imposed an embargo on supply of limited weapons to India after the 1965 India-Pakistan war. By then the Soviets, who were competing for influence in South Asia, had emerged as important suppliers of weapons to India. While the Sino-Soviet rift brought the US and China closer, the Soviet Union was keen to forge a close relationship with India. It had proposed a treaty to India in 1970 and sought New Delhi's consent. New Delhi was not keen to sign the treaty at that point, as it was extremely cautious and did not want to enter into any agreement that would compromise its strategic autonomy.

However, the Pakistan government's White Paper of 6 August regarding developments in East Pakistan which was followed by Yahya Khan government's declaration of 7 August accusing the Awami League of secession and terming Bangabandhu Sheikh Mujibur Rahman a traitor, closed any possible chance of negotiated political settlement of 'East Pakistan crisis'. The Soviets also tried to nudge Pakistan to resolve the crisis, using the influence they enjoyed since the 1965 Tashkent Agreement in which the Soviets had brokered between India and Pakistan. Prior to the signing of Indo-Soviet Treaty, in July, the Soviets had stopped supplying arms to Pakistan.

The US closely followed the Soviet attitude and its position on the East Pakistan crisis. In spite of the fact that the nuclear-powered aircraft carrier, *USS Enterprise* sailed into the Bay of Bengal, which was a planned strategy of the United States, on 6 December, President Nixon conveyed to Soviet General Secretary Brezhnev,

...regret to say that what is happening now in South Asia, where you are supporting the Indian Government's open use of force against the independence and integrity of Pakistan, merely serves to aggravate an already grave situation. Beyond that, however, this course of developments runs counter to the recent encouraging trend in international relations to which the mutual endeavors of our two governments have been making such a major contribution. It is clear that the interests of all concerned states will be served if the territorial integrity of Pakistan were restored and military action were brought to an end. Urgent action is required and I believe that your great influence in New Delhi should serve these ends.⁷

Apart from the military support, Soviet veto was important for the Liberation War as it prevented alignment of pro Pakistan forces in the Security Council. The Soviet Union vetoed the Resolution brought by the US and other countries like Argentina, Belgium, Burundi, Italy, Japan, Nicaragua, Sierra

one, and Somalia in the Security Council. In the General Assembly, on 8 December, a majority of the countries voted in favour of a cease-fire and withdrawal of Indian and Pakistani troops from each other's territory. Pakistani Ambassador Agha Shahi, called it "an overwhelming, historic vote", and said "no attempt must be made to disrupt the national unity of Pakistan", and urged, "that efforts be intensified in order to bring about, speedily, conditions necessary for the voluntary return of the East Pakistan refugees to their homes." He further said this must be "must be consistent with the territorial integrity and national unity of Pakistan" ruling out any negotiation with "secessionist elements"⁸. This reflects Pakistan State's approach which ruled out any compromise with the Awami League, paving the way for the creation of a new state in the subcontinent.

The United States and East Pakistan Crisis

Throughout the political crisis in East Pakistan, the US was supportive of Yahya's effort and insisted that it was internal to Pakistan even after the flow of refugees to India touched around 7-8 million in August 1971. For example, when the military regime promised on 28 June that it is going to transfer power to the civilian regime, Kissinger supported it and was happy that Pakistan was showing sincerity to resolve the problem. During his visit to India he expressed his sympathies for the refugees but was far from pressuring the Pakistani regime on the humanitarian crisis or prioritising a political solution which India insisted on. Interestingly, encouraged by US inaction, in August the military regime announced Mujib's trial for treason, prompting India to appeal to the world leaders to use their influence on the 'Yahya's regime'.

According to P.N. Dhar, in spite of India suggesting to the US to get in touch with the Mujibnagar government directly, the US was reluctant but clandestinely in touch with Khondokar Mushtaq Ahmad. This contact, according to Dhar, was to help Yahya to disrupt the Mujibnagar government's leadership.⁹ Moreover, Pakistan was moving on a path to delegitimise the Awami League (AL) and there was a fear that re-election might

be held by declaring seats of those who left for India as vacant or to co-opt the AL leaders by declaring general amnesties. Such attempts failed; the Pakistan government published a White Paper accusing the Awami League for plotting with India to split Pakistan and was making a case to justify a military crackdown. Furthermore, the military government of Yahya Khan gave a statement that it is going to hold a secret military trial of Sheikh Mujib.

During the war, China worked in accordance with the US advice to protect the interests of Pakistan. The US had made it clear to India that in case China intervened in one way or the other in the Bangladesh Liberation War, which was supported by India, New Delhi should not rely on the US. China's role was factored into India's war planning.¹⁰ The Indo-Soviet Treaty was precisely aimed at fighting this coalition against India that could have threatened India's security while it faced the problem of a massive influx of refugees.

On 6 November 1971, the US Secretary of State, William Rogers, also conveyed to India that "war would be tragic for India... If we cannot force Yahya Khan to deal with Mujibur Rahman, whom he regards a traitor."¹¹ The US insisted that India withdraw its troops but could not guarantee whether it would lead to the normalisation of process in East Pakistan. Rather, it was conveyed to India that as long as the *Mukti Bahini* was active in East Pakistan with India's support, Pakistan could not reduce military action.¹² Rather than pressuring Yahya to announce negotiations with the Mujibnagar government or free Mujib, which India insisted on, President Nixon was interested in India-Pakistan disengagement on the border, and wanted India not to go for any military action against Pakistan. The US decided to cut off military aid to India, which was conveyed to the Indian Ambassador, in the following statement:

US will continue its effort to contribute to easing of tensions and is taking this action as result of its view that military conflict can only stand in way of political solution. American people will not understand

provision of new military supplies in the light of the present military situation.¹³

The US also analysed the situation in geopolitical context. It admitted that the Soviets were more active in "trying to settle disputes in the subcontinent" as they did not want the situation to favour China.¹⁴

The United States tried to project itself as neutral during the war even though Nixon asked Kissinger for a 'tilt' towards Pakistan discussing cutting-off of military aid to India while contemplating a US \$22 million economic aid for Pakistan. However, Kissinger argued that "It's hard to tilt toward Pakistan, as the President wishes, if every time we take some action in relation to India we have to do the same thing for Pakistan."¹⁵ Pakistan also invoked the terms of an agreement signed on 05 March 1959 where military help would be extended by the US as war appeared inevitable. This was also assured by President Kennedy in 1962.¹⁶

The Nixon administration was keen that India got the blame for the war, as Kissinger informed Nixon that the major US newspapers would put a headline that "India is largely to blame for the outbreak of hostilities and it lists all the things the Indians have rejected."¹⁷ The US President felt happy about it. On 6 December, when the war was in full swing, the US was discussing the plight of the Urdu-speaking minority in East Pakistan in the United Nations and calling upon all parties to take steps to prevent a massacre and show 'certain coolness to the Indians' and should make known what US did "to foster a discussion between Bangladesh and Islamabad."¹⁸ The US justified its stand of supporting Pakistan and argued that Yahya's military action is just a reaction to India's support to the *Mukti Bahini*. Richard Nixon also told Henry Kissinger that the blame for the war should be put on India and throughout the war he wanted to see that Pakistan gets weapons and whether those could be supplied via Iran and Jordan.¹⁹ To escape media attention on the continuing US military supplies to Pakistan, F-5 aircraft meant for Libya were supplied to Pakistan via Iran.²⁰

The effort of the US, the then Soviet Union and China was to liberate West Pakistan in 1971. There was pressure on India to accept a ceasefire and return territory in West Pakistan that was occupied by India during the war. As Kissinger famously said, "Pakistan has been saved." US support to Pakistan during 1971 in spite of the American people supporting Bangladesh's liberation is encapsulated in Kissinger's book, *The White House Years*, where he writes, President Nixon and his staff were profoundly grateful for Pakistan's role as the channel for negotiations. It was a service for which Pakistan's leaders, to their credit and honour, never sought any reciprocity or special consideration."²¹

While Bangladesh was liberated on 16 December 1971, the politics of recognition of Bangladesh as a sovereign state continued till 1974. Pakistan's recognition was particularly significant as China vetoed Bangladesh's admission to the UN. The issue of recognition got enmeshed with the repatriation of PoWs and Bangladesh's decision to try Pakistani officers for war crimes. This also placed the repatriation of Bengali prisoners stationed in West Pakistan during the war in a difficult position. There was Soviet pressure on India to repatriate the PoWs and Bangladesh was party to this decision and Pakistan refused to negotiate with Dhaka.

Politics of Recognition

After liberation, the recognition of Bangladesh involved intense and complex negotiations with Pakistan over several issues that were thrown up by the war, including division of assets and repatriation of Biharis. Even today, these issues are part of bilateral politics and find mention in the context of 1971.

The question of the ideology of the two-nation theory on which Pakistan was created was increasingly questioned within Pakistan, on whether religion can remain a glue that can bind the diverse ethnicity together. However, Pakistan parried the issue by blaming India for the separation of East Pakistan and

creation of new nation and refused to recognise Bangladesh. In the 1973 constitution, in the section on the provinces of Pakistan, it laid down a provision that reads, that the constitution "shall be appropriately amended so as to enable the people of East Pakistan, as and when foreign aggression in that province and its effect are eliminated, to be represented in the affairs of the federation."²² Not surprisingly, Bhutto made a reference to this provision while speaking on the motion to pass the constitution bill on 10 April 1973. He said:

[W]ith the return of prisoners of war, and after a small decent period, I believe the external factors will be relatively under control and then we can meet because I would always want to meet you and to continue our dialogue and our discussions because I believe that this is the best way, this is the only way. We cannot shoot our way through because we have seen that when you shoot your way through, you reach the grave, and there is no flower left.²³

The 1973 constitution interestingly declared Islam as the state religion. Bhutto claimed that the 1973 constitution has more Islamic provisions compared to the past constitutions of Pakistan and much more than the constitutions of Muslim countries including monarchist Muslim countries,²⁴ just to prove that the two-nation theory is intact and has not been delegitimised by the emergence of Bangladesh.

India also wanted to withdraw its troops from Bangladesh 'to avoid hurting Bengali pride' and also to reassure its neighbours about India's objectives not to station its troops.²⁵ This was also important for the recognition of Bangladesh as an independent country.

The Politics of Recognition of Bangladesh

The question of recognising Bangladesh as an independent country brought into focus the role of China, which vetoed Bangladesh's entry to the United Nations. On 25 August, when Bangladesh's admission to the UN was considered, "China charged that Bangladesh stood in violation of two United

Nations resolutions—one passed in the General Assembly and the other in the Security Council...consideration of the Bangladesh application be delayed until all prisoners of war on the subcontinent were repatriated and until all foreign soldiers were removed from Bangladesh."²⁶ China itself had joined the UN ten months ago. China portrayed the 1971 war as India-Pakistan war and insisted that its outcome was not acceptable unless there was reconciliation between Pakistan and Bangladesh, which according to China, would demonstrate that Bangladesh "is a truly independent state."²⁷

In November 1972, the UN General Assembly passed a Resolution seeking the release of PoWs from India. However, India insisted that the PoWs had surrendered to the joint India-Bangladesh forces and it could not release them without the concurrence of Bangladesh. Arguing in the United Nations, Raja Tridev Roy representing Pakistan, said, "The position that the release and repatriation of our prisoners of war requires the agreement of 'Bangladesh' is not supported by the Geneva Conventions.... Unless the Assembly addresses itself to the unresolved problems organically inseparable from admission, its consideration of this question cannot advance the possibility of the admission of 'Bangladesh' to the United Nations."²⁸ He further said,

The recognition of "Bangladesh" is different for Pakistan than for other States. It bears upon an important principle. We cannot ignore the fact that the territory which now proclaims itself as "Bangladesh" was an integral part of Pakistan, and that it was sundered from Pakistan by the use of armed force. The events of last year have already eroded the principle of the territorial integrity of States, enshrined in the Charter. There is no doubt a new reality in the subcontinent. But if this precedent is not to impend the security and integrity of all multinational or multilingual States, it is important that its legitimacy be consecrated, not through Pakistan's coerced recognition of its existence, but through a freely negotiated and just settlement of the issues which interpose serious obstacles.

to the recognition of "Bangladesh" and its admission to the United Nations.²⁹

Pakistan continued with this stand with the help of China, and also wanted the withdrawal of Indian troops from Bangladesh. The return of the PoWs were conditional on Pakistan's recognition of Bangladesh. Bangladesh had made it clear it would not negotiate except on the basis of sovereign equality. Pakistan also dragged the issue of recognition and made all efforts to stall any trial of its officers for war crimes. As Gary J. Bass says, "Pakistan, however, insisted that the price of its recognition—a precedent-setting act of legitimation that would allow other states to follow—was impunity for war criminals. Bangladesh had little choice but to acquiesce."³⁰ Without Pakistan's recognition, countries like Britain were also not willing to admit Bangladesh to the Commonwealth. Bhutto in his public posture nursed a desire, being fully aware of the futility of this wish, that both the countries can become a confederation. He saw the creation of Bangladesh as an Indian conspiracy. While Pakistan attributed the 'war crime trial' as contingent to regional peace, India also was non-committal as a signatory of the Geneva Convention and gave preference to peace in the region which it thought was more important than retribution. At the same time, it conveyed firmly that its decision was contingent on Bangladesh's agreement.

Pakistan invoked the issue of national sovereignty in the International Court of Justice and argued that it acted against "internal revolt in their own country" and that "Pakistan had not committed genocide."³¹ Bangladesh made a major concession, as a *fait accompli*, to Pakistan's insistence on the return of PoWs without formal political recognition of Bangladesh as an independent country. Bangladesh concentrated on solving the humanitarian problems that required repatriation of Bengalis held in Pakistan camps. Bangladesh was equally keen for the repatriation of stranded Bengalis in Pakistan. Pakistan was against the repatriation of Biharis, or stranded Pakistanis as Bangladesh refers to them and was also opposed to the trial of 195 Pakistani officers on war crimes.³² Pakistan also said that it

would try 203 Bengali officers for espionage and such other charges, if Bangladesh went ahead with the war crime trials. It was resolved through US intervention which also exerted pressure on Pakistan against this trial.³³ India consulted Bangladesh regularly on these issues since Bangladesh had made it clear that it would participate in any negotiation as a sovereign equal to the Pakistani state. However, without recognition Bangladesh could not participate as an equal in the negotiation. Dhaka also rejected Pakistan's proposal to meet informally to resolve the issue. In August 1973, an agreement was reached between India and Pakistan which said that "the Special Representative of the Prime Minister of India, having consulted the Government of Bangladesh has also conveyed the concurrence of Bangladesh Government in this Agreement."³⁴ The clause with regard to repatriation reads:

Without prejudice to the respective positions of Bangladesh and Pakistan on the question of non-Bangalees, who are stated to have "opted for repatriation to Pakistan", the Government of Pakistan guided by considerations of humanity, agrees, initially, to receive a substantial number of such non-Bangalees from Bangladesh. It is further agreed that the Prime Ministers of Bangladesh and Pakistan or their designated representatives will thereafter meet to decide what additional number of persons, who may wish to migrate to Pakistan, may be permitted to do so. Bangladesh has made it clear that it will participate in such a meeting only on the basis of sovereign equality.³⁵

Pakistan accorded recognition to Bangladesh on 22 February 1974, paving the way for a tripartite agreement between India, Bangladesh and Pakistan for the return of the 195 PoWs and other civilians held by India with simultaneous transfer of Bengalis held in Pakistan. India and Pakistan in April 1974 agreed that, "If a detainee claims to be the national of the country in which he is detained, his case shall be investigated and decided by mutual agreement between the two governments."³⁶ Bangladesh insisted on repatriation of non

Bengalis, especially employees in the central government of Pakistan and their families, 25,000 hardship cases and a 'minimum of some 116,000 persons' in the first phase and the fate of 200,000 persons, "who had declared their allegiance to Pakistan" in the survey conducted by the International Red Cross hung in balance as "Pakistan continued to temporise."³⁷ Some scholars also argue that peace with Pakistan and Kashmir were priority issues for India. But at the same time, the anti-India campaign by Pakistan, accusing India of violating the Geneva Convention and approaching the International Court of Justice, brought pressure on India which could not defer the repatriation. India's attempt to defend the right of Bangladesh to persecute war criminals did not bear any result as Pakistan put the recognition of Bangladesh on hold. Pakistan bargained hard, citing its domestic compulsions which were rejected by Bangladesh.

The question of division of assets between Bangladesh and Pakistan as well as the repatriation of Biharis remain contested topics between the two countries even now. Pakistan accepted some Urdu-speaking people from Bangladesh initially after the tripartite agreement was concluded and some of the Biharis were repatriated in the 1990s with the financial assistance of Saudi Arabia and other Muslim countries. However, over a period of time, this issue had been shelved due to Pakistan's reluctance. Bangladesh's judiciary finally granted citizenship to the children of the 'stranded' Urdu speakers who were born after the liberation, to enable them to settle down as citizens of Bangladesh.

The issue of recognition from Pakistan and other Muslim countries posed political problems. Several questions were raised by Mujib's detractors regarding the issue of secularism and speculation regarding why the Muslim world is delaying the recognition. As a *quid pro quo* for recognition, Mujib joined the second Organisation of Islamic Conference (OIC) Summit in Lahore. However, except for Saudi Arabia, which had certain reservations on Bangladesh's constitution being secular, all other Muslim countries accorded recognition to Bangladesh.

Bengalis, especially employees in the central government of Pakistan and their families, 25,000 hardship cases and a "minimum of some 116,000 persons" in the first phase and the fate of 200,000 persons, "who had declared their allegiance to Pakistan" in the survey conducted by the International Red Cross hung in balance as "Pakistan continued to temporise."³⁷ Some scholars also argue that peace with Pakistan and Kashmir were priority issues for India. But at the same time, the anti-India campaign by Pakistan, accusing India of violating the Geneva Convention and approaching the International Court of Justice, brought pressure on India which could not defer the repatriation. India's attempt to defend the right of Bangladesh to persecute war criminals did not bear any result as Pakistan put the recognition of Bangladesh on hold. Pakistan bargained hard, citing its domestic compulsions which were rejected by Bangladesh.

The question of division of assets between Bangladesh and Pakistan as well as the repatriation of Biharis remain contested topics between the two countries even now. Pakistan accepted some Urdu-speaking people from Bangladesh initially after the tripartite agreement was concluded and some of the Biharis were repatriated in the 1990s with the financial assistance of Saudi Arabia and other Muslim countries. However, over a period of time, this issue had been shelved due to Pakistan's reluctance. Bangladesh's judiciary finally granted citizenship to the children of the 'stranded' Urdu speakers who were born after the liberation, to enable them to settle down as citizens of Bangladesh.

The issue of recognition from Pakistan and other Muslim countries posed political problems. Several questions were raised by Mujib's detractors regarding the issue of secularism and speculation regarding why the Muslim world is delaying the recognition. As a *quid pro quo* for recognition, Mujib joined the second Organisation of Islamic Conference (OIC) Summit in Lahore. However, except for Saudi Arabia, which had certain reservations on Bangladesh's constitution being secular, all other Muslim countries accorded recognition to Bangladesh

after Pakistan recognised it. The Saudi recognition came after Mujib's assassination, though his government was already in talks with Saudis to recognise Bangladesh.³⁸

Pakistan not only looked towards the oil-rich countries of West Asia to emphasise its Islamic identity, it felt elated after the assassination of Sheikh Mujibur Rahman and the introduction of 5th Amendment to the Bangladesh constitution³⁹ introduced by the military ruler General Ziaur Rahman, who succeeded Sheikh Mujibur Rahman. Islamic features were introduced into the Bangladesh constitution through this amendment much as a part of a legitimisation exercise of the military government. There was no popular demand to introduce Islamic features even though the supporters of erstwhile Pakistan regime in Bangladesh continued their campaign against secularism. Later, General H.M. Ershad introduced the 8th Amendment, which declared Islam as the state religion.⁴⁰ The Supreme Court of Bangladesh held both the amendments brought by the military rulers as unconstitutional in 2011. However, the country, through the 15th Amendment to the constitution, has managed to restore many of the original features of the 1972 constitution.

Bangladesh: Overcoming the Geopolitical Challenges

The independence of Bangladesh in 1971 and its journey as an independent nation-state has been unique. In Bangladesh all the sects of Islam continue to enjoy equality and therefore unlike Pakistan, one does not see any sectarian violence. As many Bangladeshis emphasise, the emergence of Bangladesh was inherent in the creation of Pakistan⁴¹ and the Bengalis only realised the separateness and their unique identity after it became part of Pakistan.⁴²

Bangladesh, which was referred to as an international basket case by U. Alexis Johnson from the State Department and endorsed by Henry Kissinger who said "not our basket case."⁴³ However, Bangladesh has proved all the doomsday predictions wrong. Not only has Bangladesh restructured its post-war

- ¹⁸ Minutes of Washington Special Actions Group Meeting / 1 / the meeting was held in the White House Situation Room on 06 December 1971, a briefer record of the meeting, prepared by James Noyes (DASH/1307), in the Washington National Records Center, OSD Files, FRG 100 70 0007, Box 74, Pakistan 381 (Dec) 1971, <https://2001-2009.state.gov/r/pa/ho/frus/nixon/xi/45607.htm>, accessed on 05 November 2022.
- ¹⁹ Telephonic conversation between Nixon and Kissinger between 03-15 December, 19 January 1972, pp. 2-3, <https://nsarchive2.gwu.edu/NSAEBB/NSAEBB79/BBB/00.pdf>, accessed on 19 December 2021.
- ²⁰ Department of State, "F5 Aircraft to Pakistan", 29 December 1971, <https://nsarchive2.gwu.edu/NSAEBB/NSAEBB79/BBB/04.pdf>, accessed on 07 November 2021.
- ²¹ Henry Kissinger, "The White House Years", Delhi: Vikas Publishing House, 1979, p. 849.
- ²² G. W. Choudhury, "New Pakistan's Constitution, 1973", *Middle East Journal*, Winter, 1974, Vol. 28, No. 1, p. 18.
- ²³ National Assembly of Pakistan, Bhutto's speech in the National Assembly of Pakistan, 10 April 1973, p. 2471.
- ²⁴ Bhutto's speech in the National Assembly of Pakistan, 10 April 1973, p. 2468.
- ²⁵ Dhar, *Indira Gandhi*, p. 185.
- ²⁶ Robert Alden, "China's First U. N. Veto Bars Bangladesh", *The New York Times*, 26 August 1972, <https://www.nytimes.com/1972/08/26/archives/chinas-first-un-veto-bars-bangladesh-soviet-union-and-india-are.html#:~:text=25%E2%80%94After%20a%20bitter%20attack,membership%20in%20the%20United%20Nations>, accessed on 05 November 2021.
- ²⁷ Murad Rind, "China and Bangladesh's U.N. Entry", *Pakistan Forum*, Vol. 1, No. 4, January 1973, Middle East Research and Information Project, <https://www.jstor.org/stable/pdf/2568946.pdf?refreqid=excelsior%1A441c0a81b67fb60815098322301cf1c9>, accessed on 07 December 2021.
- ²⁸ UN General Assembly, Twenty-Seventh Session, 2059th meeting, 9 October 1972, p. 15 (Official Records), <http://undocs.org/en/A/17/2000>, accessed on 05 November 2021.
- ²⁹ UN General Assembly, Twenty-Seventh Session, 2059th meeting, 9 October 1972 (Official Records), p. 14, <http://undocs.org/en/A/17/2000>.
- ³⁰ Gary J. Bass, "Bargaining Away Justice: India, Pakistan, and the International Politics of Impunity for the Bangladesh Genocide", *International Security*, Vol 41, No. 2, Fall 2016, p. 149.
- ³¹ *Ibid.*, p. 173.

³² Dhar, no. 6, p. 211.

³³ Bass, "Bargaining Away Justice", p. 177.

³⁴ Ministry of External Affairs, "Agreement between the Government of India and the Government of the Islamic Republic of Pakistan regarding Repatriation of Persons", 28 August 1973, https://www.mea.gov.in/bilateral-documents.htm?dtl/54661/Agreement_on_Repatriation_of_Persons accessed on 15 November 2021.

³⁵ Ministry of External Affairs, Agreement between the Government of India and the Government of the Islamic Republic of Pakistan.

³⁶ Ministry of External Affairs, "Agreement on Repatriation of Persons", 09 April 1974, https://www.mea.gov.in/bilateral-documents.htm?dtl/6140/Agreement_on_repatriation_of_persons accessed on 15 November 2021.

³⁷ Kamal Hossain was involved in the negotiation as the foreign minister of Bangladesh. See Kamal Hossain, *Bangladesh Quest for Freedom and Justice*, Dhaka: UPL, 2013, p. 208.

³⁸ King Faisal had reservations on Bangladesh's constitution. Mujibur Rahman explained Bangladesh's constitution that embodied the aspiration of Bengalis, no communal society and their bitter experience and how they were butchered by their religious brother was emphasised. Later the Foreign Minister Kamal Hossain also met King Faisal and his successor. Kamal Hossain writes that recognition would have been accorded but tragic death of Mujibur Rahman changed Bangladesh's political course. See *Ibid.*, pp. 191-196.

³⁹ The 5th Amendment to the constitution legalised all the changes made by the military regime, notably the deletion of secularism and ban on politics of religion. These features in the constitution were drawn from the ideals of liberation war and is generally referred as foundational principles of Bangladesh constitution.

⁴⁰ For details see Shah Alam, "The State-Religion Amendment to the Constitution of Bangladesh: A Critique", *Verfassung und Recht in Übersee / Law and Politics in Africa, Asia and Latin America*, Vol. 24, No. 2 (2 Quartal 1991), pp. 209-225, <https://www.pstor.org/stable/pdf/43110030.pdf?refreqid=excelsior%3Ac4cf1d39ac92d9acc61d146d578c7de>, accessed on 07 November 2021.

⁴¹ Harun ur Rashid, *The Foreshadowing of Bangladesh: Bengal Muslim League and Muslim Politics, 1906-1947*, Dhaka: UPL, 2003.

⁴² Talukdar M. Nuruzzaman, *Bangladesh Revolution and its Aftermath*, Dhaka: UPL, 2003 (Second Edition), p. 224.

⁴³ Minutes of Washington Special Actions Group Meeting, 06 December 1971, accessed on 29 April 2022.

⁴⁴ See Hossain, p. 127.

⁴⁵ Rounaq Jahan, "Bangladesh in 1972: Nation Building in a New State," *Asian Survey*, Vol. 13, No. 2, 1973, p. 200.

⁴⁶ Ibid., p. 208.

⁴⁷ Asian Development Bank, "Bangladesh", <https://www.adb.org/countries/bangladesh/economy>, accessed on 07 November 2021.

⁴⁸ World Bank, "Pakistan", <https://www.worldbank.org/en/country/pakistan/overview>, accessed on 07 November 2021.

⁴⁹ Asian Development Bank, "Pakistan", <https://www.adb.org/countries/pakistan/economy>, accessed on 07 November 2021.

⁵⁰ World Bank, "Bangladesh", <https://www.worldbank.org/en/country/bangladesh/overview>, accessed on 07 November 2021.

⁵¹ World Bank Database, <https://data.worldbank.org/indicator/BN.CAB.XOKA.GD.ZS?locations=BD>, accessed on 07 November 2021.

⁵² Rehman Sobhan, *Bangladesh: Problem of Governance*, Dhaka: UPL, 1993, p. 87.